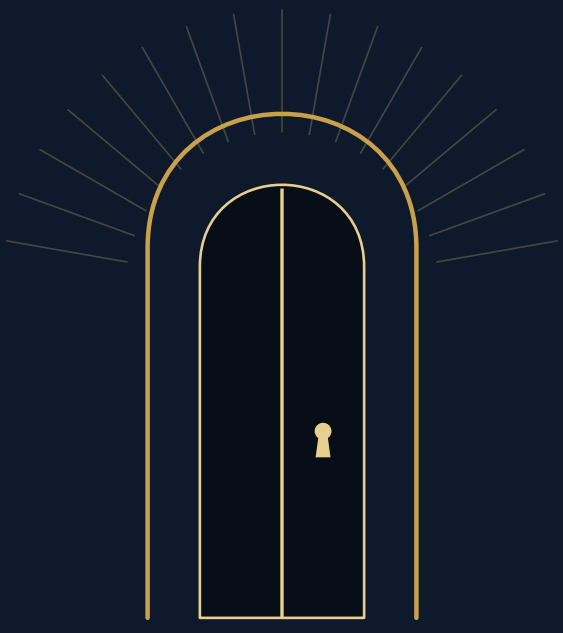


Minding the Gap

RESTORED EDITION



Minding the Gap

Cratylan Urbanism, the Dismembered Hermes, and the Prosopopoeic Ethics of the Interstice in Neil Gaiman's Neverwhere

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Minding the Gap: Cratylan Urbanism, the Dismembered Hermes, and the Prosopopoeic Ethics of the Interstice in Neil Gaiman's Neverwhere.

Restored edition, version 6, October 2026.

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Trim 7 × 10 in.

This ae night, this ae night,
Every night and all,
Fire and fleet and candle-light,
And Christ receive thy soul.

LYKE WAKE DIRGE, TRADITIONAL

I should be afraid of the innumerable night of fir trees.

G. K. CHESTERTON, THE NAPOLEON OF NOTTING HILL

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that Neil Gaiman's *Neverwhere* (BBC teleplay and novel, 1996) is not primarily a portal fantasy about a concealed city, nor a social allegory of homelessness, nor a Campbellian quest romance, though it is legibly all three, but a philosophical fable about the economy of the sign: about what becomes of names, values, and persons when the conventions that circulate them have been worn smooth by use. Its governing claim is that London Below constitutes the *Cratylan remainder* of a *Hermogenean metropolis*. Borrowing the terms of Plato's *Cratylus*, in which Hermogenes defends the conventional arbitrariness of names and Cratylus their natural correctness, the study shows that London Above is a regime of effaced reference, in which toponyms have become labels, money has become abstraction, and persons have become fungible faces in a crowd, while London Below is the sediment of motivated meaning that accumulates in the interstices of that regime: a city in which Earl's Court is an earl's court, Knightsbridge a bridge of night, and those who have fallen through the cracks have fallen, literally, through cracks.

The novel's master trope, literalization, is theorized here as *prosopopoeic re-motivation*: the restoration of face to what usage has defaced, whether toponyms, the dispossessed, or gods whose names now survive chiefly on station signage and Monopoly squares. Under this description, the novel's apparently heterogeneous materials (its puns, thresholds, itinerant market, fallen angel, and ordeal) cohere as functions of a single figure: Hermes, the threshold-god whose herms stood at Athenian doorways and whose faces were struck off in 415 BCE. Drawing on the scene in Aristophanes' *Plutus* in which an unemployed Hermes offers his services as god of the hinge, the market, the trick, the guide, and the contest, the dissertation identifies a structure it names *the dismembered Hermes*: the distribution of those five offices among Door, the Floating Market, the Marquis de Carabas, the novel's guides, and Hunter, which together generate a *hermetic polity* sustained by passage rather than by place.

The novel's ethics are located in an imperative of attention, condensed in the London Underground's own injunction to mind the gap and elaborated through Simone Weil, Iris Murdoch, and Emmanuel Levinas, whose objects are precisely those beings and meanings that fall into the interstices of conventional order. This ethics is opposed, within the novel, to the Angel Islington's apocalyptic programme of total restoration. Door's climactic act, which opens the door to heaven onto an unreachable elsewhere, is read as the text's decisive philosophical gesture: an opening that forecloses closure, a messianicity without messianism that preserves the gap rather than abolishing it.

The argument proceeds through source study (Blake, De Quincey, Mayhew, Dickens, Chesterton, Carroll, Barrie, Wells), philosophical exegesis (Plato, Nietzsche, Simmel, Benjamin, de Certeau, Rancière, Derrida), and comparative reading (Kafka, Calvino, Ellison, Miéville). It also maps the limits of the novel's achievement: a personalist ethics that grants its hero exit and leaves voice, the politics its villain murdered, to its heroine, a Cratylan determinism that distributes nominal freedom unequally along gendered lines, and a fabulous rendering of dispossession that courts what Ruskin called the lower picturesque. The dissertation concludes by proposing a *Cratylan rhetoric of fantasy*, supplementary to Farah Mendlesohn's portal, immersive, intrusive, and liminal modes, in which the fantastic is produced by the re-motivation of the arbitrary sign, so that the world grows marvellous precisely in proportion as it grows literal.

KEYWORDS Neil Gaiman; *Neverwhere*; urban fantasy; London literature; Plato's *Cratylus*; Cratylism; arbitrariness of the sign; relative motivation; toponymy; literalization; paronomasia; prosopopoeia; the uncanny; Hermes; trickster; threshold; liminality; rites of passage; hermetic polity; heterotopia; Floating Market; gift economy; debt; usury; economy of waste; distribution of the sensible; invisibility; homelessness; ethics of attention; Simone Weil; Emmanuel Levinas; Walter Benjamin; weak messianism; messianicity without messianism; angelology; Atlantis; katabasis; initiation; Plato's Cave; portal fantasy; rhetorics of fantasy; wainscot societies; nominative determinism; gender and narrative; lower picturesque; mind the gap.

Prefatory Note

Neverwhere has no single text, and the condition is apt to its subject. The work originated in a commission from Lenny Henry's production company, Crucial Films, and was first realized as a six-part serial broadcast on BBC Two in September 1996; the novel, composed alongside and in tension with the teleplay, appeared from BBC Books in the same year. The first American edition (Avon, 1997) was revised to soften metropolitan particulars thought opaque to non-British readers. A later "Author's Preferred Text" restored material excised from both earlier editions and was subsequently issued with the coda "How the Marquis Got His Coat Back," first published in the anthology *Rogues* (2014). The work has further afterlives in a comics adaptation by Mike Carey and Glenn Fabry (Vertigo, 2005–2006) and a BBC Radio 4 dramatization directed by Dirk Maggs (2013). *Neverwhere* is thus itself a palimpsest, a stratified object whose layers neither fully coincide nor fully replace one another, and this study treats its textual instability as a formal correlate of the city it describes, in which every stratum persists beneath its successor.

Because pagination and even chapter divisions vary across these states of the text, references to the novel are made by narrative episode (the Floating Market at Harrods, the crossing of the Night's Bridge, the Ordeal of the Key, the Labyrinth) rather than by page. Where precision helps, chapter numbers are added in the form "novel, ch. 12"; they refer to the text against which this study's account of the plot has been checked, a prologue and twenty chapters without the coda, whose American usages, such as "sidewalk" and "apartment," mark it as the US-derived state of the text. Where a reading depends on a detail specific to one state of the text, the dependence is noted. Classical texts are cited by their standard reference systems (Stephanus pagination for Plato, line numbers for Aristophanes, Virgil, Ovid, and Milton, book and chapter for Thucydides), and scripture by the Authorized Version. Since the novel and most modern critical sources remain in copyright, this study paraphrases them and reserves direct quotation for public-domain materials, among them Plato, Ovid, Virgil, Dante, Milton, Blake, Keats, Carroll, Barrie, Wells, Chesterton, the Lyke Wake Dirge, and the Authorized Version, whose exact wording is frequently the point.

The method is comparative, philosophical, and intertextual, and it distinguishes three orders of relation that criticism of Gaiman routinely conflates. *Genealogy* designates documented sources: authors Gaiman has named, honored in dedications, or embodied in his fiction, such as G. K. Chesterton, C. S. Lewis, Lewis Carroll, and Hope Mirrlees. *Filiation* designates probable sources whose presence is inferable from the text without external testimony, such as Henry Mayhew, whose surname the protagonist bears, or H. G. Wells, whose "The Door in the Wall"

the novel's ending all but rewrites. *Constellation*, a term borrowed from Walter Benjamin and Theodor Adorno, designates theoretical comparanda that Gaiman need never have read but whose juxtaposition with the novel makes visible a structure neither discloses alone; it is chiefly in this third order that the dissertation's original argument is conducted.

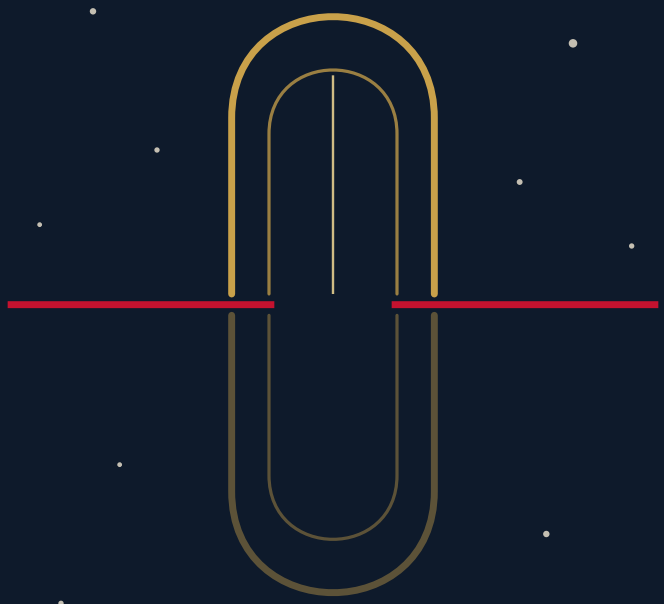
The constellational method carries a known risk, which Umberto Eco named *hermetic semiosis*: the drift by which everything comes to signify everything else. A study whose subject is a city in which names mean too much is especially exposed to that drift. The dissertation therefore practises what it calls *disciplined Cratylism*, a reading that takes the novel's motivated names seriously while holding every proposed correspondence answerable to the text's own structure. It also takes its final warrant from the *Cratylus* itself, whose Socrates concludes (439a–b) that knowledge of things should finally be sought from the things themselves rather than from their names.

A further matter of method concerns the author. From July 2024, a number of women made allegations of sexual assault, abuse, and coercion against Gaiman: first in Tortoise Media's investigative podcast *Master: The Allegations against Neil Gaiman*, in which two women spoke initially and others in later episodes (*Locus*, August 2024), and then in Lila Shapiro's *New York* magazine cover story of January 2025, "There Is No Safe Word," which gave the accounts of eight women. Gaiman has denied all of the allegations; after the magazine article he stated that he had never engaged in non-consensual sexual activity with anyone. In February 2025 one of the women, Scarlett Pavlovich, sued Gaiman and his then wife, Amanda Palmer, in federal court in Wisconsin, and Palmer alone in New York and Massachusetts. The New York suit was withdrawn in June 2025, and the Wisconsin and Massachusetts suits were dismissed in October 2025 and February 2026 on the ground that the claims belonged before the courts of New Zealand, where the events were alleged to have occurred; the Wisconsin dismissal has since been affirmed on appeal (*Bleeding Cool*, 2026). No court has ruled on the merits, and Gaiman's lawyers have stated that New Zealand police investigated her complaint and brought no charges (Associated Press, 10 February 2026). The allegations have nonetheless altered the circulation of the work. Disney paused its film of *The Graveyard Book* in September 2024 (Rice 2024); the final season of *Good Omens* was reduced to a single episode, with Gaiman no longer involved in its production (*Variety*, October 2024); and in January 2025 Dark Horse Comics announced that it would no longer publish him (Mouriquand 2025).

This study takes three positions in consequence. First, an allegation is not a finding, and nothing here adjudicates these claims in either direction. Second, a novel is not evidence about its author's conduct, and an allegation about an author is not evidence about what his novel means; the arguments of the following chapters are drawn from the text and its sources, and they would stand had the allegations never been made. Third, reception is part of a text's history. The questions Chapter Eight raises about gender, consent, dependence, and the use of women's lives in the making of men's stories are now asked by readers with an urgency that the study acknow-

ledges rather than suppresses, and section 8.6 sets out what the allegations change in the reading of the novel and what they do not.

INTRODUCTION



α

Two Cities and a Gap

A INTRODUCTION

Two Cities and a Gap

0.1

The problem of a minor book

Neverwhere has occupied an awkward station in the Gaiman canon. Chronologically it falls between the completion of *The Sandman* (1989–1996) and the more ambitious prose of *Stardust* (1999) and *American Gods* (2001). Generically it has been shelved as a television tie-in, an urban fantasy, or a young-adult crossover avant la lettre. Its surface is undemanding: an amiable, indecisive young man in the City stops to help a bleeding girl, is thereby erased from the world he knew, descends into a hidden London populated by the forgotten, and earns a name and a vocation before choosing that hidden world over the one that discarded him. The villains are vivid and legible, the quest is linear, and the comedy is broad. Yet this apparent simplicity conceals the most concentrated statement of the method Gaiman would spend the next three decades elaborating. The gods sustained by the residue of belief in *American Gods*, the door to an inverted copy-world in *Coraline* (2002), the ghouls who bear the titles of the eminent dead in *The Graveyard Book* (2008): each is anticipated, in compressed and almost diagrammatic form, in the London Below of 1996.

0.2

The premise as idiom

The novel's founding gesture is linguistic before it is geographical. London Below, the Marquis de Carabas tells Richard Mayhew as they climb down into a sewer, is inhabited by the people who fell through the cracks in the world (novel, ch. 5); Door's murdered father, in a recording she plays, had already described its people as the dispossessed who live below and between, in the cracks (ch. 4). In ordinary English, to fall through the cracks is a dead metaphor, a catachresis so thoroughly naturalized that it no longer registers as figurative: it designates the administrative oversight by which a person escapes the attention of the institutions charged with their welfare.

Gaiman's decisive act is to take the idiom at its word. There are cracks; people fall through them; they land somewhere; and the somewhere has a politics, an economy, a theology, and a nobility. Every subsequent marvel in the novel, from the Night's Bridge to the Angel Islington, repeats this primal operation of restoring a worn figure of speech to literal force. The novel's ontology is thus generated by its rhetoric. Samuel R. Delany observed that science fiction is distinguished by a reading protocol under which a sentence such as "her world exploded," figurative in mundane fiction, may be literally true. *Neverwhere* applies that protocol to the toponymy and idiom of a single city and discovers that the city has been speaking in buried literalisms all along.

"

The city has been speaking in buried literalisms all along.

0.3

Thesis

This dissertation contends that the novel's apparently miscellaneous furniture is unified by a single structural opposition, between a *Hermogenean metropolis* and a *Cratylan undercity*, and by a single mediating figure, the threshold-god Hermes, whose functions the novel distributes among its principal characters. The argument has five components.

The first is semiotic. London Above is governed by the conventionalist theory of naming that Plato's Hermogenes defends and Ferdinand de Saussure formalized as the arbitrariness of the sign; its names are labels, its money is abstraction, and its persons are interchangeable. London Below is governed by the naturalist theory that Cratylus defends, under which names belong to their bearers by right. Its literalized toponyms are not whimsy but a counter-semiotics.

The second is ethical. The passage between the two cities is triggered by an act of attention, Richard's refusal to pass by on the other side, and the novel's moral vision is an ethics of attention to the interstice. The London Underground's familiar safety announcement supplies its imperative: *mind the gap*, construed not as a warning against falling but as an instruction to attend to what has fallen.

The third is mythological. The novel's characters embody the offices of a dismembered Hermes: Door is the god of the hinge, the Floating Market the god of exchange, the Marquis de Carabas the god of the trick, Anaesthesia and the novel's other guides the god who leads, and Hunter the god of the contest. London Below is a hermetic polity, a community constituted by passage itself.

The fourth is theological. The Angel Islington's plan to storm heaven represents a strong messianism, the violent restoration of a lost wholeness, against which the novel sets the weak messianic power, in Benjamin's phrase, of small acts of attention. Door's climactic opening of the door onto an infinite elsewhere is the novel's refusal of apocalyptic closure.

The fifth is generic and critical. *Neverwhere* exemplifies a *Cratylan rhetoric of fantasy*, in which the fantastic arises from the re-motivation of the arbitrary sign; but that rhetoric has costs, including feudal nostalgia, nominal determinism, and a gendered distribution of the freedom to name oneself, which the novel registers without resolving.

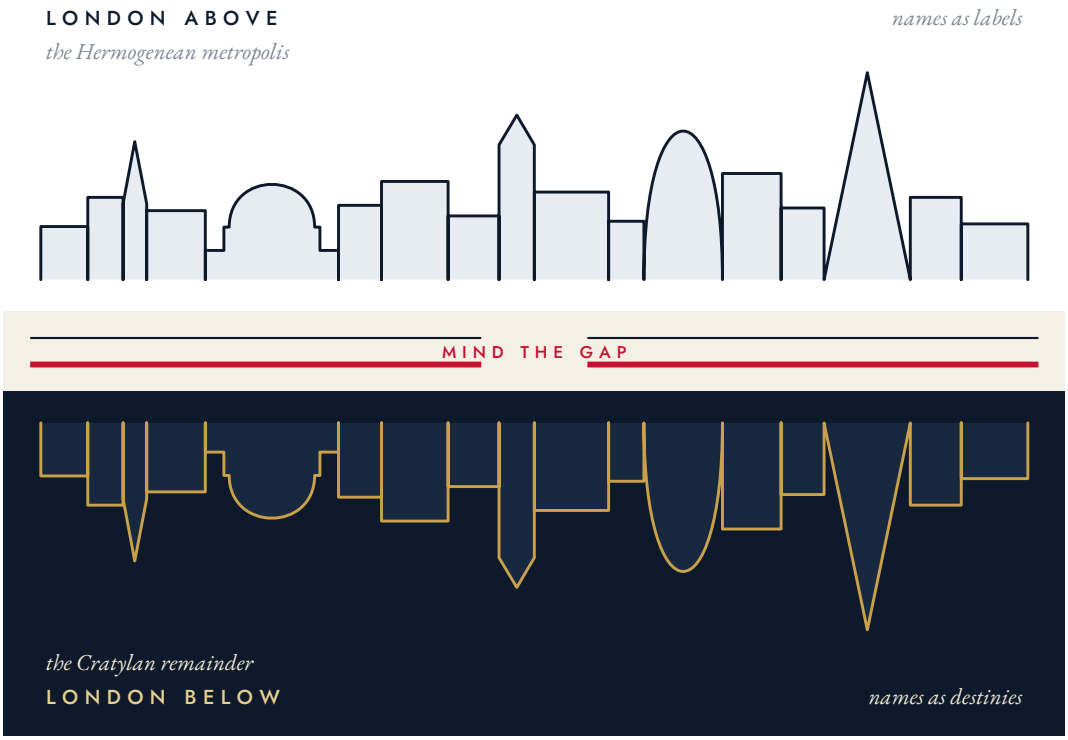


FIGURE 1 *The two cities. London Above names by convention; London Below takes its names at their word. The gap between them is the novel's subject and this study's ethic.*

0.4

Terms

Five coinages recur. *Hermogenean* describes any regime in which names, values, or identities are conventional, exchangeable, and indifferent to their bearers. *Cratylan* describes any regime in which they are motivated, proper, and binding. *Prosopopoeic re-motivation* names the novel's master trope: the conferral of face, and therefore of address and claim, upon what usage has

rendered faceless. *The dismembered Hermes* names the distribution of the god's five Aristophanic offices among the novel's agents. *Minding the gap* names the ethical imperative that unites the other four, the obligation to perceive and sustain what falls between conventional categories.

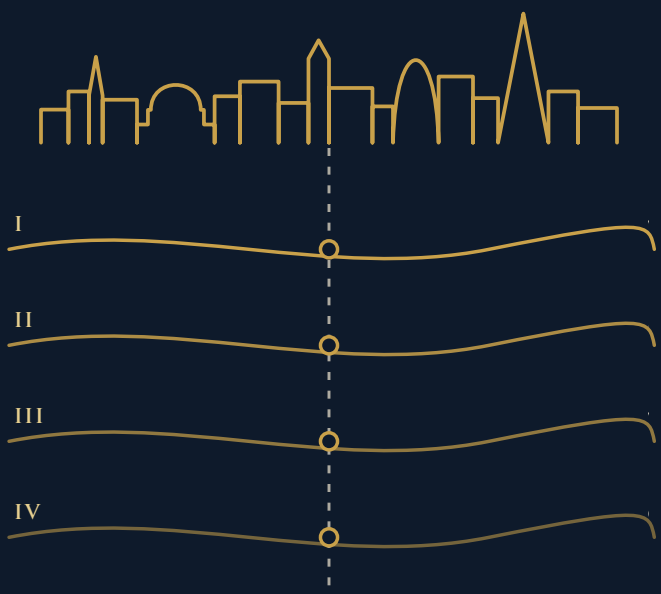
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The state of criticism and the shape of the argument

Existing commentary on *Neverwhere* has tended to read the novel along one of three axes: as an allegory of homelessness in Thatcherite and post-Thatcherite London; as a Campbellian bildungsroman in which a passive everyman acquires agency; or as an exercise in urban fantasy belonging to a lineage that runs from Dickens to China Miéville. Each axis captures something real, and each leaves the others unexplained. The allegorical reading cannot account for the novel's angelology; the mythic reading cannot account for its puns; the generic reading cannot account for its ethics. The present study offers a frame within which all three become intelligible as aspects of one design.

Chapter One reconstructs the archive beneath the novel: its textual genesis and its genealogies in the London visionary tradition, the Victorian literature of the poor, the nursery portal fantasy, and the modern literature of the underground. Chapter Two develops the Cratylan reading of the novel's names. Chapter Three examines the ontology of invisibility through the figure of Anaesthesia. Chapter Four assembles the dismembered Hermes. Chapter Five analyses the Floating Market and the economy of favour. Chapter Six treats Islington and the novel's angelology. Chapter Seven reads Richard's descent and return as an inverted katabasis. Chapter Eight sets out the limits of the novel's achievement, and the Conclusion formulates the Cratylan rhetoric of fantasy and the categorical imperative of the interstice that the novel implies.

CHAPTER ONE



I

The Archive Beneath

I CHAPTER ONE

The Archive Beneath

Sources, Precursors, and the Textual Palimpsest

London Below is built from the rubble of earlier Londons, and the novel is built from the rubble of earlier books. This chapter excavates five strata of that archive: the visionary tradition that treats London as a spiritual text; the Victorian literature that made the urban poor visible as a population; the nursery portal fantasy; the modern literature of the underground; and the utopian tradition of the non-place that the novel's title invokes.

1.1

The visionary stratum: Blake, De Quincey, Chesterton

The first and deepest stratum is William Blake's. Three Blakean texts underwrite the novel's cosmology. "London" (*Songs of Experience*, 1794) supplies its sociology: a walker who wanders through "each charter'd street," hearing in every voice "the mind-forg'd manacles" that bind the city's inhabitants to its conventions. The charter, a grant of privilege that is also a legal definition of space, is precisely what London Below lacks and precisely what it escapes. *Jerusalem* (1804–1820) supplies the novel's double topography, overlaying the empirical city with a visionary one: in plate 27, "The fields from Islington to Marybone, / To Primrose Hill and Saint John's Wood, / Were builded over with pillars of gold; / And there Jerusalem's pillars stood." That Blake's visionary London begins at Islington is a coincidence the novel's Angel converts into irony, since Gaiman's Islington is the would-be builder of a heavenly city who would raze the earthly one to reach it. *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell* (1790–1793) supplies the epistemology. "If the doors of perception were cleansed," plate 14 declares, "every thing would appear to man as it is, infinite. For man has closed himself up, till he sees all things thro' narrow chinks of his cavern." Blake's sentence contains, in nuce, the novel's entire apparatus: doors, perception,

the cavern, and the chinks, which is to say the cracks, through which a closed-up humanity glimpses what it has excluded.

Thomas De Quincey's *Confessions of an English Opium-Eater* (1821) contributes the novel's most poignant structural memory. Starving in London as a runaway, the young De Quincey was rescued by Ann, a girl of the Oxford Street pavements who spent her own scant money to revive him; when he left the city briefly, he lost her, and searched for her afterward in vain through what he called "the mighty labyrinths of London." The pattern of a young woman of the streets who guides and saves a newcomer and is then swallowed irrecoverably by the city recurs in Gaiman's Anaesthesia, the rat-speaker who guides Richard toward the Floating Market and is taken by the darkness on the Night's Bridge. That De Quincey's narrative is also the founding text of English literary narcosis, and that Gaiman names his lost guide for the condition of insensibility, makes the filiation more than thematic, as Chapter Three argues.

G. K. Chesterton belongs to the order of filiation, and the novel says so before its first sentence. *Neverwhere* opens with an epigraph from *The Napoleon of Notting Hill* (1904) in which a speaker confesses that he dares not go to St John's Wood, for he would be "afraid of the innumerable night of fir trees": a district's name read as a literal forest. The epigraph is itself an act of re-motivation, and it announces the method of the book it heads. Gaiman's veneration is documented elsewhere too: *Good Omens* (1990), co-written with Terry Pratchett, is dedicated to Chesterton, and in *The Sandman* the sentient place Fiddler's Green takes human form as a gentle, Chestertonian figure named Gilbert. Three Chesterton texts bear on *Neverwhere*. The essay "A Defence of Detective Stories" (*The Defendant*, 1901) argues that the city is more poetic than the countryside because every brick and paving stone is a deliberate human symbol, a message from some person as surely as a telegram; London Below is that thesis made habitable. *The Napoleon of Notting Hill* imagines a near-future London in which a whimsical king, as a joke, revives medieval heraldry and charters for the metropolitan boroughs, and a fanatical young provost, Adam Wayne, takes the joke in earnest and fights a war for Pump Street. The novel's closing recognition, that the humorist and the fanatic are two halves of a single mind, describes the precise mechanism of Gaiman's undercity, in which a pun on a toponym is taken with lethal seriousness. *The Club of Queer Trades* (1905), finally, imagines a secret society whose qualification for membership is the invention of an entirely new way of earning a living, and thereby anticipates the vocational exoticism of London Below's rat-speakers, Velvets, and favour-brokers.

1.2

The sociological stratum: Mayhew, Dickens, Engels, Hugo

The second stratum is the Victorian literature that first made the urban poor visible as a population with a taxonomy. Its central monument is Henry Mayhew's *London Labour and the London Poor* (1851; expanded 1861–1862), which classified the street poor into those who will

work, those who cannot work, and those who will not work, and which recorded, in interviews of unprecedented sympathy, the trades of the mudlarks, the toshers or sewer-hunters, the bone-grubbers, the pure-finders who gathered dog dung for the tanneries, and the rat-catchers. That Gaiman's protagonist bears Mayhew's surname is the strongest single piece of evidence for the novel's sociological filiation. Its stakes are sharpened by a detail of Mayhew's second volume, which records the sewer-hunters' legend of a breed of wild hogs said to have descended from a pregnant sow lost in the drains about Hampstead and to have grown numerous and ferocious on the city's refuse. The novel supplies a version of the legend in its own voice. Old Bailey tells the Marquis that in the reign of Charles I, before the Fire and the Plague, a butcher by the Fleet Ditch had an animal fattening for Christmas, a piglet by some accounts, which escaped into the ditch one December night, vanished into the sewers, and grew huge and vicious on what it found there (novel, ch. 8). The Great Beast of London, the colossal boar that haunts the Labyrinth and that Richard Mayhew finally kills, is the Mayhewian legend grown to mythic scale, and the namesake of the folklorist slays the monster of the folklore he recorded.

Charles Dickens supplies three further elements. In "Night Walks" (*The Uncommercial Traveller*, 1860), Dickens describes his insomniac perambulations as a temporary condition of "houselessness," a term that registers his sympathetic proximity to those for whom the condition was permanent. In *Bleak House* (1852–1853), the crossing-sweeper Jo is perpetually told to move on until there is nowhere left to move, a figure for the spatial exclusion that London Below converts into a counter-territory. In *Our Mutual Friend* (1864–1865), the fortune at the novel's centre is made from dust-heaps, the accumulated refuse of the metropolis, and the plot opens with a waterman fishing corpses from the Thames for what is in their pockets: wealth extracted from waste, which is the economic principle of the Floating Market.

"

The namesake of the folklorist slays the monster of the folklore he recorded.

Friedrich Engels's *The Condition of the Working Class in England* (1845) supplies the structural explanation of invisibility. Engels observed that Manchester was built so that a member of the middle class could live in it for years, travel daily between home and business, and never encounter a working-class district, because the main thoroughfares were lined with shops that screened the slums behind them. Invisibility, for Engels, was not a failure of perception but a feature of urban design. Victor Hugo, the French counterpart to this English tradition, supplies two more. In *Notre-Dame de Paris* (1831), the Cour des miracles is a beggars' kingdom with its own king and nobility, into which the poet Gringoire stumbles and where he must pass an

ordeal or hang. In *Les Misérables* (1862), the digression on the Paris sewers declares that the sewer is the conscience of the city, the place where every mask falls and every disguise is stripped away. Between them, Hugo's two texts furnish both the political form of London Below, an aristocracy of the dispossessed, and its moral function, the city's buried conscience. Charles Booth's colour-coded poverty maps (1889–1903), George Gissing's *The Nether World* (1889), Jack London's *The People of the Abyss* (1903), and George Orwell's *Down and Out in Paris and London* (1933) extend the tradition into the twentieth century.

1.3

The nursery stratum: Carroll, MacDonald, Barrie, Baum, Lewis

By his own retrospective account, Gaiman conceived *Neverwhere* partly as an attempt to give adult readers something of what the portal fantasies of his childhood had given him. The genealogy is explicit for Lewis Carroll and C. S. Lewis. *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* (1865) supplies the descent, the loss of identity, and, above all, the world generated by literalized language, a matter for Chapter Two. Lewis's *The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe* (1950) supplies the domestic portal, and *The Magician's Nephew* (1955) the Wood between the Worlds, an interstitial zone of passage.

Three further precursors belong to filiation. George MacDonald's *The Princess and the Goblin* (1872) explains its subterranean goblins as descendants of people who once lived above ground but withdrew beneath the mountains in resentment of a king's exactions, so that a people driven out of the social order becomes a hidden nation beneath it. J. M. Barrie's Lost Boys, in *Peter and Wendy* (1911), are children who fell out of their perambulators while their nurses were looking the other way and who, unclaimed after seven days, were sent to the Neverland: an exact nursery analogue of falling through the cracks, down to the bureaucratic interval after which the unclaimed are reassigned to another world. L. Frank Baum's *The Wonderful Wizard of Oz* (1900) supplies the plot structure of Door's quest. Dorothy and her companions travel to a hidden power in an emerald hall, are sent on a deferring errand to retrieve the Witch's broom, and discover that the power is a fraud. Door and her companions travel to the Angel Islington's hall, are sent to retrieve the key held by the Black Friars, and discover that the angel is worse than a fraud.

The twentieth-century portal and wainscot traditions extend the lineage. Hope Mirrlees's *Lud-in-the-Mist* (1926), a novel Gaiman has repeatedly championed, imagines a bourgeois town that has outlawed the very mention of Fairyland, only for the repressed to return through smuggled fruit; Mary Norton's *The Borrowers* (1952) imagines a diminutive people who subsist on what the household above them loses; Terry Pratchett's *Truckers* (1989) houses a wainscot civilization of nomes inside a department store, an uncanny anticipation of the Floating Market's convocation in Harrods; and Diana Wynne Jones's *Howl's Moving Castle* (1986) contains a

single door whose dial opens onto four different places, a domestic machine for the non-Euclidean architecture of Door's family house.

1.4

The underground stratum: Dostoevsky to Delany

The modern literature of the underground provides the novel's existential register. Dostoevsky's *Notes from Underground* (1864) gives literature its first great subterranean subject, a man who lives beneath the floorboards of modernity in defiance of the Crystal Palace, the glass emblem of rationalized utopia that stood, not incidentally, in London. Dostoevsky's travel sketch *Winter Notes on Summer Impressions* (1863) records his horror at the London of the Great Exhibition, which he figured as a temple of Baal, and at the nocturnal multitudes of the Haymarket poor. H. G. Wells's *The Time Machine* (1895) stratifies the class system vertically, with the effete Eloi above and the subterranean Morlocks below; *Neverwhere* inverts Wells's valuation, locating vitality below and anaesthesia above. E. M. Forster's "The Machine Stops" (1909) and Edward Bulwer-Lytton's *The Coming Race* (1871) supply subterranean civilizations of opposite moral valence.

The American line is equally pertinent. Richard Wright's "The Man Who Lived Underground" (1942) and Ralph Ellison's *Invisible Man* (1952) establish invisibility as a social rather than an optical condition: Ellison's narrator is unseen not because he lacks substance but because others refuse to see him, and he withdraws to a cellar lit by stolen electricity. Thomas Pynchon's *Gravity's Rainbow* (1973), set substantially in wartime London, borrows the Calvinist category of the *preterite*, those passed over by election, as a name for history's disregarded. Samuel R. Delany's *Dhalgren* (1975) imagines Bellona, a city that has dropped out of the national order and out of ordinary time, inhabited by the marginal and traversed by a protagonist who cannot remember his own name. Each of these texts offers a version of what Gaiman would make into a city.

One documented source belongs in this stratum as well. Gene Wolfe's urban fantasy *Free Live Free* (1984), whose protagonists are a company of down-at-heel lodgers in a single boarding house, is recorded as a partial inspiration for both the television serial and the novel, and its gathering of the marginal into a questing company anticipates Gaiman's.

1.5

The title: a genealogy of the non-place

The word *Neverwhere* compounds two negations, one temporal and one spatial, and in doing so it inserts the novel into the longest-running tradition of political fiction. Thomas More's *Utopia* (1516) coined its title from the Greek *ou-topos*, no place, punning on *eu-topos*, the good place.

Samuel Butler's *Erewhon* (1872) anagrammatized *nowhere* for a satirical commonwealth in which illness is punished as crime and crime treated as illness. William Morris's *News from Nowhere* (1890) transported its narrator into a pastoral future London in which the Houses of Parliament have become a storehouse for dung. Barrie's Never Never Land compressed the formula for the nursery. Gaiman's coinage adds the temporal negation that Charles Renouvier named *uchronia*, the no-time of alternate history: *never* plus *where*. London Below is accordingly both a no-place and a no-time, a city where places persist after their meaning has drained away and where time pools rather than flows, so that medieval courts, Roman soldiery, and Victorian legend coexist in a single present. The title's double negation is the first statement of the novel's thesis that what the official city has negated persists in negated form, as an anti-place and an anti-time, and that its persistence is a form of resistance.

CHAPTER TWO



II

The Cratylan City

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The Cratylan City

Names, Puns, and the Return of the Literal

London Below is a counter-semiotics: a city in which the bond between name and named, long since rendered arbitrary in the official metropolis, has been re-motivated, so that to bear a name is to be bound by it. This chapter reconstructs the ancient quarrel that the novel restages, proposes a typology of its literalizations, and argues that their common operation is prosopopoeic: the conferral of face upon what usage has defaced.

2.1

A quarrel about names that is also a quarrel about Hermes

Plato's *Cratylus* stages the oldest surviving dispute in the philosophy of language, and its terms remain those of *Neverwhere*. Hermogenes holds that names are correct by convention and agreement alone: whatever name is given to a thing is its right name, and if another is substituted, the new one is no less correct than the old, just as masters change the names of their slaves (384d). Cratylus holds that every thing has a correct name by nature, the same for Greeks and barbarians alike, and he presses the point with a provocation: Hermogenes, he says, is not really named Hermogenes, even if all mankind calls him so (383a–b). Socrates, summoned to adjudicate, at first inclines towards nature. A name, he proposes, is an instrument (*organon*) for teaching and for dividing being, as the weaver's shuttle divides the threads of the web (388b–c), and like every instrument it must be made by a craftsman, the rare legislator of names who fashions each one with an eye to the form it ought to express (389a–390e). Yet the dialogue's long etymological middle dismantles what it was meant to establish. The etymologies grow increasingly fanciful; the primary names imitate their objects through their letters only fitfully, so that if *rho* expresses motion and hardness, the *lambda* in *sklērotēs* ("hardness") contradicts it (434c–435a); and Socrates concedes that the pull of likeness is, in Hermogenes' own word, a meagre thing, which

convention must supplement (435c). The dialogue closes with the counsel that knowledge must be sought from things rather than from names (439a–b), and with Cratylus still drawn towards the Heraclitean flux. Aristotle completes the irony by reporting that the historical Cratylus, in old age, ceased to speak at all and merely moved his finger, rebuking Heraclitus on the ground that one could not step into the same river even once (*Metaphysics* Γ.5, 1010a).

What makes the dialogue the indispensable intertext for *Neverwhere* is that its quarrel about names is, from the first exchanges, a quarrel about Hermes and money. Socrates glosses Cratylus' taunt that Hermogenes is not truly "no true son of Hermes" (in Jowett's rendering) as a joke at the expense of a man perpetually in pursuit of wealth and perpetually failing to obtain it, Hermes being the god of gain (384c). When the etymologies reach the god himself, Socrates derives his name from speech and makes him patron of the interpreter (*hermēneus*), the messenger, the thief, the liar, and the bargainer, every trade conducted by the power of words (407e–408a); Hermogenes, he concludes, is indeed no son of Hermes, being no contriver of speech (408b). There follows the dialogue's most remarkable image. Pan, the son of Hermes, is named for the "all" (*pan*) that speech signifies and perpetually turns about, and because speech is double, true and false, Pan is double-natured, smooth and divine above, rough and goatish below. True speech, Socrates says, dwells above among the gods, while falsehood dwells below among men, rough like the goat of tragedy, since fables and falsehoods belong to the tragic life (408b–d).

The *Cratylus* thus contains in germ every element of the novel: the correctness of proper names; the identity of the god of words with the god of commerce, theft, and passage; and a vertical topography of language in which truth dwells above and falsehood below. *Neverwhere* inverts that topography. In London Above speech is smooth, conventional, and false, in the precise sense that its names no longer say what they name; in London Below speech is rough, comic, and true, because its names mean what they say. The dissertation's governing opposition takes its terms from the dialogue's two antagonists. London Above is *Hermogenean*, a regime of designation by fiat, in which names, like those of the renamed slaves of 384d, are imposed and reassigned by whoever has power to impose them. London Below is *Cratylan*, a regime in which names belong to their bearers by right and cannot be revoked, because name and nature coincide. That Hermogenes' paradigm of conventional naming is the renaming of slaves is not incidental. Orlando Patterson's comparative study *Slavery and Social Death* (1982) identifies renaming as a constitutive ritual of enslavement, the symbolic enactment of the natal alienation by which a person is severed from every claim of descent and made the instrument of another's will. The arbitrary name is the semiotics of social death, and Chapter Three argues that Richard Mayhew's erasure is a social death of exactly this kind, administered not by a master but by a city.

2 . 2

Relative motivation and the toponymic necropolis

Ferdinand de Saussure made Hermogenes' thesis the first principle of modern linguistics: the bond between signifier and signified is arbitrary, which is to say unmotivated, possessing no natural connection with what it signifies (*Course in General Linguistics*, 1916, Part One, ch. 1). Less often recalled is the qualification Saussure introduced in his discussion of absolute and relative arbitrariness (Part Two, ch. 6). Some signs are only relatively arbitrary: French *dix-neuf* ("nineteen") is motivated by *dix* and *neuf* as *vingt* ("twenty") is not, and *poirier* ("pear tree") by *poire* and the suffix *-ier*. Motivation, moreover, is historically unstable. Sound change perpetually converts relative motivation into absolute arbitrariness, so that Latin *inimicus*, transparently *in-* and *amicus*, becomes French *ennemi*, motivated by nothing, and every language oscillates between a lexicological pole of maximal arbitrariness and a grammatical pole of maximal motivation.

Toponyms are the class of sign most exposed to this drift, for two reasons. They are compounds, and therefore originally motivated, since a place-name typically begins as a description of the place. And as proper names they function independently of their descriptive content once conferred. John Stuart Mill gave the second point its canonical form in *A System of Logic* (1843, Book I, ch. 2, §5): a town may have been named Dartmouth because it lies at the mouth of the Dart, but "it is no part of the signification of the word Dartmouth, to be situated at the mouth of the Dart," and were sand to choke the river's mouth or an earthquake to divert its course, the name would not change. Saul Kripke's account of names as rigid designators, fixed at an initial baptism and transmitted along a causal-historical chain (*Naming and Necessity*, 1972/1980), refines the Millian thesis without abandoning it: a name keeps its reference whatever becomes of the descriptions once attached to it. A metropolis is accordingly a *toponymic necropolis*, a cemetery of motivations, in which every name preserves the corpse of a description its users have ceased to read.

Neverwhere exhumes those descriptions. The table sets the principal toponyms of London Below against their attested origins, which follow A. D. Mills's *A Dictionary of London Place Names* (2001).



FIGURE 2 *Four modes of re-motivation, by which London Below restores motive to the worn names of the city. Table 1 sets out the principal cases.*

TABLE 1 *The toponymic necropolis: London place-names, their attested origins, and their forms in London Below.*

LONDON TOPONYM	ATTESTED ORIGIN	IN LONDON BELOW	MODE OF RE-MOTIVATION
Blackfriars	The Dominican priory that moved to the site in 1276, its friars called Black Friars from their black mantles	The Black Friars, a monastic order that guards a key and administers its ordeal	RESTORATIVE
Earl's Court	The manorial court house of the de Vere Earls of Oxford, lords of the manor of Kensington	An aged Earl holding court, with retinue and fool, in an Underground carriage	RESTORATIVE
Hammersmith	Old English *hamor* + *smiððe*, "hammer smithy"	Hammersmith, a gigantic blacksmith	RESTORATIVE
Shepherd's Bush	Disputed; plausibly a bush or common where shepherds rested flocks bound for Smithfield	The Shepherds, herders of persons, developed in the 2014 coda	RESTORATIVE
Knightsbridge	*Cnihtebricge* (c. 1050), "bridge of the young men or retainers" (Old English *cniht*)	The Night's Bridge, whose darkness takes a toll of those who cross	PARONOMASTIC
Islington	*Gislandune* (c. 1000), "hill of a man called Gīsla"	Islington, an angel imprisoned beneath London	PERSONIFYING

LONDON TOPONYM	ATTESTED ORIGIN	IN LONDON BELOW	MODE OF RE-MOTIVATION
The Angel	A coaching inn whose painted sign became the name of the district and its station	The same angel, given a body	EMBLEMATIC
Old Bailey	The bailey, or outer rampart, of the City wall; later the metonym for the Central Criminal Court	Old Bailey, an aged rooftop birdcatcher entrusted with the Marquis's life	PERSONIFYING
Seven Sisters	A ring of seven elms at Page Green, Tottenham	Seven formidable and estranged sisters, among them Serpentine	PERSONIFYING
Serpentine	The Hyde Park lake, laid out in 1730 and named for its sinuous form	Serpentine, a forbidding matriarch with whom Hunter has a history	PERSONIFYING

The table discloses four modes of re-motivation, each answering to a distinct theory of how meaning survives its own effacement. In *restorative* re-motivation the undercity recovers a toponym's founding referent: the Dominicans return to Blackfriars, the manorial court to Earl's Court, the forge to Hammersmith. London Below here functions as the city's etymological memory, an *anamnesis* in the Platonic sense, the recollection of what the name once knew. In *paronomastic* re-motivation a homophone usurps a lost etymon: *cniht*, the retainer, has vanished from Knightsbridge, and night has moved into the vacated sound. The mechanism is that of the reference shifts Gareth Evans analysed in "The Causal Theory of Names" (1973), where *Madagascar*, once a name for part of the African mainland, came through Marco Polo's misunderstanding to designate the island; it is also that of the Freudian joke, in which a verbal accident releases a repressed meaning. In *personifying* re-motivation a name acquires a face: the bailey becomes an old man, the elms become sisters, the lake a matriarch. In *emblematic* re-motivation, finally, an image becomes a being. The Angel was first a painted inn sign, then a district, then a station, and latterly one of the cheapest properties on the British edition of the Monopoly board; Gaiman restores its body to an angel who had survived for centuries as the picture of a picture.

The case of Islington shows that these modes are not exclusive, and that the palimpsest, at its deepest stratum, runs to a face. To personify Islington appears to be the novel's boldest liberty with the map. Yet the district's earliest recorded name, *Gislandune*, preserves the name of a person, the otherwise unknown Gīsla whose hill it was. In making Islington a person, Gaiman, whether or not he knew it, restores the person from whom the place was named. Personification proves to be restoration at a lower depth, and the sequence of the city's history, from person to place to label, runs backwards. The toponymic necropolis is not only a cemetery of descriptions; it is a cemetery of faces.

The novel's literalizations are therefore not whimsy. Together they amount to an ontological descriptivism, a reversal of the direction of fit that governs reference in the official city. In the Millian and Kripkean regime of London Above, a name attaches to a thing whatever the thing may be like. In London Below the thing must come to fit the name: Earl's Court must contain an earl and a court, and the Night's Bridge must be a bridge of night. Frege's distinction between sense and reference (1892), and the Russellian proposal that ordinary proper names abbreviate descriptions, are here not semantic theses but cosmological laws, under which the sense of a name determines the nature of its bearer. London Below is what the world would look like if descriptivism were true, and its uncanniness, as section 2.5 argues, derives from exactly that.

2.3

The nonsense precedent: Carroll's literalists

The immediate literary precedent for a world generated by the literalization of language is Lewis Carroll's. The Mock Turtle of *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland* (1865, ch. 9) is a creature produced by taking a culinary name at its word: mock turtle soup, an imitation made from a calf's head, is presumed to require a mock turtle from which to be made, and Tenniel accordingly drew the creature with the head and hind hooves of a calf. "Once," the Mock Turtle says, "I was a real Turtle," and his melancholy is the melancholy of a being who exists only because a name was misread. The Night's Bridge stands to Knightsbridge as the Mock Turtle to its soup: a misreading produces a being, and the being, once produced, is as real as anything else.

Through the Looking-Glass (1871) extends Carroll's philosophy of naming in two episodes that bear directly on the novel's structure of erasure and recognition. In the third chapter, the Gnat asks what use it is for insects to have names if they will not answer to them, and Alice replies that names are of no use to the things named but useful "to the people that name them." The exchange states the Hermogenean thesis with an economy Plato never attained: conventional names serve the namers. Alice then enters the wood "where things have no names," forgets her own, and walks in perfect amity with a Fawn, her arms about its neck, until they reach an open field. There the Fawn recovers its name, recognises her as "a human child," and bolts in alarm. Namelessness abolishes enmity; naming restores hierarchy and fear. Richard Mayhew passes through all three of Carroll's states. In London Above his name is a label of use chiefly to the institutions that file it; his erasure leads him into the wood where things have no names; and in London Below he is recognised, but in a world where recognition, as the Fawn knew, places one among predators.

The sixth chapter supplies the political theory of the whole. Asked whether a name must mean something, Humpty Dumpty replies that of course it must: his own name means the shape he is, whereas with a name like Alice's she might be any shape, almost. Minutes later he

declares that a word, when he uses it, means just what he chooses it to mean, and when Alice wonders whether one can make words mean so many different things, he answers: "The question is, which is to be master—that's all." Humpty Dumpty is a Cratylist about his own proper name and a Hermogenean about everyone else's words; he pays extra the words he makes work hard, and they owe him obedience in return. The asymmetry is the political truth of naming, and it recurs in *Neverwhere* in two forms. The nobility of London Below, the Earl, Lord Ratspeaker, Lord Portico, hold titles that disclose their essence. Mr Croup, by contrast, is the novel's Humpty Dumpty: his ornate, polysyllabic idiolect is a hoard of words collected for their texture and spent on intimidation, a language paid extra and therefore owing nothing to things. The novel's chief assassin is its chief Hermogenean, and its villains, as Chapter Six argues, serve a programme of total restoration that would close every gap.

Two later filiations complete the lineage. Elisabeth Beresford's *The Wombles* (1968) imagined a burrowing people beneath Wimbledon Common who live by salvaging what the human city leaves behind, and Michael de Larrabeiti's *The Borribles* (1976) answered Beresford with a savage parody: a tribe of feral, runaway London children who wage war on the Rumbles of Rumbledom, a toponymic burlesque of Wimbledon, and among whom a name must be won by a feat. In de Larrabeiti the Cratylan principle already governs the moral economy of an undercity of the dispossessed: one is not given a name but earns it, and the name records the deed. Richard, who arrives in London Below with nothing but the name his parents gave him, follows the Borrible path, acquiring through the Ordeal of the Key and the killing of the Great Beast not a new name but the standing that makes his old one mean something.

2 . 4

Worn coins: Nietzsche, France, Derrida, and the usure of the sign

The Hermogenean metropolis has a philosophy of its own, and its central image is a coin. In the posthumously published essay "Über Wahrheit und Lüge im außermoralischen Sinne" (written 1873), Nietzsche defines truths as illusions whose illusory character has been forgotten, metaphors worn out and drained of sensuous force, "Münzen, die ihr Bild verloren haben": coins that have lost their image and now count as metal rather than as coins. Anatole France's dialogue "Aristos et Polyphile, ou le langage métaphysique," in *Le Jardin d'Épicure* (1894), elaborates the figure: the metaphysicians resemble knife-grinders who put coins and medals to the wheel in place of knives and scissors, rubbing away legend, date, and effigy until nothing shows whose image the coin once bore. Jacques Derrida opened "La mythologie blanche" (1971) with France's passage and named its operation *usure*, a French word meaning both wear and usury. The philosophical concept, on this account, is a metaphor rubbed smooth by circulation, and its value is interest accrued on a capital of meaning whose origin has been effaced.

The effaced effigy is the image of London Above. Its names are worn coins that still circulate, their faces gone, and so, in a different register, are its persons: Richard's colleagues, his fiancée, and the commuters among whom he travels are interchangeable tokens of the money economy that Georg Simmel, whose diagnosis Chapter Three takes up, identified as the great leveller of qualitative difference. The worn coin also prepares the economics of Chapter Five, where the Floating Market's preference for barter, favour, and obligation over money is read as a refusal of *usure* in both its senses. Derrida's argument nonetheless imposes a caution that this dissertation adopts. There is no pure origin from which metaphor fell and no proper sense the grindstone wore away; the effigy was always already a figure, and the dream of restoring it is itself metaphysical. Gaiman's re-motivations honour the caution even where they seem to violate it. The Night's Bridge is not *Cnihtebricge* restored but a new coin struck over the worn one. Re-motivation is minting, not archaeology, and London Below is not the city's lost origin but its counterfeit, in the precise and honourable sense of a coin struck against the official currency.

The novel teaches its reader to hear names this way before London Below appears, and it uses Nietzsche's own coin. In the prologue, drunk outside a pub in a small Scottish town on the night before he leaves for London, Richard gives an old homeless woman his umbrella, printed with the map of the Underground, and watches the names of its stations walk away into the rain on her back; minutes later he finds himself wondering whether there is a real circus at Oxford Circus, with clowns and dangerous beasts (novel, prologue). The question is the novel's method in miniature, asked before its plot begins. At the threshold of the Ordeal, the novel performs the same operation on an idiom built from a coin. Richard remembers a childhood visit to a castle tower, where a teacher told the class that a penny dropped from the top would crack a man's skull at the bottom like a bullet; when he grasps what the friars intend for him, the penny drops with the force of that remembered thunderbolt (novel, ch. 11). The worn coin of the idiom, falling, recovers the murderous weight that use had rubbed away. Gaiman's literalism is not confined to toponyms. It is a general practice of re-minting the city's dead metaphors, in the precise sense Nietzsche gave the figure.

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Re-motivation is minting, not archaeology.

Stéphane Mallarmé supplied the aesthetic name for that minting. In "Crise de vers" (1897) he lamented the perversity by which French gives *jour* a dark timbre and *nuit* a bright one, so that the sound of each word contradicts the thing it names; verse exists, he concluded, because it "rémunère le défaut des langues," because it repays or compensates the defect of languages. Gérard Genette, whose *Mimologiques: Voyage en Cratylie* (1976) charts the Cratylist dream

from Plato to the twentieth century, calls this position a *secondary* Cratylism: the acknowledgement that language is arbitrary, joined to the will to correct its arbitrariness by art. *Neverwhere* is secondary Cratylism realized as a city. It does not pretend that London's names were ever true; it makes them true, compensating the defect of a language in which Knightsbridge has nothing to do with knights and still less with night. That Mallarmé's own example of a misfitted name is *nuit* deepens the correspondence: the Night's Bridge is the remuneration of a word that had forgotten the dark.

Walter Benjamin's early essay "Über Sprache überhaupt und über die Sprache des Menschen" (1916) had already given the opposition of the two cities its theological form. Benjamin rejected what he called "die bürgerliche Auffassung der Sprache," the bourgeois conception of language, for which the word is a conventional sign for a thing, passed from one person to another: the Hermogenean thesis exactly. Against it he set the language of names, modelled on Adam's naming of the animals in Genesis, "and whatsoever Adam called every living creature, that was the name thereof" (2:19, AV), in which the name does not signify the thing from outside but answers to the language of things themselves. The Fall, in Benjamin's account, was a fall of language from the name into the mere sign, from naming into judgment and chatter, and it left nature mute and mournful: to be named by the many languages of fallen humanity, by names that do not know it, is to suffer what Benjamin called *Überbenennung*, overnaming, which he held to be the deepest linguistic reason for all melancholy. London Above is an overnamed city, its places and persons labelled many times over by names that do not know them, and its characteristic mood is the blasé melancholy that Chapter Three examines. London Below is not the Adamic language restored, since there is no origin to restore. It is a secondary language of names, struck by art over the worn signs of the fallen city, and its melancholy is lifted, when it is lifted at all, by names that answer to their bearers.

2 . 5

Prosopopoeia: the restoration of face

Quintilian's account of prosopopoeia, the fiction of persons, reads as a programme for *Neverwhere*. In this form of speech, he writes, it is permitted to bring the gods down and to raise the dead, and "urbes etiam populique vocem accipiunt": even cities and peoples receive a voice (*Institutio Oratoria* IX.2.31). The novel does all three. It brings an angel down, it raises the infernal population of the forgotten, and it gives voice to the city's names. Cicero had shown the political force of the figure when he made the fatherland itself address Catiline, a city that "quodam modo tacita loquitur," that after a fashion speaks in silence (*In Catilinam* I.18). London Below is the tacit speech of London, its silent address to those who walk over it.

Paul de Man's "Autobiography as De-facement" (1979) gave the trope its modern theoretical form. De Man defined prosopopoeia as the fiction by which a speaker addresses something

absent, dead, or mute as though it could answer, thereby lending it speech; and because speech implies a mouth, and a mouth a countenance, the figure culminates, as its Greek name *prosōpon poiein* records, in the making of a face. But de Man insisted that the trope disfigures in the same measure that it restores: the face it confers is a mask, and the voice it lends is the speaker's own. Barbara Johnson's "Apostrophe, Animation, and Abortion" (1986) drew out the ethical and political consequences, showing that the decision as to which beings are addressed, and thereby animated, is never rhetorically innocent.

Read through this tradition, the novel's three central acts of re-motivation are a single act directed at three objects. The literalized toponym gives face to a name. The population of London Below gives face to persons the official city has rendered faceless, the vagrant and the lost, whose features, as Chapter Three shows, London Above is unable to retain. The Angel Islington gives face to a god who survived only as an emblem. In each case prosopopoeic re-motivation restores the possibility of address: what had been merely an object of reference becomes an interlocutor, and therefore a claimant. The trope must be distinguished from John Ruskin's pathetic fallacy (*Modern Painters* III, 1856, ch. 12), with which it might be confused. The pathetic fallacy attributes feeling to nature through a distortion in the observer, as when Charles Kingsley's foam is called cruel and crawling. Prosopopoeic re-motivation attributes being to language through the logic of language itself. Its warrant is not emotion but etymology, homophony, and the dormant motivation Saussure called relative.

Freud's "Das Unheimliche" (1919) explains why the result is uncanny rather than merely whimsical. The uncanny, Freud observed, is readily produced when the boundary between imagination and reality is effaced, and in particular when a symbol assumes the entire office and meaning of what it symbolizes. Freud's own method in that essay is Cratylan. He reaches his theory through the dictionary, tracing how *heimlich*, homely and familiar, passes through the sense of the concealed and secret until it coincides with its opposite, *unheimlich*, and he adopts Schelling's definition of the uncanny as whatever ought to have remained hidden and has come to light. London Below is uncanny in exactly this philological sense: it is the secret of the home city, the *heimlich* London concealed within the familiar one, brought to light by the literalization of its names.

The novel's milieu shows that the prosopopoeic impulse was not Gaiman's alone. The London fiction of the preceding two decades had repeatedly given the city a face and a voice. Iain Sinclair's *Lud Heat* (1975) and Peter Ackroyd's *Hawksmoor* (1985) read occult intention into the churches of Nicholas Hawksmoor; Michael Moorcock's *Mother London* (1988) followed three psychiatric outpatients who hear the voices of the city's inhabitants; and Alan Moore and Eddie Campbell's *From Hell*, serialized from 1989, sent its murderer on a carriage tour of a London mapped as a mythic diagram. Ackroyd's *London: The Biography* (2000) would later make the prosopopoeia historiographical, writing the city's history as the life of a person, and Ben Aaronovitch's *Rivers of London* (2011) would personify the Thames and its tributaries as a quar-

relsome family of river gods. What distinguishes *Neverwhere* within this lineage is its source of authority. Sinclair and Ackroyd find the city's face in occult history, Moore in architectural conspiracy; Gaiman finds it in the city's names. His prosopopoeia is philological rather than esoteric, and its democratic implication is that the city's secret life is legible to anyone who can read a map of the Underground.

Three cautions accompany the achievement, and Chapter Eight develops them. Socrates warned that likeness is a meagre support for names; Derrida, that there is no origin to restore; de Man, that every face conferred is also a mask. In London Below the conferral of names that fit is also a confinement. Hunter is only ever a hunter, Door is her function, and the Velvets are what their name describes. The Cratylan city frees its inhabitants from the arbitrary designation of the renamed slave only to bind them to designations they cannot revise. That ambivalence is the price of the novel's central gift, and the chapter that follows turns from the faces conferred on names to the faces withheld from persons.



CHAPTER THREE





III

Anaesthesia

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Anaesthesia

The Distribution of the Sensible and the Ontology of Invisibility

The inhabitants of London Below are not hidden; they are unperceived. Their invisibility is not an optical fact but a political distribution of sensibility, enforced less by walls than by habits of attention, and the novel names that condition in the person of its first and most fragile guide.

3.1

The name of the guide

Anaesthesia is a rat-speaker, a girl of the subterranean guild that serves the rats of London, ordered by the Lord Rat-speaker, over her tears, to take Richard to the Floating Market after his erasure has left him nowhere else to go (novel, ch. 4). Timid and kind, she is among the first inhabitants of London Below to treat him with simple goodwill, and the novel gives her what it gives few of its inhabitants, a history. Walking beside the Thames, she tells him that she was born above. Her mother became mentally ill, social services took her younger sisters away, and she was sent to an aunt whose partner abused her; when she told her aunt, she was beaten, called a liar, and threatened with the police, and on her eleventh birthday she ran away. She slept by day and walked by night to keep warm, took bread and milk from doorsteps, and lived on the rotten fruit thrown out by street markets, until she fell ill under an overpass in Notting Hill and woke in London Below, where the rats had found her. Asked whether she has tried to return, she answers that no one gets both worlds. On the far side of the river they must cross the Night's Bridge, whose darkness exacts a toll from those who pass over it, and she does not come out of the dark. Richard emerges alone. The narrative registers his shock; London Below, as section 3.5 shows, moves on without her.

Her name is the most philosophically freighted in the novel. *Anaesthesia* compounds the privative *an-* with *aisthēsis*, perception or sensation. The word had a modest prior life in medical

lexicography, but it entered general use in November 1846, when Oliver Wendell Holmes proposed it to William Morton for the insensibility produced by ether, some weeks after Morton's public demonstration at the Massachusetts General Hospital. Its root names the faculty whose science Alexander Baumgarten founded under the title *Aesthetica* (1750), defined in its opening paragraph as the science of sensible cognition, *scientia cognitionis sensitivae*, and which Kant's "Transcendental Aesthetic" in the *Critique of Pure Reason* (1781/1787) reconceived as the doctrine of the a priori forms of sensibility, space and time. To be anaesthetized is thus to be removed from the forms under which anything can be perceived at all, and the novel's title acquires a transcendental sense. London Below, a *neverwhere*, is not a region of London Above's space and time that happens to be concealed. It is what falls outside the forms of the official city's intuition. A single house there may have rooms scattered across the metropolis; its market convenes in a different place each time; its time pools rather than flows, the city having, as Richard learns, more time than it can use at once. For London Above the undercity is not hidden but anaesthetic, beyond the reach of its sensibility.

The name also reaches backward. Chapter One traced the filiation that runs from De Quincey's Ann of Oxford Street, the girl of the pavements who saved a starving runaway and was lost to him in the labyrinth of London, to Gaiman's guide. That De Quincey's *Confessions* is also the founding document of English narcotic literature sharpens the inheritance. Ann belongs to a narrative of opium; Anaesthesia bears the name of the condition opium was used to induce. In both texts a young woman of the streets mediates a newcomer's passage into the city's hidden life, and in both she is the price of it.

The coincidence the word records is also structural. The decades that perfected the medical abolition of pain were those in which Mayhew documented the street poor and the metropolis learned not to see them. Susan Buck-Morss, in "Aesthetics and Anaesthetics: Walter Benjamin's Artwork Essay Reconsidered" (1992), argued that modernity converted the synaesthetic system of the senses into an anaesthetic one: assaulted by the shocks of industrial and urban life, the sensorium learned to defend itself by numbing, and the nineteenth century developed an entire technology of narcosis, from opiates and ether to the phantasmagoria of the arcade and the exhibition. Benjamin's "Über einige Motive bei Baudelaire" (1939), drawing on the protective shield against stimuli posited in Freud's *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920), had described the metropolitan subject as a consciousness trained to parry shocks, so that experience degrades into isolated, unassimilated incident. London Above is Buck-Morss's anaesthetic sensorium given civic form, and the guide who bears its name dies in the dark between the two cities.

3 . 2

The blasé metropolis

The most exact theoretical description of London Above's mode of perception was written in 1903. In "Die Großstädte und das Geistesleben," Georg Simmel argued that the metropolis subjects its inhabitants to an intensification of nervous stimulation so relentless that it produces a characteristic psychic defence, the blasé attitude. Its essence, he wrote, is "die Abstumpfung gegen die Unterschiede der Dinge," a blunting of sensibility to the differences between things. The blunting is not a failure to perceive, as in the dullard. The differences are perceived, but their meaning and value, and with them the meaning and value of the things themselves, are felt to be void. Simmel traced the attitude to the money economy, which reduces every qualitative distinction to a question of how much and so hollows out the core of things, their particularity, their specific value, and their incomparability. Its correlate in social relations is *Reserviertheit*, a reserve that holds others at a distance and shades at its limit into aversion.

This is the mechanism of Richard Mayhew's erasure, rendered with a precision that the novel's fantastic premise might seem to preclude. After he carries Door off the pavement, the people of London Above do not cease to see him. His flat is shown to prospective tenants while he is still living in it; his desk at work is cleared, and colleagues who sat beside him fail to know him; cabs slide past his raised arm; his fiancée looks at him without recognition. They perceive him, but his difference fails to register; he has become one of the things whose meaning is felt as void. The novel's ontology of invisibility is the blasé attitude perfected into a law of nature. Fittingly, the world from which Richard is erased is the City, the square mile in which the money economy Simmel analysed is more concentrated than anywhere else in Britain.

Erving Goffman's sociology of public life makes the gradient of the erasure precise. In *Behavior in Public Places* (1963), Goffman described civil inattention, the ritual by which strangers grant one another just enough visual notice to acknowledge each other's presence before withdrawing their attention as a mark of respect. In *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life* (1956), he had identified a quite different treatment, accorded to *non-persons* such as servants, who are physically present but treated as though absent. Richard's life before the novel opens is a life of civil inattention, the anonymity of the commuter. His erasure transfers him to the category of the non-person, present to the senses and absent to significance.

Literature anticipated the sociology. In G. K. Chesterton's Father Brown story "The Invisible Man" (1911), four watchers swear in good faith that no one entered a building in which a murder was committed: the murderer was a postman, whom they saw and did not notice. "Nobody ever notices postmen somehow," Father Brown observes, and his explanation is that the man was invisible mentally rather than optically, perceived as a function rather than as a person. Kafka's *Die Verwandlung* (1915) traces the same process through a family rather than a city. Gregor Samsa, a commercial traveller as wholly absorbed by his employment as Richard by his,

wakes transformed, loses his position, and is progressively unrecognised by those who loved him, until his sister asks how the creature in his room could possibly be Gregor. Richard's metamorphosis is purely social: nothing in his body changes, only his place in the distribution of the perceptible. The comparison clarifies the novel's achievement. Kafka needed a vermin to show how a family can cease to see a son; Gaiman shows that a city needs no metamorphosis at all.

The American tradition gave the condition its most searching statement. The narrator of Ralph Ellison's *Invisible Man* (1952) explains in his prologue that his invisibility belongs not to his body but to the inward vision of those who look at him, and he lives in a forgotten section of a basement lit by bulbs that run on electricity stolen from Monopolated Light & Power. Ellison anticipates Gaiman's undercity in its essentials: invisibility is a relation rather than a property; the invisible live below; and they light their world with what the monopolists above do not notice they have lost.

3.3

The police of the sensible

Jacques Rancière's political philosophy supplies the concept that unifies these observations. In *La Mésentente* (1995) and *Le Partage du sensible* (2000), Rancière describes every social order as a *partage du sensible*, a distribution of the sensible, *partage* meaning at once a sharing and a partition. Each order determines what is visible and what is not, what counts as speech and what as noise, who has a part in the common and who has none. Rancière calls the maintenance of such an order *police*, in a sense broader than the constabulary, and reserves the name *politics* for the rare interruptions in which the part of those who have no part makes itself seen and heard. The emblematic act of the police, for Rancière, is the injunction to move along because there is nothing to see; politics consists in showing that there is something to see after all.

London Below is the part of those who have no part, given a city of its own, and the account of Richard's erasure is a sustained dramatization of the police injunction. Its genealogy runs through Dickens. In the chapter of *Bleak House* (1852–1853) titled "Moving On," a constable orders the crossing-sweeper Jo to move on, and Jo protests that he has been moving on all his life and asks where, in a city that will have him nowhere, he can possibly go. Jo's question has no answer in London Above. *Neverwhere* answers it by imagining a destination: below.

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) and Jean-Luc Nancy's essay "L'Être abandonné" (1983) give the same condition its juridical form. The banned, in the archaic sense that Nancy recovers, are not simply cast out of the law; they are abandoned to it, delivered over to a power that has suspended its protection while retaining its hold, and Agamben made this inclusive exclusion the hidden structure of sovereignty, in which bare life is included in the political order precisely by being exposed. London Below's inhabitants live in this condition. They are not outlaws: the law of London Above still applies to them, its police can still move them on,

and its institutions still shape the gaps into which they fall. What they lack is the law's regard. Their invisibility is the phenomenology of abandonment, and their city is what abandonment builds when the abandoned have only one another.

The injunction has an older form. In the third canto of the *Inferno*, Dante and Virgil pass through the vestibule of hell, where the souls of those "che visser sanza 'nfamia e sanza lodo" (III.36), who lived without infamy and without praise, are rejected alike by heaven and by hell. Virgil dismisses them in a line that compresses the ethic of the official city: "non ragioniam di lor, ma guarda e passa" (III.51), let us not speak of them, but look and pass. They run behind a whirling banner in a train so long that Dante would not have believed death had undone so many (III.52–57), and Virgil calls them "questi sciaurati, che mai non fur vivi" (III.64), these wretches who were never alive. T. S. Eliot transposed the canto to the City of London in *The Waste Land* (1922): "Unreal City, / Under the brown fog of a winter dawn, / A crowd flowed over London Bridge, so many, / I had not thought death had undone so many," and "each man fixed his eyes before his feet." Eliot's crowd is the commuting workforce of the City, Richard Mayhew's own milieu.

The convergence of these texts locates the novel's moral topography exactly. London Above is the vestibule of the *Inferno* relocated to the financial district. Its citizens are Dante's *ignavi* and Eliot's commuters, the uncommitted who live without infamy and without praise, and its governing maxim is Virgil's *guarda e passa*. Richard at the opening is one of them, an amiable man content to let his fiancée organize his life. His first moral act is a refusal of the maxim: he looks, and he does not pass. In the vestibule Dante recognises the shade of him "che fece per viltade il gran rifiuto" (III.60), who made the great refusal out of cowardice. Richard's story culminates in a great refusal made out of courage, the refusal of a life that the vestibule calls living, whose meaning Chapter Seven considers.

The Gospel supplies the paradigm. In the parable of the Good Samaritan, a priest comes upon a man who "fell among thieves" and "passed by on the other side," and a Levite does likewise; the Samaritan, "when he saw him, he had compassion on him" (Luke 10:30–33, AV). The parable answers the lawyer's question "who is my neighbour?" (10:29) by redefining the neighbour not as a member of a category but as the agent of an act, "He that shewed mercy on him" (10:37). Neighbourhood is constituted by attention rather than by proximity, kinship, or law, and this is the constitutive principle of London Below as a community. Its members are bound not by residence, since its places move, nor by blood, since many have been severed from their families, but by the reciprocal acts of notice, favour, and aid through which they acknowledge one another.

The antagonist of that principle is Jessica, and her prototype is Baudelaire's. In the prose poem "Les Yeux des pauvres" (*Le Spleen de Paris*, 1869), a man sits with his beloved at a glittering new café on a new boulevard when a poor father and his two children stop outside to gaze at its splendour. The narrator is moved, and a little ashamed of the glasses and carafes before him.

His beloved is not. "Ces gens-là me sont insupportables avec leurs yeux ouverts comme des portes cochères!" she exclaims, and she asks him to have the proprietor send them away. The eyes of the poor, open like carriage gates, are doors, and the beloved's demand is the police injunction spoken in the register of taste. When Richard finds a bleeding girl on the pavement on the way to dinner with the newspaper magnate Jessica works for, Jessica first steps over her, taking her for a drunk with a home to go to; then, anxious not to be late, she insists that someone else will help, offers as a compromise that he call an ambulance without giving his name, and finally makes their engagement conditional on his walking on (novel, ch. 1). Richard does not deliberate. The novel says he did not stop to think and that the act was not a matter of his volition, while passers-by stare at the man carrying a bloodied girl and do nothing. The girl's name is Door. Baudelaire's simile has become a person, and the novel's plot begins at the moment when the man, unlike Baudelaire's narrator, chooses the eyes of the poor over the beloved who cannot bear them.

3.4

Attention and the face

If the characteristic faculty of London Above is anaesthesia, the faculty London Below demands is attention. Wordsworth, recording his residence in London in the seventh book of *The Prelude* (1850), registered both. Amid the overflowing streets he would say to himself, "The face of every one / That passes by me is a mystery!", and he recalled being stopped by a blind beggar propped against a wall, wearing on his chest a written paper that told his story, whence he came and who he was. The poet found in the paper "an apt type" of "the utmost we can know, / Both of ourselves and of the universe," and he gazed on the beggar's face "As if admonished from another world." The passage contains the novel's phenomenology entire: the passer-by's face is a mystery, the dispossessed man is reduced to a label, and the attentive look discovers in him an admonition from another world. Gaiman literalizes Wordsworth's simile. The other world from which the beggar admonishes is London Below.

The modern philosophy of the face developed what Wordsworth intuited. For Emmanuel Levinas, in *Totalité et infini* (1961), the face of the other person is not an object in the visual field but an epiphany that exceeds every idea the observer can form of it, and its expression is at once destitution and command: the face of the widow, the orphan, and the stranger addresses the observer from a height and forbids violence before any choice has been made. London Above's inability to retain the faces of those below is, in Levinasian terms, an evasion of that command, accomplished by making the face forgettable before it can speak. The novel's erasures are literal effacements, and London Below is a city of restored faces. Here the ethical sense of the face and the rhetorical sense examined in Chapter Two coincide. Richard's stopping for Door is

a prosopopoeia performed in the register of action: he confers face and claim on a body the street had already reclassified as an obstruction.

Simone Weil, whom Levinas read and contested, gave the ethics of attention its most rigorous form. In her reflections on the right use of school studies (1942), Weil argued that the fullness of neighbourly love lies in the capacity to ask a sufferer what he is enduring, which requires perceiving him not as one item of a class, a sample of the administrative category of the unfortunate, but as someone wholly like oneself on whom affliction has set its mark; and that this perception depends on a particular manner of looking, which is attention. Weil's warning against the category recalls Wordsworth's label and names the logic of London Above, which perceives the dispossessed only as a classification. Iris Murdoch, who took the term from Weil in *The Sovereignty of Good* (1970), understood attention as a gaze at once just and loving, fixed on a particular reality other than the self, and described moral change as a patient, largely invisible discipline of looking again, in which the anxious ego loosens its grip and the world reappears.

Weil derived her question from the Grail. In the oldest versions of the legend, she noted, the Grail belongs to whoever first asks its guardian, a king paralysed by a grievous wound, what he is suffering. In Wolfram von Eschenbach's *Parzival* (c. 1200–1210), the hero fails to ask on his first visit to the wounded Anfortas and asks only at the end of his long errancy: "œheim, waz wirret dir?", uncle, what ails you? The question heals the king. Wagner's *Parsifal* (1882) condensed the theme into the formula of the hero's election, "Durch Mitleid wissend, der reine Tor": made wise through compassion, the pure fool. Richard Mayhew is the novel's *reiner Tor*, the guileless outsider whose compassion opens a quest the wise could not have begun. He too finds a person of noble blood wounded on the threshold of a hidden realm, and he too must ask rather than pass by. The German language offers a further correspondence that the novel cannot have intended and that its Cratylan method nonetheless licenses. *Der Tor* is the fool; *das Tor* is the gate. The pure fool follows the Door.

Blake had already named the alternative to such attention. "How do you know but ev'ry Bird that cuts the airy way, / Is an immense world of delight, clos'd by your senses five?" asks *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell* (plate 7). Anaesthesia, in Blake's terms, is the closure of the senses that reduces every being to what the five senses report of it; attention is the cleansing of the doors of perception that discloses the immense world within.

3 . 5

Anaesthesia's toll

The loss of Anaesthesia on the Night's Bridge invites a reading that the novel's onomastics make almost irresistible and its ethics make uncomfortable. Allegorically, the episode depicts the end of Richard's insensibility: he crosses from the city of the blasé into the city of the perceived, and what he leaves in the dark is anaesthesia itself. The name makes the allegory, and the allegory

makes the girl a means. The crossing is made in company. A woman in leather, not yet named but later revealed as Hunter, joins them at the bridge and warns them in the dark not to draw the attention of what moves there; the darkness fills Richard with visions, among them Jessica's contempt and, prophetically, the Beast charging him in a labyrinth while he grips a spear (novel, ch. 4). When the light returns, the girl's hand is gone from his, and a scatter of quartz beads from her necklace rolls down the curve of the bridge. The necklace was her pride; she had bartered for it at an earlier Floating Market. Richard keeps one bead. The novel exacts the price of Richard's awakening from the most vulnerable person in his company, and London Below treats her loss as unremarkable. Hunter tells him that the bridge takes its toll and that he should be grateful it did not take him; the rats, through Door's translation, say that the night took her as tribute, that they do not blame him, and that sometimes the taken come back (ch. 8); and the Lord Rat-speaker later assures him that there are no hard feelings, at which Richard reflects bitterly that she had been expendable (ch. 19). The novel registers the injustice through its focalizer even as its world absorbs it. The bead returns at the crisis of the Ordeal, examined in Chapter Seven, where the memory of the dead girl holds Richard to the truth of what he has seen; the debt to her is honoured by his survival, not by hers. The episode thus reproduces, inside the city of attention, the very structure the city exists to resist, the disappearance of the least visible person in the service of another's passage, and then converts her into his talisman. The novel concedes that attention has a cost, and that the cost does not fall evenly, an asymmetry to which Chapter Eight returns.

The Night's Bridge belongs to a long typology of bridges between the living and the dead, and its divergence from that typology is instructive. The Chinvat bridge of Zoroastrian eschatology broadens for the righteous and narrows to a blade's edge for the wicked; the Sirat of Islamic tradition is finer than a hair and sharper than a sword, crossed by the just while the damned fall; and the Brig o' Dread of the Lyke Wake Dirge, the Yorkshire watch-night song recorded by John Aubrey in the seventeenth century, must be crossed by every soul on its night journey. In the *Gylfaginning* of Snorri Sturluson, Hermóðr rides nine nights through dark valleys to the bridge over the river Gjöll, whose guardian remarks that five companies of the dead crossed it the day before with less clamour than he makes alone, and that he lacks the colour of a dead man. These are bridges of judgment: they sort the crossers by desert, and they register the difference between the living and the dead. The Night's Bridge does neither. Its darkness takes its toll without regard to innocence, and Anaesthesia, the gentlest person in the novel, is taken while Richard passes. The bridge is not a tribunal but a tollgate, and its eschatology is fiscal rather than moral. Its nearest classical analogue is Charon's fee, the obol placed in the mouth of the dead, a coin that bore a face; on the Night's Bridge the toll is paid in faces. The moral universe of London Below is accordingly not providential but transactional, a world of tolls, debts, and favours whose logic Chapter Five reconstructs.

> *On the Night's Bridge the toll is paid in faces.*



FIGURE 3 *Bridges of the dead. The traditional crossings sort souls by desert; the Night's Bridge takes its toll regardless (section 3.5).*

The Dirge is not merely a parallel. It is the novel's second epigraph, after Chesterton's, and it returns twice inside the story. As Richard runs through the labyrinth after Hunter's death, a rhyme he heard as a child sounds in his head to the rhythm of his feet, the Dirge's refrain of "fire and fleet and candle-light"; and when Door strikes a match in the angel's emptied hall after the climax, the same words come back to him without his knowing why (novel, chs. 16–17). A lyke-wake is the watch kept over a corpse, and the refrain is sung for the dead. The stanzas Gaiman chose for his epigraph are those that make the soul's safety on its journey depend on its charity in life: whoever gave "hosen and shoon" may put them on against the thorns of Whinny-moor, and whoever gave meat or drink will not shrink from the fire. The epigraph omits the stanzas of the bridge itself, and it has been observed that even in Aubrey's text nothing happens at the Brig o' Dread, as if a stanza had been lost. *Neverwhere* supplies the missing crossing, and on its bridge something happens. The ethic the epigraph sets out is enacted in the prologue, where Richard, unable to give the old woman money, gives her his umbrella, and she tells him that a good heart is sometimes enough to see one safe wherever one goes, but mostly not (novel, prologue). The novel's ethics of attention has a ballad source as old as Aubrey's manuscript, and the novel states

that ethic's limit in its first scene; on the Night's Bridge the limit is enforced, since the darkness does not ask who gave hosen and shoon.

Martin Heidegger's lecture "Bauen Wohnen Denken" (1951) took the bridge as the paradigm of the thing that gathers. The bridge, he argued, draws banks, stream, and landscape together into a neighbourhood, and it escorts the comings and goings of mortals to the other side, including at last the crossing that mortals make in death. The Night's Bridge literalizes Heidegger's final clause and discards the rest: it gathers nothing; it subtracts. As the novel's first threshold, it defines by contrast the threshold that follows. Georg Simmel's short essay "Brücke und Tür" (1909), whose title names the novel's first two thresholds in order, distinguished the bridge, which connects what was separated, from the door, which both separates and connects and which can at any moment be opened, and it concluded that the human being is "das Grenzwesen, das keine Grenze hat," the bordering creature who has no border. The bridge on which Anaesthesia is lost is a crossing that cannot be reversed; the door that Richard opened when he stopped on the pavement is a threshold that remains, in Simmel's sense, perpetually open. Chapter Four turns to that door and to the god of doors.

The ethical stakes of the chapter are condensed in the final page of Italo Calvino's *Le città invisibili* (1972). Marco Polo tells Kublai Khan that the inferno of the living already exists, made daily by our life in common, and that one may escape its suffering in either of two ways. One may sink into it so completely that it ceases to be visible; or, at constant risk and with unremitting vigilance, one may learn to discern the persons and things within it that do not belong to it, and then sustain them and make room for them. Calvino's two ways are anaesthesia and attention. London Above has taken the first, and Richard Mayhew, without knowing it, has taken the second. *Neverwhere* is the record of his apprenticeship.

CHAPTER FOUR



IV

The Dismembered Hermes

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The Dismembered Hermes

Thresholds, Tricksters, and the Hermetic Polity

London Below is organized around the offices of a single god. Hermes, whose faces Athens struck from their pillars in 415 BCE, survives in Gaiman's London in pieces, his functions distributed among the novel's principal agents, and the pieces, taken together, constitute a city whose only foundation is passage.

4.1

The night of the herms

In a single night of 415 BCE, as Athens prepared the great armament that was to sail against Syracuse, most of the stone herms of the city had their faces mutilated. Thucydides describes the objects precisely: square-cut pillars, made according to local custom, which stood in great numbers "ἐν ἰδίοις προθύροις καὶ ἐν ἱεροῖς," in the porches of private houses and in sanctuaries (VI. 27.1). Each bore the bearded head of Hermes and, lower down, an erect phallus; a joke in Aristophanes' *Lysistrata* (1093–1094), advising the aroused Athenian envoys to cover themselves lest the "herm-choppers" see them, suggests that faces were not the only parts struck off. The city received the sacrilege as an omen for the expedition and as evidence of a conspiracy to overthrow the democracy (VI.27.3). Informers were rewarded, citizens executed or exiled, and Alcibiades, implicated in a related charge of parodying the Eleusinian Mysteries, was recalled from his command, escaped, and defected to Sparta (VI.28–29, 53, 60–61). Andocides' speech *On the Mysteries* (399 BCE) preserves the account of one of the accused who turned informer.

Thucydides' verb is exact: the herms *periekopēsan ta prosōpa*, were cut about the faces. The god who presided over thresholds stood at the doorway as a face upon a post, and what the conspirators destroyed was the face of the threshold, its *prosōpon*. Chapter Two argued that the novel's master trope is the restoration of face to what usage has defaced; the herms of 415 are the originary scene of that defacement, the moment when a city's doorways lost their faces in a

single night. *Neverwhere* restages the scene with a structural fidelity that its comic surface conceals. The novel's action is set in motion by the massacre of Door's family, the House of the Arch, whose head was Lord Portico, at the hands of Mr Croup and Mr Vandemar, acting for a patron whose identity the plot withholds. *Portico* translates the *prothuron* where the herm stood, and the slaughter of the household of the lord who bears that name is a mutilation of the herms: an assault on the guardians of the threshold, committed in secret, that prepares an expedition of hubris and conceals a conspiracy against the established order. The Athenian expedition ended in catastrophe in the Great Harbour of Syracuse in 413; Islington's, as Chapter Six shows, ends at a door. The survivor of the massacre is the herm that escaped the chisel. Door is the face that remained on the threshold.

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Door is the face that remained on the threshold.

4 . 2

The unemployed god

The most illuminating classical text for the novel's distribution of divine functions is not a hymn but a comedy. In Aristophanes' *Plutus* (388 BCE), the honest and impoverished Athenian Chremylus contrives to cure the god of wealth of his blindness, so that Plutus thereafter enriches only the just. The consequence is a catastrophe for the gods: no one any longer needs to sacrifice, and Olympus starves. Hermes arrives at Chremylus's door, hungry and resentful, and proposes to desert to the household of mortals. Asked by the slave Cario what use he could be, he offers his epithets one after another (1153–1163). He could be *Strophaios*, the god of the hinge, stationed by the door; Cario replies that the house has no further need of twists and turns. He could be *Empolaios*, the god of trade; but the household is rich and needs no huckster. He could be *Dolios*, the god of guile; but this is the season of honest ways, not tricks. He could be *Hegemonios*, the god who guides; but the god of wealth can see now and needs no guide. Finally he offers himself as *Enagonios*, patron of contests, and this Cario accepts, since nothing suits Wealth better than musical and athletic competitions. What a fine thing it is, Cario remarks, to have many surnames: this one has found himself a living (1164–1165). Hermes is then set to washing tripe at the well.

The scene yields three propositions. First, a god survives unemployment through his names. Hermes's epithets are his means of livelihood, and the comedy is Cratylan to its core, since each surname is a job. Second, the five epithets enumerate the offices of the god with an economy no theogony matches: the hinge, the market, the trick, the guide, the contest. Third, Hermes is

made redundant by a just distribution of wealth. When Wealth sees, mediation becomes superfluous; Hermes is the god of a world in which wealth is blind and must be reached through doors, deals, ruses, guides, and contests. London Above is such a world, yet there too Hermes is unemployed, for a different reason: the self-regulating market, the automatic door, and the money form have abstracted his offices into mechanisms that require no god. His functions therefore migrate downward, to the city of those who have fallen out of the economy, where mediation remains personal. Aristophanes' unemployed god finds work among London's unemployed.

There he is dismembered. The Greek imagination knew that a god torn apart need not fall silent. When the Maenads tore Orpheus limb from limb, his head and lyre floated down the Hebrus, the lyre still lamenting and the lifeless tongue still murmuring, while the riverbanks murmured in reply (Ovid, *Metamorphoses* XI.50–53); the lyre was Hermes's invention. The novel's distribution of the god's offices is a *sparagmos* of the same kind. Scattered, the members of Hermes go on singing, and their concert is a city.

TABLE 2 *The five offices of Hermes in Aristophanes'* Plutus *and their bearers in* Neverwhere.

EPITHET IN PLUTUS	OFFICE	BEARER IN NEVERWHERE	PRINCIPAL ANALOGUES
Strophaios, of the hinge	The threshold: opening, closing, passage between worlds	Door, of the House of the Arch, daughter of Lord Portico	Janus *bifrons*; Cardea, goddess of the hinge; Kafka's doorkeeper, inverted
Empolaios, of trade	Exchange: the market, the windfall, trade at the boundary	The Floating Market and its truce	Hermes *Agoraios*; the medieval market peace; Bakhtin's carnival marketplace
Dolios, of guile	The trick: misdirection, self-fashioning, the borrowed name	The Marquis de Carabas	Perrault's cat; the infant cattle-thief of the *Homeric Hymn*; Radin's Wakdjunkaga
Hegemonios, of guidance	Guidance: message, escort, the conduct of souls	Anaesthesia, Lamia, Old Bailey, the rats and their speakers	Hermes *Psychopompos*; Virgil and the Sibyl; Browning's Pied Piper
Enagonios, of contests	The contest: trial, ordeal, the hunt	Hunter	Atalanta and the Calydonian boar; Hesiod's good Strife; Nietzsche's "Homer's Contest"

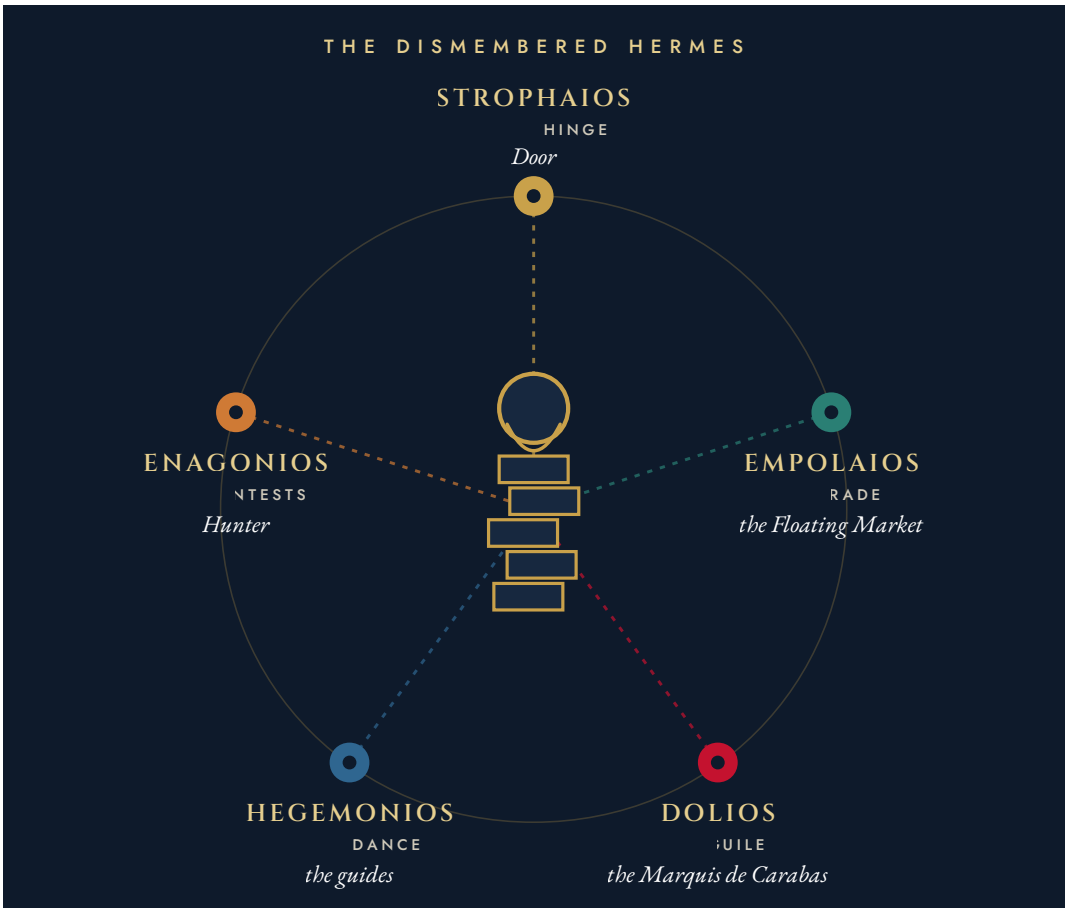


FIGURE 4 *The dismembered Hermes: the five offices Aristophanes' unemployed god offers in the* Plutus*, distributed among the bearers of London Below (section 4.2).*

The second office, the market, is the subject of Chapter Five; the other four are examined here.

4.3

Strophaios: Door and the hinge

Door is the surviving heir of a lineage whose members can open what is shut, whether a lock, a wall, or the space between one part of London and another. Her name is her nature in the strictest Cratylan sense, and her family's names are drawn from the architecture of passage: she is of the House of the Arch, her father was Lord Portico, her mother Portia, her brother Arch, and her sister Ingress (novel, ch. 4). Islington, explaining why it spared her, describes the family's gift with precision: they can open locked doors and make doors where there were none (ch. 17). She is the god of the hinge made flesh and given to a girl.

The Roman religion of the door provides her closest typology. Janus, whose name Romans connected with *ianua*, the door, explains himself in Ovid's *Fasti*: "quidquid ubique vides, caelum, mare, nubila, terras, / omnia sunt nostra clausa patentque manu" (I.117–118), whatever you see anywhere, sky, sea, clouds, lands, all are shut and opened by my hand. He presides, he adds, over the doors of heaven, "praesideo foribus caeli" (I.125), and he is called now Patulcius, the opener, now Clusius, the closer, according to his office. His two faces have an architectural rationale: "omnis habet geminas, hinc atque hinc, ianua frontes" (I.135), every door has twin faces, one turned to the street and one to the household. A door is a *prosōpon* that faces two ways at once. Door is two-faced in this exact and honourable sense: she faces both Londons, belongs to both, and is the hinge on which their relation turns. Beside Janus stood a female deity of the hinge itself. "Dea cardinis haec est," Ovid writes of Carna, or Cardea: "numine clausa aperit, claudit aperta suo" (VI.101–102), this is the goddess of the hinge; by her power she opens what is shut and shuts what is open. Ovid's aetiology names what was done to her, and by whom. The nymph Crane, as Carna was first called, escaped unwanted suitors by sending them ahead into a cave and hiding; Janus, whose second face saw her hiding behind him, seized and raped her, and then paid her for it: "ius pro concubitu nostro tibi cardinis esto: / hoc pretium positae virginitatis habe," let the right of the hinge be yours in return for our lying together; take this as the price of your lost virginity (VI.119–128). With the hinge came the whitethorn that wards off the *striges*, the bird-demons that drain the blood of infants (VI.129–168). In the Roman myth, then, the power of the threshold is conferred on a woman by her rapist as a *pretium*, a price, and the rape is narrated as a settlement of accounts. The myth binds together two economies this dissertation keeps apart, the economy of the threshold and the economy of forfeiture examined in Chapter Five, and it binds them through a woman's body. Door's power is exercised in the aftermath of violence, against assassins, and in a world where the Velvets drink the warmth of the living, but it was not paid to her by a violator: it is the inheritance of her house, and she turns it at last against the being who ordered that house destroyed. Chapter Eight returns to the gendered economy that this genealogy discloses.

Georg Simmel's "Brücke und Tür" (1909), introduced at the close of Chapter Three, supplies the philosophy of the hinge. The bridge, Simmel argued, connects what nature has separated and is indifferent to the direction in which it is crossed. The door is more complex. It separates the inside of a human space from everything outside, and in the same act connects them, since a door is a wall that can be opened; its possibility of opening is what gives the enclosure its freedom, and its meaning differs according to whether one passes through it inward or outward. Arnold van Gennep, writing in the same year, made the threshold the governing figure of *Les Rites de passage* (1909). The door, he argued, marks the boundary between the foreign world and the domestic, or between the profane and the sacred; to cross it is to join oneself to a new world; and the zones between territories place whoever traverses them in a special condition, magical and religious, for as long as the passage lasts: "il flotte entre deux mondes," he floats

between two worlds. Van Gennep's verb anticipates the Floating Market, and his phrase describes Richard Mayhew for the whole length of the novel.

The modern counter-type of Door is Kafka's doorkeeper. In "Vor dem Gesetz" (1915), a man from the country comes to the door of the Law, which stands open as always, and asks admittance; the doorkeeper says that he cannot be admitted now. The man waits for years, bribes the doorkeeper, studies the fleas in his fur collar, and grows old. Dying, he asks why in all those years no one else has sought admittance, and the doorkeeper roars into his failing ear: "Hier konnte niemand sonst Einlaß erhalten, denn dieser Eingang war nur für dich bestimmt. Ich gehe jetzt und schließe ihn." No one else could gain admittance here, since this entrance was meant only for you; I am now going to shut it. Kafka's door is the threshold of a society of formal openness: open in principle, impassable in fact, and closed at last by the very officer appointed to keep it. London Above's doors are Kafkan in this sense, open to all and passable only by those whom its distribution of the sensible already counts. Door is the anti-doorkeeper. Her gift negates the impassability of thresholds as such, which is why the powers of the novel covet her. And Richard Mayhew, who comes to London from Scotland, is Kafka's man from the country, with one difference that makes the novel possible: he does not wait.

4.4

Dolios: the Marquis de Carabas

The Marquis de Carabas, the novel's trickster, bears a name borrowed from a fairy tale. In Charles Perrault's "Le Maître chat ou le Chat botté" (*Histoires ou contes du temps passé*, 1697), a miller's youngest son inherits nothing but a cat, and the cat, having obtained boots and a sack, presents game to the king on behalf of "Monseigneur le Marquis de Carabas," a title, Perrault notes, "qu'il lui prit en gré de donner à son Maître," that he took it into his head to give his master. The cat then stages a drowning to procure fine clothes, terrifies the peasants of the countryside into declaring that their fields belong to the Marquis on pain of being "hachés menu comme chair à pâté," chopped as fine as mincemeat, and tricks an ogre into taking the shape of a mouse before eating him. The miller's son marries the princess. Perrault's first moral is that industry and savoir-faire are worth more to the young than goods inherited.

The Marquis de Carabas is thus the most purely conventional name in European literature: a title conferred by no authority, attached to no estate, made true by nothing but repetition and intimidation. J. L. Austin's *How to Do Things with Words* (1962) took the naming of a ship as a paradigm of the performative utterance, valid only when pronounced by the appointed person in the appropriate circumstances. The cat is no such person, and his naming is, in Austin's terms, a misfire that succeeds through uptake. Derrida's reply to Austin in "Signature événement contexte" (1971) argued that every performative works by citation, by the iterability of a formula that can be repeated in any context. Gaiman's Marquis carries Derrida's argument into onomas-

tics, for his name is a quotation. Within a Cratylan city where Door is a door and Hunter a hunter, he is the Hermogenean exception, the one inhabitant whose name is evidently assumed rather than inherited and who signifies by convention alone. Yet the exception confirms the rule at a higher level. A trickster's true name is a false one, and the Marquis's self-conferred title is accordingly the most Cratylan name in the book. Perrault's moral distinguishes the two sources of standing in London Below: the inheritance that makes Door what she is, and the savoir-faire that makes the Marquis a marquis.

The *Homeric Hymn to Hermes* supplies the trickster's archetype. Born at dawn, the infant god plays the lyre by midday and by evening has stolen the cattle of Apollo (17–19), driving them backwards with their hooves reversed and binding brushwood to his own feet to confuse the tracks (75–86). He lies to Zeus with a straight face and settles his quarrel with Apollo by inventing exchange, trading the lyre for the herd. The hymn's opening catalogue of epithets reads as an inventory of the novel: *polytropos*, of many turns; *haimulomētēs*, of wheedling cunning; *lēistēr*, the robber; *hēgētōr oneirōn*, the bringer of dreams; *nuktos opōpētēr*, the watcher by night; *pulēdokos*, the one who waits at the gates (13–15). The watcher by night and the waiter at gates name the Night's Bridge and Door, and the robber who settles his thefts by trade names the Marquis, whose services are rendered against favours, debts of honour that he collects and dispenses as other men handle money.

Twentieth-century anthropology made the trickster a universal category. Paul Radin's *The Trickster* (1956), which collected the Winnebago cycle of Wakdjunkaga with essays by C. G. Jung and Karl Kerényi, presented a figure who is at once creator and destroyer, giver and negator, who dupes others and is always himself duped. Lewis Hyde's *Trickster Makes This World* (1998) defined the trickster as the boundary-crosser par excellence, the spirit of the doorway and the crossroads, whose violations of boundary are the means by which cultures renew themselves. The Marquis fulfils both descriptions, and the most trickster-like of his acts is the cheating of death. Captured, tortured, and killed by Croup and Vandemar, who break the hour's head start they had promised him in exchange for a Tang dynasty figurine (Croup sends Vandemar after him six minutes into it), he is returned to life because he had long before entrusted to Old Bailey a box containing his life; when the Marquis's corpse, dumped in the sewers and fished out by the Sewer Folk, turns up for sale at the Floating Market aboard HMS Belfast, Old Bailey buys it and uses the box to revive him (novel, chs. 10, 13–14). The device belongs to the folklore of the external soul that James Frazer catalogued in *The Golden Bough* (1890; 3rd ed. 1906–1915), where the giant keeps his heart outside his body and Koschei the Deathless hides his death in an egg inside a duck inside a hare inside a chest. Gaiman's variation is juridical. The Marquis's survival is held in trust, in what English law calls a bailment, the delivery of goods into another's keeping on condition of their return, whose doctrine Chief Justice Holt systematized in *Coggs v Bernard* (1703). The coincidence of *bailey* and *bail* is paronomastic rather than etymological, *bailey* descending from a word for a palisade and *bail* from a verb of delivery, but it is precisely

the kind of coincidence the novel teaches its readers to hear. Old Bailey, the name of England's central criminal court, is in London Below the bailee of a life.

An earlier version of the cat's tale bears on the Marquis's fate. In Giambattista Basile's *Lo cunto de li cunti* (1634–1636), the cat who has made her master's fortune feigns death to test his gratitude and hears him order the corpse thrown out of the window by its paws; she rebukes him and departs. The trickster's services create debts that their beneficiaries are tempted to forget. The Marquis's economy of favour rests on the same precarious memory, and it is fitting that his restoration depends on the one institution in London Below that remembers by contract.

4.5

Hegemonios: guides, messengers, psychopomps

Hermes is the god who leads. At the opening of the last book of the *Odyssey*, he calls the souls of the slaughtered suitors out of Odysseus's hall with his golden wand, and they follow him gibbering like bats in the recesses of a cave, past the streams of Ocean and the White Rock, past the gates of the Sun and the land of dreams, to the meadow of asphodel (XXIV.1–14). In the *Homeric Hymn to Demeter*, it is Hermes whom Zeus sends down into Erebus to bring Persephone back to the light (334–383): he is the only god who passes freely in both directions across the boundary of death. The tradition of the guide runs from the Sibyl who leads Aeneas down, warning that the descent is easy and the return the labour ("facilis descensus Averno," *Aeneid* VI.126), to the Virgil whom Dante follows.

Neverwhere has no single Virgil. Its guidance is distributed among many guides, most of whom fail, perish, or betray. Anaesthesia leads Richard to the market and is lost on the Night's Bridge. Lamia, one of the vampire-like Velvets, whom Richard himself engages to guide the company to the angel's residence, names her price in his warmth, and the price proves to be more than he can pay and live; only the Marquis's arrival saves him. She is Hermes Psychopompos turned predator, the conductor of souls who conducts them into her own cold. Her name descends from the child-devouring daemon of Greek folklore by way of John Keats, whose *Lamia* (1820) asked whether all charms do not fly "At the mere touch of cold philosophy," and foresaw that philosophy would "clip an Angel's wings, / Conquer all mysteries by rule and line, / Empty the haunted air, and gnomed mine" (II.229–236). Keats's lines unite, in a single prophecy of disenchantment, the angel whom Chapter Six examines and the haunted mine that London Below inhabits. Old Bailey, the rooftop bird-catcher who keeps the Marquis's life in a box, is a psychopomp of the reverse direction, a Hermes who returns a soul to the living, as Hermes returned Persephone. Messages travel by bird and by rat: Door's first summons to the Marquis goes by street pigeon, and the rats and their speakers form a chthonic network through which word passes from one end of London Below to the other.

The rats have a precursor whose story binds guidance to debt. In Robert Browning's "The Pied Piper of Hamelin" (1842), a piper rids the town of its rats by leading them into the river, and when the town refuses to pay the agreed fee, he leads its children to Koppelberg Hill, where "A wondrous portal opened wide, / As if a cavern was suddenly hollowed; / And the Piper advanced and the children followed, / And when all were in to the very last, / The door in the mountain-side shut fast." The Piper is a Hermetic figure, a player of the pipe that Hermes invents at the close of his hymn (511–512) and a conductor of souls, and his story is the fable of a city that would not honour its debts and lost its children through a door. London Below is Hamelin's mountain seen from inside. Its inhabitants are what the city above declined to pay for, and the door that received them has not reopened.

The distribution of guidance has a moral consequence. Where every guide is partial, guidance becomes a communal and costly practice rather than a vocation vested in one master. The novel's hero is led by a frightened girl, a predator, an augur, a trickster, a noblewoman who opens doors, and a network of rodents, and his apprenticeship consists in learning which guides to trust. In the hermetic polity the office of the psychopomp belongs to no one and is exercised by everyone, at a price.

4.6

Enagonios: Hunter and the contest

Hunter enters the novel by winning a contest. At the Floating Market, Door holds a trial for a bodyguard, and Hunter, who has hunted the great beasts of the world, defeats the hired brute who expects the post. She is Hermes *Enagonios*, the patron of the games whose herms stood in the gymnasia, and the agonistic culture he presided over has been the subject of classic analysis. Hesiod distinguished two kinds of Strife (*Works and Days* 11–26): the evil Eris who fosters war, and the good Eris who rouses even the idle to work by envy of a neighbour's prosperity, so that potter vies with potter, carpenter with carpenter, and beggar envies beggar. Nietzsche's early essay "Homers Wettkampf" (1872) made the contest the vital principle of the Hellenic state and read ostracism as its safeguard: the Greeks banished the pre-eminent individual not to protect themselves from him but so that the play of rival forces could begin again. The contest requires plurality, and whoever would end it by an absolute victory destroys it.

Hunter's tragedy is the corruption of the agon by the desire for its end. Before she ever offered her services to Door, Croup reveals, she had agreed to work for the villain, and her price is the one prey she has never taken, the Great Beast of London, together with the spear with which to take it (novel, ch. 15). At Down Street, on the road to the angel, she pays for the spear by handing Door over to Croup and Vandemar, the men who murdered Door's family, and receives it in a fishing-rod case: a bronze blade with faces carved along its haft. The Marquis, arriving with a crossbow, makes her lay it down and tells Richard to carry it. She sells the good

Strife for a contest that would admit no successor, and she dies of it in the Labyrinth. The Beast's first charge breaks her; dying, she tells Richard to take up the spear, confesses that she betrayed Door because she wanted to be the one to kill the Beast, and resolves to make amends. She draws the Beast with a humming note that fills the maze, and as it strikes her she tells Richard when and how to thrust; the least agonistic man in the book makes the kill with the spear she bought (ch. 16). Dying, she names him the greatest hunter in London Below and gives him her knife, which she calls "she." The mythic template is exact. In the story Phoenix tells in the ninth book of the *Iliad* (IX.529–599), and in Ovid's elaborated version (*Metamorphoses* VIII.260–546), Oeneus of Calydon neglects the sacrifice due to Artemis, and the goddess sends a monstrous boar to ravage his land. Atalanta, the huntress, draws its first blood; Meleager kills it and awards her the spoils; and the prize sets off a chain of quarrel and death that consumes the hunters themselves. Hunter is Atalanta, Richard a reluctant Meleager, and the Great Beast, a colossal boar, belongs to the lineage of the Calydonian monster, the Erymanthian boar of Heracles's labours, the boar that killed Adonis, the Twrch Trwyth of *Culhwch and Olwen*, and the feral hogs of the London sewers recorded by Henry Mayhew.

The Calydonian myth adds a detail of the first importance. The boar is the visitation of a forgotten sacrifice. In *Plutus*, Hermes is unemployed because the city has ceased to sacrifice; in Calydon, a monster comes because one sacrifice was neglected. The Great Beast of London is the monster of the city's forgotten rites, the shape in which its neglected gods return, and its killing, which Chapter Seven reads as the culmination of Richard's initiation, is the novel's rite of reparation.

4.7

The hermetic polity

The four offices examined here, together with the market treated in Chapter Five, compose a polity of a singular kind. London Below has nobility but no sovereign, places but no territory, law but no legislature. Its market floats; its Earl holds court in a moving carriage of the Underground; its noblest house had rooms scattered across the city. Its institutions are all institutions of passage: the truce of the market, the toll of the bridge, the hospitality of the court, the ordeal of the key, the favour owed and repaid. It is a polity constituted not by a place but by the offices of the god of passage, and it may accordingly be called *hermetic*.

Jean-Pierre Vernant's essay "Hestia–Hermès" (1963) identified in Greek religion a polarity that clarifies what such a polity lacks. Hestia, the goddess of the hearth, embodies the centre, fixity, the interior, and continuity; Hermes, the god of the threshold and the road, embodies movement, exchange, and contact with the outside; and the *Homeric Hymn to Hestia* (29) invokes the two together as the friendly powers who dwell in the houses of men. London Below is Hermes without Hestia. Its inhabitants are, in the official language of London Above, the homeless,

those from whom the hearth has been withdrawn, and their polity has been obliged to make passage itself into a home. Where it has hearths, at the food stalls of the market or in the Earl's hospitality, they are portable: Hestia carried in Hermes's satchel. Vernant also observed that the polarity was gendered, Hestia female and Hermes male. Gaiman's assignment of the hinge to a girl unsettles that division, and Chapter Eight considers at what cost.

Victor Turner's anthropology of the liminal describes the social form that results. In *The Ritual Process* (1969), Turner characterized persons in the liminal phase of a rite of passage as betwixt and between the positions assigned by law, custom, and convention, and he named the spontaneous, egalitarian bond that unites them *communitas*. He observed that liminality could be institutionalized, as in monastic orders and mendicant movements, and that rituals of status reversal could crown the lowest and humble the highest. London Below is permanent liminality: a population held in the threshold and organized there, not into an egalitarian communitas but into a parodic hierarchy of marquises, earls, and lords, crowned like Hugo's beggar-king in the Cour des miracles. Its fools are sacred in Turner's sense. The Earl's jester, Tooley, takes his name from Tooley Street in Southwark, itself a centuries-long slurring of St Olave, so that a saint's name worn down by use has become the name of a fool: the paronomastic re-motivation of Chapter Two at its most melancholy.

Michel de Certeau's distinction between strategies and tactics, in *L'invention du quotidien* (1980), describes the polity's relation to its host. A strategy belongs to a subject with a place of its own, from which it can survey and administer an exterior; a tactic belongs to those without a proper place, who must operate on terrain organized by another, seizing opportunities on the wing and making do with what the other's order provides. London Below is a tactical city. It has no place of its own and occupies London Above's places in their off-hours: a department store after closing, a museum ship, a disused station, a rooftop, a sewer. Its emblematic practice is what de Certeau, borrowing workers' slang, called *la perruque*, "the wig": the employee's use of the employer's time and materials for purposes of his own. The Floating Market is the city's *perruque*.

The polity's relation to the official city's eye has a mythic form as well. Hermes's most famous epithet in Homer is *Argeiphontes*, traditionally understood as the slayer of Argus, the hundred-eyed watchman *Panoptes*, whom Hermes lulled to sleep with the pipe and a story before cutting off his head (Ovid, *Metamorphoses* I.668–723). The City of London, in which Richard Mayhew works, was in the years of the novel's composition among the most closely watched districts in Britain, cordoned after the IRA bombing at Bishopsgate in 1993 by the checkpoints and cameras known as the "ring of steel" (Christian Science Monitor, 8 July 1993). The inhabitants of London Below pass beneath that Argus unseen. Their invisibility, which Chapter Three described as a deprivation, is also a power, the power of the god who puts the all-seeing to sleep.

The deepest sense of *hermetic*, finally, is the esoteric one. The *Emerald Tablet* attributed to Hermes Trismegistus, the syncretic Hermes-Thoth of late antiquity, transmitted in Arabic by

the ninth century and in Latin from the twelfth, opens with the axiom on which every Hermetic correspondence rests: "quod est inferius est sicut quod est superius, et quod est superius est sicut quod est inferius," that which is below is like that which is above, and that which is above like that which is below. *Neverwhere* is a test of the axiom. London Below corresponds to London Above name for name and station for station, yet the correspondence is an inversion: Cratylan below, Hermogenean above; faces below, labels above. The *Tablet* continues that the one thing "ascendit a terra in coelum, iterumque descendit in terram," ascends from earth to heaven and descends again to earth, receiving the power of the higher and the lower. The hermetic polity lives by that double movement, a commerce between above and below that never ceases. Its enemy is the being who would ascend without descending again, and who for that purpose seeks to gather the scattered offices of Hermes into a single instrument: to buy the contest, to steer the hinge towards himself, and to murder the trickster when he comes too close. Where Isis gathered the members of the dismembered Osiris to restore a god (Plutarch, *De Iside et Osiride* 18), the Angel Islington gathers the dismembered offices of Hermes to make a weapon. Chapter Six examines that angel; Chapter Five first examines the office he could not capture, the market.

CHAPTER FIVE



V

Usure and the Gift

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The Floating Market and the Political Economy of the Remainder

The Floating Market is the economic institution of the hermetic polity: a market of the city's remainders, held in borrowed space and suspended time under a sacred truce, in which value is re-motivated as the novel's names are re-motivated, by restoring to each exchange the face that money had worn away.

5.1

Pluto's wealth

In the *Cratylus*, the god of the underworld bears two names, and Socrates' account of them anticipates the economy of London Below. *Ploutōn*, he says, was named for wealth, *ploutos*, because wealth comes up from beneath the earth (403a). The other name, *Haidēs*, the multitude derive from *aeidēs*, the unseen, and fear it accordingly, though Socrates prefers to derive it from the god's knowledge of all noble things (403a–404b). The undercity of *Neverwhere* unites both names. It is the realm of the unseen, as Chapter Three argued, and it is a realm of wealth, but its wealth consists of what has fallen from above: the city's lost, discarded, broken, and superseded things, and its lost, discarded, broken, and superseded people.

Baudelaire defined the figure who lives on such wealth. In "Du vin et du haschisch" (1851) he described the Parisian ragpicker as a man charged with gathering up the debris of the capital's day: "Tout ce que la grande cité a rejeté, tout ce qu'elle a perdu, tout ce qu'elle a dédaigné, tout ce qu'elle a brisé, il le catalogue, il le collectionne": everything the great city has rejected, lost, disdained, or broken, he catalogues and collects. Walter Benjamin made the ragpicker the emblem of the poet and of his own historical method. In a methodological note for the *Passagen-Werk*, he declared that he would not inventory the rags and refuse of the nineteenth century but would let them, in the only way possible, come into their own, "zu ihrem Rechte kommen lassen," by using them. The Floating Market is Benjamin's method as an institution, a market at which the

rags and refuse of London come into their own through use. The Greeks had a word for the goods it trades. A *hermaion*, a gift of Hermes, was a lucky find, a windfall, a thing come upon by chance; the market of the god of finds is a market of *hermaia*.

5.2

Borrowed space, suspended time

The Floating Market has no site. It convenes for a single night in a place made known beforehand, and the places it borrows are the official city's: in the novel, the department store of Harrods after closing, and later HMS Belfast, the cruiser moored on the Thames as a museum. An earlier market, Anaesthesia remembers, met inside the clock tower of Big Ben, among the great wheels that keep Westminster's time, and it was there that she bartered for the quartz necklace whose beads will matter later (novel, ch. 4). The first venue is emblematic. Harrods, the cathedral of the commodity in Knightsbridge, reached in the novel across the Night's Bridge, takes as its motto *Omnia Omnibus Ubique*, all things for all people, everywhere. The Floating Market fulfils the motto as the store cannot, offering everything, including the unsaleable, to everyone, including those without money, anywhere it pleases to convene. Benjamin called the department store the flâneur's last haunt, the place where the idler's roving gaze was finally captured by the commodity. The Floating Market occupies that haunt when its proprietors have gone home and turns the temple of the commodity into a fair.

Michel Foucault's lecture on heterotopias, "Des espaces autres" (delivered in 1967, published in 1984), names the kind of place the market creates. Heterotopias, Foucault argued, are real places that function as counter-sites, in which the other sites of a culture are at once represented, contested, and inverted. Among his examples were the fairground, which fills the vacant ground at a city's edge for a few days of festival; the museum, in which time accumulates without end; and above all the ship, a fragment of floating space, a place that is no place, which he called the heterotopia par excellence. The market aboard HMS Belfast stacks all three into a single floating site, a fair on a ship that is a museum. Neverwhere, the place without a place, has its capital wherever its market is held.

The market's form has a long genealogy in London itself. When the Thames froze hard enough, Londoners held Frost Fairs on the ice, in 1608, in the great winter of 1683–1684, in 1715–1716, in 1739–1740, in 1789, and for the last time in 1814: streets of booths raised on a river that had become, for as long as the cold lasted, a place where no place had been (Museum of London, "Frost Fairs"). Bartholomew Fair at Smithfield, held from the twelfth century until 1855 and anatomized in Ben Jonson's comedy of 1614, gathered the cutpurses, ballad-sellers, and puppet-masters of the city into a licensed carnival (Cavendish 2005). Its disputes were settled in a court of *piepowder*, from *pieds poudrés*, dusty feet: a summary tribunal held at fairs and markets to give swift justice to itinerant traders who could not wait upon the ordinary

courts (London Museum, "The Wild 700-Year-Long History of Bartholomew Fair"). The Floating Market inherits the law of the dusty-footed.

The novel's composition coincides with the most determined modern effort to suppress such assemblies. The Criminal Justice and Public Order Act 1994 created new offences of aggravated trespass and trespassory assembly, empowered the police to remove travellers from land, tightened the law against squatters, and, in a provision that became notorious, authorized the dispersal of open-air gatherings at which music "wholly or predominantly characterised by the emission of a succession of repetitive beats" was played. The free parties and raves of the early 1990s, convened in borrowed warehouses and fields at locations disclosed at the last moment, were the period's living Floating Markets. Gaiman's market, which convenes where it will and cannot be policed because it cannot be perceived, is a fantasy of exactly the assembly the statute was designed to prevent.

5 . 3

The market peace

The Floating Market has a single law, the Market Truce. Within it no violence may be done, and the truce holds because its breach is unthinkable; even enemies may stand side by side at its stalls. The institution has a precise historical analogue. Medieval Europe placed its markets under a special peace, the *Marktfriede* of German law, which protected all who came to buy and sell and punished its breach with exceptional severity; the market crosses that still stand in many English towns were its sign. In Athens the agora was bounded by boundary stones and watched over by Hermes *Agoraios*. Norman O. Brown's *Hermes the Thief* (1947) argued that the god's association with commerce descends from the boundary stone, the heap of stones (*herma*) beside which strangers once traded, and Herodotus described the archetype of such trade in his account of the Carthaginians beyond the Pillars of Heracles (IV.196). They laid their goods on the beach and withdrew; the natives set gold beside the goods and withdrew in turn; and the exchange proceeded without a word until both sides were satisfied, neither wronging the other. The market began as a peace at the boundary between peoples who had no other peace.

The Market Truce is the closest thing London Below has to a constitution, and it is a constitution without a sovereign. Pierre Clastres, in *La Société contre l'État* (1974), described societies that deliberately prevent the emergence of a separate coercive power, whose chiefs are peacemakers, orators, and generous givers but cannot command. London Below is such a society. Its Earl dispenses favour and hospitality but rules no one; its lords are courtesies; and its only binding law is a peace sustained by collective sanction rather than by a monarch. Mikhail Bakhtin's account of the carnival marketplace in *Rabelais and His World* (1965) describes the culture that grows in such a space: the marketplace as an unofficial second world, a second life of the people beyond officialdom, with its own speech, its own laughter, and its own suspension of the hier-

archies that govern the world outside. The Floating Market is periodic carnival, a recurrent second life, and London Below's parodic aristocracy is the carnival's crowned fool made permanent.

5 . 4

Favour, gift, and debt

The currency of London Below is not money. Goods are bartered, services traded, and the most valuable instrument of exchange is the favour, an obligation remembered rather than recorded. The Marquis de Carabas renders his services against favours owed, and the plot is driven by debts of honour among houses, guides, and guardians. Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1925) described the system to which this economy belongs: an order of *prestations totales* in which the obligations to give, to receive, and to reciprocate bind persons and groups into lasting relationships. What compels the return, Mauss argued, drawing on the Maori informant Tamati Ranapiri, is that "la chose reçue n'est pas inerte": the thing received is not inert, for it carries the *hau*, the spirit of the giver, which seeks to return to its source. Lewis Hyde's *The Gift* (1983) developed the contrast between the two economies. A gift establishes a bond and must keep moving, increasing as it passes from hand to hand; a commodity changes hands without creating any connection between buyer and seller, and the transaction ends when the price is paid. The favours of London Below are gifts in Hyde's sense: they bind, they travel, and they never quite close.

The novel's own transactions bear the analysis out. When the Sewer Folk fish the murdered Marquis out of the drains and offer his body at the market aboard HMS Belfast, Old Bailey haggles in mime: a half-used stick of deodorant is licked and refused, a bottle of Chanel No. 5 is sniffed and accepted, and the corpse changes hands (novel, ch. 14). The price is set by the buyer's senses rather than by a general equivalent, and the people who live in the sewers prize scent above all things. The market prices goods by the *aisthēsis* they answer to, the opposite of the anaesthetic abstraction Chapter Three described. Old Bailey also performs the gift in its purest form. Before Richard returns Above, the old man presses on him a black crow's feather bound with red thread and insists that it is free, a keepsake and a thank-you, owed nothing (ch. 19). In the last chapter, back in his restored life, Richard finds the feather in his pocket, calls it rubbish, and drops it in the gutter; a little later it is no longer there, and soon afterwards the way back to London Below opens (ch. 20). The novel leaves the connection unstated, but its sequence enacts Mauss's principle that the thing received is not inert, and Thompson's, that rubbish is the passage through which value returns.

> *They bind, they travel, and they never quite close.*

David Graeber's *Debt: The First 5,000 Years* (2011) supplies the distinction that separates the two Londons. An obligation becomes a debt, Graeber argued, at the moment it can be precisely quantified, and money is the instrument that makes obligations quantifiable, impersonal, and transferable to third parties. In what Graeber called human economies, money serves to create, maintain, and sever relationships between persons; in commercial economies it dissolves those relationships into calculable sums. London Above is a commercial economy of debt; London Below is a human economy of obligation. Graeber also identified three moral principles that coexist in every society: a baseline communism, in which help is given according to need without accounting; exchange, in which equivalence is sought; and hierarchy, in which precedent fixes relations between unequals. London Below combines all three with unusual transparency. Richard's original act of stopping for Door is baseline communism; the market is exchange; the court is hierarchy. Its economy differs from London Above's not because it lacks exchange but because exchange there has not been allowed to swallow the other two principles.

The obligation economy has its own cruelties, and the novel does not conceal them. Nietzsche argued in the second essay of *Zur Genealogie der Moral* (1887) that the moral concept *Schuld*, guilt, descends from the material concept *Schulden*, debts (II.4), and that the creditor-debtor relation is the oldest relation between persons, the place where person first stood against person and measured himself against person (II.8). In that archaic economy, the creditor who could not be repaid in goods was compensated with the debtor's body and pain (II.5). London Below's economy of persons retains the archaism. The Night's Bridge takes its toll in a girl; Lamia charges in warmth, the heat of the living body; Hunter's loyalty is bought with a spear and the promise of a kill, and paid for with Door, whom she hands to her family's murderers; the Marquis's life is held in pledge, and his murdered body is offered for sale at the Floating Market itself. Shakespeare dramatized the same archaism in *The Merchant of Venice* (c. 1596–1598), whose bond forfeits a pound of flesh, and whose resolution is a feat of literalism worthy of London Below: "This bond doth give thee here no jot of blood; / The words expressly are 'a pound of flesh'" (IV.i). The reader of Gaiman will note that the advocate who saves the debtor by taking the bond at its word bears a name that sounds, paronomastically if not etymologically, the Latin *porta*, the door. The comparison concerns the play's structure of forfeiture and literal interpretation, not the antisemitic caricature with which Shakespeare burdened its creditor, which this study does not reproduce.

5 . 5

Usure: money that breeds

The Floating Market's refusal of money joins a long tradition of argument against money's abstraction from persons. Aristotle distinguished the household art of acquisition, which need limits, from the chrematistic art of accumulation without limit, and he reserved his severest judgment for usury, which makes gain out of money itself rather than from the use for which money was devised. The Greek word for interest, *tokos*, means offspring, since money bred from money resembles its parent, and "of all modes of getting wealth this is the most unnatural" (*Politics* I.10, 1258b, trans. Jowett). Dante placed the usurers on the burning sand of the seventh circle, and his treatment of them is the darkest image of the Hermogenean metropolis in Western literature. Looking into their faces, Dante recognizes none of them, "non ne conobbi alcun" (*Inferno* XVII.54). He can identify them only by the purses hanging from their necks, each marked with "certo colore e certo segno" (XVII.56), a certain colour and a certain sign, the heraldic arms of a banking house, on which their eyes seem to feed. The usurer has lost his face and kept his coat of arms. He is known by his money's sign, not by his countenance: the effaced coin of Chapter Two made into a damned soul.

The Victorian critique translated this tradition into political economy. John Ruskin's *Unto This Last* (1860–1862) insisted that "THERE IS NO WEALTH BUT LIFE," and coined the word *illth* for the wealth that injures those who hold it and those from whom it is extracted. Karl Marx's analysis of the commodity in the first volume of *Capital* (1867) gave the tradition its most penetrating form. A commodity, Marx wrote, appears at first sight a trivial thing, but analysis shows it to be "a very queer thing, abounding in metaphysical subtleties and theological niceties"; in the commodity form "a definite social relation between men" assumes, in their eyes, "the fantastic form of a relation between things" (ch. 1, §4, trans. Moore and Aveling, 1887). A table, once it becomes a commodity, "stands on its head, and evolves out of its wooden brain grotesque ideas."

Neverwhere responds to Marx with characteristic literalism. The goods of the Floating Market are avowedly magical: charms, wonders, things with powers. Its commodities openly possess the theological character that Marx attributed covertly to every commodity, and the result is a paradox. A market of avowed fetishes is less mystified than a market whose fetishism is denied, because in London Below the magic of things is acknowledged as magic, and the relations among persons remain visible through the objects they exchange. Each thing at the market has a history, a finder, and a former owner; each exchange binds two faces. The Floating Market thus performs on the commodity the operation the novel performs on the name. It re-motivates value, restoring to the thing the faces of the persons whose relation it mediates, and so reverses the abstraction that Marx called fetishism and Derrida, in a different register, called *usure*. Chapter Two showed that Derrida's word means both the wearing of metaphor and the breed-

ing of interest. London Above's worn names and its interest-bearing money are one phenomenon at two levels, and London Below refuses both.

A caution is again required, and it must name what was done. The tradition against usury is not innocent. In medieval England, where the Church forbade Christians to lend at interest, Jewish moneylenders were made the visible face of credit, and they paid for it in blood. Jews were massacred in London at the coronation of Richard I in 1189. At York in March 1190, besieged by a mob in the royal castle on the site now called Clifford's Tower, many of the city's Jews took their own lives rather than be killed or forcibly baptized, and those who surrendered were murdered; the rioters, led by local gentry indebted to Jewish lenders, among them Richard Malebisse, then burned the records of their debts kept in the Minster, as William of Newburgh recorded. Edward I's Statute of the Jewry (1275) forbade Jews to lend at interest, and in 1290 he expelled them from England (Dobson 1974; Mundill 1998). A street in the City of London, Old Jewry, still bears the name of the community the expulsion emptied, and it belongs to the toponymic necropolis of Chapter Two. London Below, which re-motivates so many of the city's names, does not re-face this one, and that selection is itself a distribution of the sensible. Shakespeare gave the tradition its most durable stage caricature in Shylock. In the twentieth century Ezra Pound fused his denunciation of usury in the *Cantos*, most famously Canto XLV (1937), with antisemitism, and during the Second World War he broadcast antisemitic and pro-Fascist propaganda on Italian state radio (Doob 1978), for which he was indicted for treason in the United States and, found unfit to stand trial, confined in St Elizabeths Hospital until 1958. Any appeal to the tradition must refuse its scapegoat. *Neverwhere* does so: its agents of abstraction are an angel and two ageless killers in the service of a cosmic ambition, and its critique is directed at the severance of value from persons, not at any people.

5 . 6

The economy of the remainder

The Floating Market trades in what London Above has expelled, and its economy can be understood only through theories of the remainder. Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) defined dirt as matter out of place, the by-product of every systematic ordering, and observed that persons in marginal states, those left out of the patterning of society, are treated as dangerous and polluting in the same way. The inhabitants of London Below are persons out of place, and London Above's refusal to perceive them is a purity rule. Michael Thompson's *Rubbish Theory* (1979) showed that objects pass from a category of transient value, through a covert category of rubbish where they have no value at all, into a category of durable value; rubbish is the hidden passage through which worth is re-created. His examples included the run-down Victorian terraces of inner London, despised as slums before they were prized as period houses, a process for which the streets of Islington became a byword. The Floating Market is an institu-

tion of Thompson's middle category, the place where things of no value wait to be revalued, and the novel performs Thompson's transformation on its whole city, turning the refuse of London into wonder. The remainder includes the city's time. Door explains that London holds little pockets of old time, like bubbles in amber, because there is more time in the city than gets used up at once; one such pocket keeps a killing fog of the kind London Above has abolished, and when Door recalls that the fog of 1952 killed some four thousand people, Hunter adds that they were Richard's people (novel, ch. 11). London Below preserves even the city's disasters. Zygmunt Bauman's *Wasted Lives* (2004) extended the analysis to persons, arguing that the production of human waste, of populations rendered redundant, is an inseparable accompaniment of modernity's order-building and economic progress. London Below is the city of such lives, and its market is the means by which they refuse to remain waste.

Georges Bataille's *La Part maudite* (1949) supplies the term the economy of the remainder still lacks. Every society, Bataille argued, produces more energy than it needs to reproduce itself, and the surplus, the accursed share, must be spent, either gloriously, in festival, gift, sacrifice, and luxury, or catastrophically, in war; the restricted economy of utility conceals this general economy of expenditure but cannot abolish it. London Below is the accursed share of London Above in both of Bataille's senses: the surplus population the official economy cannot use, and the site where surplus is spent rather than accumulated. The Floating Market, a festival that consumes its goods in feasting and barter and accumulates nothing, is the city's sumptuary expenditure, and its tolls and forfeitures are the sacrificial side of the same economy.

Michel Serres's *Le Parasite* (1980) completes the theory, and it begins with a scene that might have been written for the novel. Serres opens with La Fontaine's fable of the town rat and the country rat (*Fables* I.9, 1668), in which the town rat entertains his guest on a Turkish carpet with "des reliefs d'ortolans," the leftovers of a rich man's feast, until "À la porte de la salle / Ils entendirent du bruit": at the door of the room they hear a noise, and the feast is broken off. From the leftovers, the guests, and the noise at the door, Serres builds a theory in which the parasite, at once the one who eats at another's table and the static that interrupts a channel, is not a deviation from social relation but its founding figure. In *Neverwhere* the rats are lords and the rat-speakers serve them. London Below is Serres's parasite, eating the leftovers of London Above's feast and listening for the noise at the door, and the novel's peculiar dignity is to treat the parasite as the city's nobility.

The two economies may now be set side by side.

TABLE 3 *Two economies, read across the gap.*

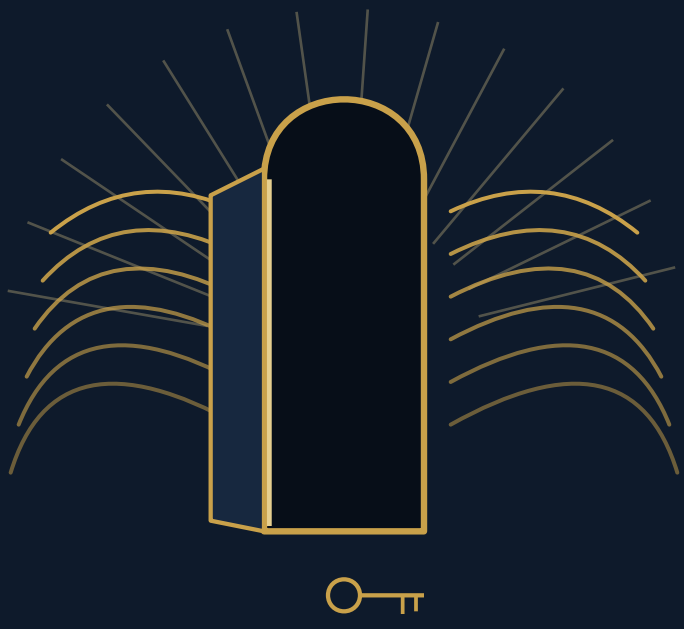
LONDON ABOVE	THE GAP	LONDON BELOW
Money: quantified, impersonal, transferable	MEDIUM OF EXCHANGE	Barter and favour: remembered, personal, binding

LONDON ABOVE	THE GAP	LONDON BELOW
Commodity whose social relations are hidden	STATUS OF THE THING	Found thing (*hermaion*) whose history and owners remain visible
Fixed premises, owned and administered	SITE	Borrowed premises, occupied tactically and briefly
Opening hours	TIME	The interval after closing
Contract, enforced by the state	LAW	The Market Truce, sustained by the market itself
Refuse to be removed; persons to be moved on	TREATMENT OF THE REMAINDER	Stock to be revalued; persons to be named
Effacement: the debt that dissolves the person	CHARACTERISTIC VIOLENCE	Forfeiture: the toll paid in the person

The final row states the balance honestly. London Below is not a utopia of the gift. Its economy restores faces to things and persons, but it also exacts payment in faces, and its cruelties are the archaic cruelties of the creditor whom Nietzsche described. What it refuses is not violence but abstraction: in London Below one may be robbed, drained, or betrayed, but one is never merely a number.

Walter Benjamin's fragment "Kapitalismus als Religion" (1921) suggests why this refusal matters for the novel's theology. Capitalism, Benjamin wrote, is "vermutlich der erste Fall eines nicht entsühnenden, sondern verschuldenden Kultus": probably the first instance of a cult that creates not atonement but guilt, or, since *Schuld* means both, not expiation but debt. A cult of perpetual indebtedness can imagine release only as the total settlement of all accounts, the end of the world as the final balancing of the ledger. That apocalyptic accountancy is the programme of the Angel Islington, who seeks not exchange but restitution, not circulation but a return to heaven that would close every account and every gap. The Floating Market, whose accounts never close because its favours never quite come due, stands against him as circulation stands against settlement. Chapter Six examines the angel and the two messianisms between which the novel chooses.

CHAPTER SIX



VI

Angelology of the Undercity

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Angelology of the Undercity

Islington, Atlantis, and the Two Messianisms

The novel's villain is an angel, and its decisive event is the opening of a door in heaven's direction. This chapter argues that Islington embodies a strong, restorative, and apocalyptic messianism, the will to abolish every gap by force, and that Door's final act answers it with a weak messianism of the threshold: an opening that refuses to become an arrival.

6.1

The angel of the sign

Islington is the novel's most complex act of re-motivation. Chapter Two traced the stages by which an angel became a word: a painted sign hung outside a coaching inn on the Great North Road; the district that took its name from the inn; the station of the Underground that took its name from the district; and, latterly, one of the cheapest properties on the British Monopoly board. Each stage removed the image further from its referent, until the angel survived only as a destination announced on station platforms and a square on which players land and pay rent. Gaiman reverses the whole sequence at a stroke. Somewhere beneath the city, beyond a labyrinth, in a hall of its own, the angel exists. The narration calls it "it" and gives it a beauty it describes as perfectly androgynous, although Croup addresses it as "sir" and Richard calls it "he"; this chapter follows the narration (novel, chs. 13, 15). The way to it lies, fittingly, through an image: Door and Richard first reach the angel's hall by opening a relic called the Angelus, kept in the British Museum, so that the angel is approached, as it was produced, through a picture. The relic is on show in an exhibition of angels sponsored by the newspaper magnate who employs Jessica and organized by Jessica herself, a collection a listings magazine finds indiscriminate (novel, chs. 1, 9): the road to the angel passes through London Above's commerce in angels. The angel is beautiful, gentle-voiced, and courteous. When Door seeks it out to learn

who murdered her family, it receives her with grave sympathy and promises its help, for a price: she must bring it the key that the Black Friars guard. The structure is that of Baum's Emerald City, which Chapter One identified as the plot's template: a hidden power, a deferring errand, a revelation. Where Baum's wizard proved a fraud, Gaiman's angel proves a murderer. It was Islington who ordered Croup and Vandemar to kill Door's family, in revenge for her father's refusal to help it, and Croup and Vandemar who tampered with Lord Portico's diary so that it would send his daughter to the angel for help.

The topography of the real station supplies an unexpected gloss. When Angel station was rebuilt between 1989 and 1992, in the years immediately preceding the novel, it received the longest escalators on the London Underground (Day and Reed 2010), a mechanical stair on which the commuters of Islington ascend and descend between the street and the depths. The station that bears the angel's name became, at the moment of Gaiman's writing, a Jacob's ladder of steel. Its riders ascend and descend; the angel beneath, this chapter argues, wishes only to ascend.

The emblematic re-motivation that gives Islington a body also gives it a disfigurement, in the sense de Man attached to prosopopoeia. A face conferred is also a mask, and Islington's beauty masks an intention it conceals. Rilke's first *Duino Elegy* (1923) had already defined the angelic aesthetic in those terms: "Denn das Schöne ist nichts / als des Schrecklichen Anfang, den wir noch grade ertragen," for beauty is nothing but the beginning of terror, which we are still just able to endure, and we admire it so because it serenely disdains to destroy us. "Ein jeder Engel ist schrecklich": every angel is terrifying. Islington is Rilke's angel at the moment its disdain to destroy comes to an end.

6 . 2

Atlantis and the labyrinth

Islington's history is a drowned city. It is the angel in whose charge Atlantis sank, and its confinement beneath London is, as it tells Door, the punishment for that loss. It dreams of the drowning, hearing each of four million voices as they die (novel, ch. 13), and it calls the affair merely unfortunate; but when the Marquis asks whether it had nothing to do with it, its composure breaks and it screams that the drowned deserved it, before subsiding into regret (ch. 17). The outburst makes it less the negligent guardian of a lost city than its judge. The choice of Atlantis is not ornamental. Plato's account in the *Timaeus* (24e–25d) and the unfinished *Critias* (108e–121c) describes an island empire beyond the Pillars of Heracles, larger than Libya and Asia together, which sought to enslave the peoples within the Straits and was defeated by an older Athens, after which, "in a single day and night of misfortune," the island sank into the sea (*Timaeus* 25c–d, trans. Jowett). The *Critias* explains the moral cause. As long as the divine nature lasted in the kings descended from Poseidon, they bore their wealth lightly; when the

divine portion faded through mixture with the mortal, they were filled with unrighteous ambition and power, *pleonexia*, the vice of wanting more (120e–121b). Zeus summons the gods to deliberate on their punishment, and the dialogue breaks off in the middle of his speech.

Atlantis is therefore Plato's parable of the commercial thalassocracy undone by acquisitiveness: a maritime empire of harbours, canals, and precious metals, ruined by the chrematistic appetite that Aristotle, as Chapter Five showed, called unnatural. Its location beyond the Pillars of Heracles is also the location of Herodotus's silent trade (IV.196), the boundary market at which strangers exchanged goods without a word and neither side wronged the other. At the edge of the known world the Greek imagination placed both the market that respects the boundary and the empire that drowned for violating it. London, the mercantile and maritime capital of the modern world, stands in the place of Atlantis. Francis Bacon had given the comparison its utopian form in *The New Atlantis* (1627), whose island of Bensalem is governed by the sages of Salomon's House and supplied with knowledge by envoys it calls "Merchants of Light." The Hermogenean metropolis of Gaiman's novel is Bacon's New Atlantis in its late, commercial form, and beneath it lies the angel of the old one, imprisoned under the city that repeats the sin it failed to prevent.

The labyrinth that surrounds Islington's hall, and the Beast that haunts it, complete a constellation the novel may not have intended but cannot escape. The Cretan labyrinth housed a monster born of a withheld sacrifice: Minos kept for himself the bull that Poseidon had sent to be sacrificed, and Poseidon punished him through Pasiphaë's passion and its offspring, the Minotaur (Apollodorus, *Bibliotheca* III.1.3–4). Poseidon was also the god of Atlantis. In 1909 K. T. Frost proposed that Plato's Atlantis preserved the memory of Minoan Crete, and in 1939 Spyridon Marinatos connected the decline of the Minoan palaces with the eruption of Thera. Gaiman's undercity assembles the same elements: a labyrinth, a monster of neglected sacrifice, and the guardian of a drowned civilization. Chapter Four read the Beast as the Calydonian boar; here it is also the Minotaur, the monster at the centre of the maze. Both readings converge on a single proposition. The path to the false heaven runs through a monster that the city's forgetting has made.

6 . 3

The angel who would not descend

The Greek *angelos*, like the Hebrew *mal'akh*, means messenger. Hermes was the *angelos* of the gods, and the angels of scripture are first of all go-betweens. The tradition systematized by Pseudo-Dionysius in *The Celestial Hierarchy* (c. 500) arranged them in nine orders across three triads and made mediation their essence: each order receives illumination from the order above and transmits it to the order below. An angel exists in the middle. Thomas Aquinas added two determinations of consequence for the novel. Each angel is its own species, since angels lack the

matter that individuates members of a species (*Summa Theologiae* I, q. 50, a. 4); every angel is therefore exactly what its name says it is, the purest Cratylan being in the created order. And an angel is not contained by a place as a body is, but is present wherever it applies its power (I, q. 52, a. 1–2). Islington's punishment is the theological scandal of an angel circumscribed: confined to a place, named for it, and reduced, by the logic of London Above, to a label on a map. Keats feared, in the lines quoted in Chapter Four, that cold philosophy would clip an angel's wings; the Hermogenean city has done worse, and made the angel a property.

Islington's response is to refuse the middle. The archetype of angelic order is Jacob's dream at Bethel: "behold a ladder set up on the earth, and the top of it reached to heaven: and behold the angels of God ascending and descending on it" (Genesis 28:12, AV). Jacob wakes in fear, cries "How dreadful is this place!", and calls it "the gate of heaven" (28:17). The angels of the ladder ascend *and* descend, and the Gospel promises the same double motion (John 1:51). The *Emerald Tablet*, cited in Chapter Four, describes the hermetic substance in the same terms, rising from earth to heaven and descending again. Islington wishes only to ascend. Its programme is the boast of Isaiah's fallen star, "I will ascend into heaven, I will exalt my throne above the stars of God" (Isaiah 14:13, AV), and its fate is Isaiah's verdict: "Yet thou shalt be brought down to hell, to the sides of the pit" (14:15). It is the angel who has broken the rhythm of the ladder, the messenger who no longer wishes to carry messages.

Milton supplies the scene that the novel's climax rewrites. In the second book of *Paradise Lost*, Satan, the fallen archangel, reaches the gates of Hell and persuades their keeper, Sin, to open them. Sin takes from her side "the fatal Key, / Sad instrument of all our woe" (II.871–872), turns it in the intricate wards, and the infernal doors fly open and grate harsh thunder on their hinges; but "She op'nd, but to shut / Excel'd her power" (II.883–884), and the gates stand open thereafter. The configuration is precisely that of Islington's hall: a fallen angel; a female keeper of a threshold; a key; a door whose opening will have consequences beyond the opener's control. Gaiman's revision lies in the keeper's response. Milton's Sin opens the gate for the angel and cannot close it. Gaiman's Door opens the gate against it, with a counterfeit of the key, and where Hell's gate stood open thereafter, this one slams shut once the angel has gone through (novel, ch. 17). The novel knows its Milton: the Marquis has warned Richard that Lucifer too was an angel, and Islington, scorning the comparison, dismisses Lucifer as a fool who ended as lord of nothing.

Gaiman's own work had prepared the configuration. In *The Sandman*'s "Season of Mists" (1990–1991), Lucifer abandons Hell, locks its gates, and gives the key to Dream, whereupon the powers of every pantheon come to bargain for it. In the story "Murder Mysteries" (1992), the angels of the Silver City bear names that state their offices, and one of them, Raguel, is the Vengeance of the Lord. Gaiman's angels are Cratylan by nature and dangerous by office, and the key to an eschatological door is the most coveted object in his fiction. *Neverwhere*

condenses both motifs into a single figure: an angel whose name has been degraded from an office to a place, and who seeks the key that would restore it.

6 . 4

The angel of history and the two messianisms

Walter Benjamin's ninth thesis "Über den Begriff der Geschichte" (1940) contains the image against which Islington must be read. Paul Klee's drawing *Angelus Novus*, Benjamin wrote, shows the angel of history. His face is turned towards the past, and where we perceive a chain of events he sees a single catastrophe that heaps wreckage upon wreckage at his feet. He would like to stay, "die Toten wecken und das Zerschlagene zusammenfügen," to awaken the dead and make whole what has been smashed. But a storm blowing from Paradise has caught in his wings with such force that he can no longer close them, and it drives him irresistibly into the future to which his back is turned. "Das, was wir den Fortschritt nennen, ist dieser Sturm": what we call progress is this storm. The coincidence of names is exact: the relic through which Door first reaches Islington is called the Angelus, and Benjamin's angel is the Angelus Novus.

Islington is Benjamin's angel in revolt. It too faces a catastrophe, the drowned city whose wreckage it cannot forget; it too would make whole what has been smashed. But it refuses to be driven by the storm. It proposes to fly against it, back into the Paradise from which it blows, and to settle accounts there: to force open the door of heaven and take dominion over the other angels in revenge for its banishment. Its programme is what the Acts of the Apostles calls "the times of restitution of all things" (3:21, AV), the *apokatastasis* in which every loss is restored, and Chapter Five showed why the word fits it in both its senses. *Restitution* is at once a theological term for the restoration of creation and a legal term for the repayment of what is owed. Islington is the angel of total settlement, the eschatological creditor whom Benjamin's cult of perpetual debt can imagine as its only release.

Gershom Scholem's essay on the messianic idea in Judaism (1959) distinguished the restorative tendency of messianism, which seeks the return of a lost ideal state, from the utopian tendency, which seeks a state that has never existed, and observed that in its apocalyptic forms the messianic idea conceives redemption as catastrophe, an irruption that destroys the order it ends. Scholem also identified the price messianism exacts from those who hold it: a life lived in deferment, in which nothing can be done definitively because everything waits upon the end. Islington joins the restorative tendency to the catastrophic form and refuses the deferment. It will not wait. The novel gives the refusal a precise juridical form: when the angel was sentenced, its jailers gave it the door to its prison and set the key nearby, intending to send an opener and the key when they judged it had earned forgiveness, and Islington has decided not to wait for the verdict (novel, ch. 17). It is a case of what rabbinic tradition warned against as forcing the end, the attempt to compel by one's own act a redemption that must be granted. Eric Voegelin's *The*

New Science of Politics (1952) called the modern version of this refusal Gnostic, the attempt to bring the eschaton within history by force, and Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) reconstructed the myth on which it rests: a divine spark imprisoned in a lower world, longing to return to the fullness from which it fell. Islington is a Gnostic angel in Jonas's sense, a spark imprisoned in the underworld of London, and a Gnostic revolutionary in Voegelin's.

Benjamin opposed to every such programme a different power. "Dann ist uns wie jedem Geschlecht, das vor uns war, eine schwache messianische Kraft mitgegeben," his second thesis declares: like every generation before us, we have been endowed with a weak messianic power, on which the past has a claim. The weak messianic power does not storm heaven. It answers the claim of the past in the present, through acts of remembrance and attention whose scale is that of a single life. In a note appended to the theses, Benjamin recalled that the Jews, forbidden to inquire into the future, did not experience it as empty time: "in ihr war jede Sekunde die kleine Pforte, durch die der Messias treten konnte," in it every second was the small door through which the Messiah might enter. Benjamin's is a messianism of the small door. The novel's ethics, as Chapter Three argued, is an ethics of the small act of attention: a man stops for a wounded girl on a pavement. In Benjamin's terms, that is the weak messianic power at work, and the girl's name is the small door.

6.5

The gate of heaven

The novel's climax brings the two messianisms into the same room. Door stands before the door in Islington's hall, which only the Black Friars' key and an Opener together can unlock, and agrees to open it only after Croup and Vandemar have tortured Richard in front of her. Scripture had furnished every element of the scene. Isaiah promised the steward of the house of David a key, so that "he shall open, and none shall shut; and he shall shut, and none shall open" (22:22, AV). The Revelation transfers the formula to Christ, "he that hath the key of David, he that openeth, and no man shutteth," and makes it a promise addressed, in the letter to Philadelphia, to an angel: "behold, I have set before thee an open door, and no man can shut it" (3:7–8). The seer then looks, and "a door was opened in heaven," and he hears a voice like a trumpet saying "Come up hither" (4:1). Islington wants to hear that voice.

Door does not let it hear that voice. She has foreseen the demand. At the Floating Market she had Hammersmith copy the Black Friars' key, a copy he could make only from the original Richard had won, and it is the copy she turns in the lock (novel, chs. 17, 19). The counterfeit does not open onto heaven. By her gift it opens onto somewhere as far away as she can manage, a gulf whose pull Richard can compare only to the surface of a star or the edge of a black hole, and Islington, Croup, and Vandemar are drawn through it before the door slams shut. The act is the novel's decisive philosophical gesture, and its structure deserves precise statement. Door does

not refuse to open; a refusal would leave the angel at the threshold, waiting, as Kafka's man waited before the Law, and would leave Richard to his torturers. Nor does she open the door to its destination; that would deliver the world to the catastrophe of restitution. She opens without arrival. The door remains a door, but it no longer leads where the strong messianism required it to lead. It leads elsewhere, and the elsewhere cannot be reached. The instrument of that opening is a counterfeit, and Chapter Two's argument returns here with full force: London Below is not the city's origin but its counterfeit, a coin struck against the official currency, and the world is saved by a forged key. The authentic key, in the terms of Benjamin's essay on mechanical reproduction the bearer of an aura and of cult value, would have served the cult of total restitution. The copy, which has no aura and claims none, cannot open heaven, and that incapacity is its grace.

> *The world is saved by a forged key.*

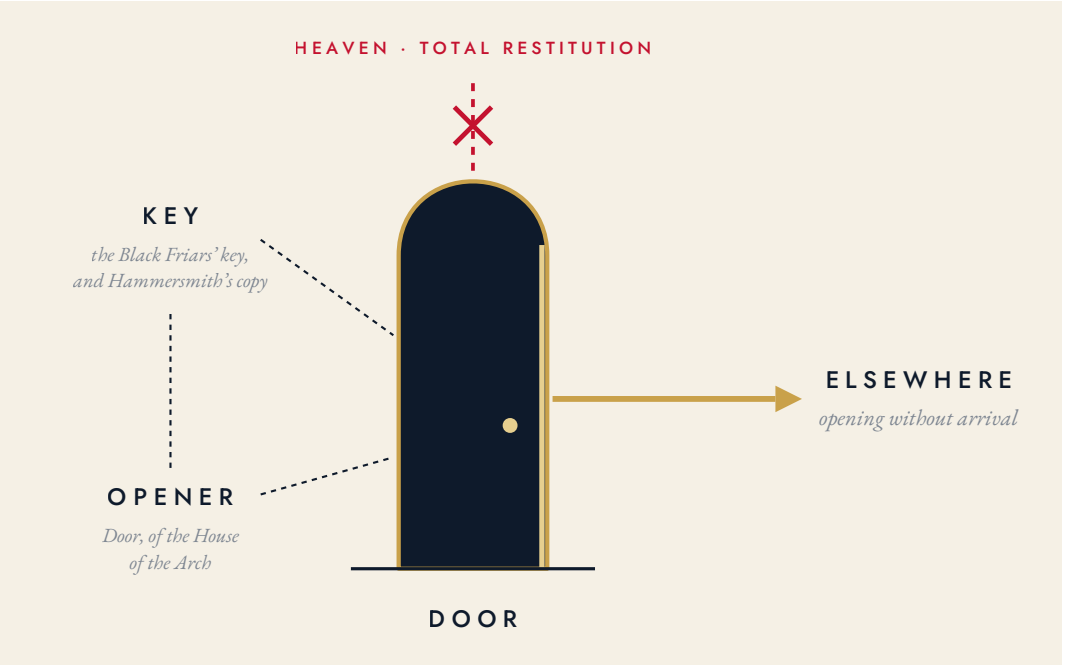


FIGURE 5 *Key, door, opener. Islington's door was built to open on forgiveness; Door's counterfeit opens it onto an elsewhere that cannot be reached (section 6.5).*

The climax spells out the economics of the strong messianism in its own terms. Facing the opened door, Islington promises its hirelings every reward their minds can conceive once it has

its throne, and vows to reward the worthy and cast down the hateful; Richard answers with the White Queen's "jam to-morrow" from *Through the Looking-Glass*, and Croup, scenting default, insists that he and Vandemar collect their debts in full and with interest (novel, ch. 17). The eschatological creditor meets its debt collectors, and the novel borrows the most famous formula of deferred payment in English nonsense to name the promise. Islington's last offer, as it is drawn through the door, is not wealth but restoration: close the door, it pleads, and it will tell Door where her sister is, still alive. Door flinches, and does not close it. The decisive refusal of the book is the refusal of a restoration, a lost member of her family held out as the price of letting the angel back, and it is made by the one character with most reason to want the past restored.

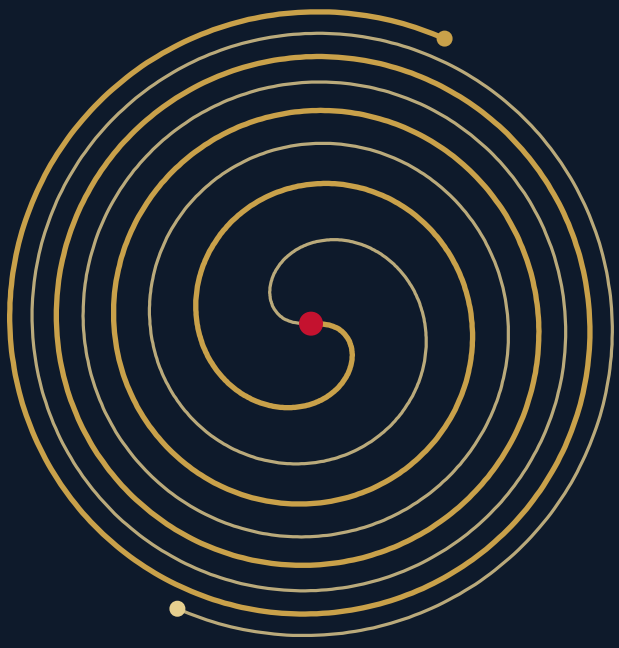
Jacques Derrida's late writings named this structure *messianicity without messianism*: an openness to the coming of what cannot be anticipated, belonging to the very form of promise and experience, and stripped of any determinate messiah, programme, or destination (*Spectres de Marx*, 1993; "Foi et savoir," 1996). Kafka had stated the paradox as a parable of deferment: the Messiah will come only when he is no longer necessary, "einen Tag nach seiner Ankunft," a day after his arrival. George MacDonald's fairy tale "The Golden Key" (1867) gave it narrative form. Its two children, Mossy and Tangle, find the golden key at the foot of the rainbow and spend their lives searching for the lock it fits, growing old and being made young again in the search; at the end they climb a stair within the rainbow towards "the country whence the shadows fall," and the narrator closes with a sentence that suspends arrival forever: "And by this time I think they must have got there." MacDonald's key opens heaven only to those who have grown into it through patience. Islington wants the key as a weapon.

Door's opening is a messianicity of exactly this kind, and it preserves what Islington would have destroyed: the gap. Its ascent would have abolished the interval between the lower world and the higher, the middle in which angels move and the threshold at which the dismembered Hermes keeps his offices. Islington's conspiracy was an attempt to gather the god's scattered members into a single instrument by coercion: it bought the contest, had the trickster murdered, had the father's diary falsified, and had the hero tortured to compel the hinge. Door's answer also assembles offices, but by alliance rather than force, and it leaves each with its bearer: her own gift of opening, the guile of a secret counterfeit, and the craft of Hammersmith, whose forge makes the copy. The polity is saved not by a reunited god but by a cooperation among his pieces.

Scripture's own final city complicates the choice in a way the novel helps to read. The New Jerusalem of the Revelation is a city of perpetual openness: "And the gates of it shall not be shut at all by day: for there shall be no night there" (21:25, AV). Its gates never close, but it has no night. The canonical eschaton promises the open door at the price of the Night's Bridge, the remainder, and the dark in which London Below lives. *Neverwhere*'s weak messianism refuses that bargain too. It keeps the door open and keeps the night.

The resolution thereby rejoins the vision with which the novel's London began. Blake's Jerusalem, Chapter One recalled, began at Islington: "The fields from Islington to Marybone" were builded over with pillars of gold. Blake's New Jerusalem was to be built in London, and his means were declared in the preface to *Milton*: "I will not cease from Mental Fight, / Nor shall my Sword sleep in my hand: / Till we have built Jerusalem, / In Englands green & pleasant Land." Gaiman's Islington wished to leave London for the heavenly city by literal war; Blake proposed to build the heavenly city in London by mental fight. Between the strong messianism that storms heaven and the weak one that builds it in the city through vision and attention, *Neverwhere* chooses Blake's. Its heaven is reached, if at all, not through the angel's door but through the small doors of the present: a girl on a pavement, a market after closing, a hand held in the dark on a bridge.

CHAPTER SEVEN



VII

Katabasis and the Ordeal

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Katabasis and the Ordeal

Madness, Initiation, and the Inverted Cave

Richard Mayhew's story is a descent into the underworld whose every station inverts its classical model. He enters by pity where the ancients forbade it, is stripped of identity as the goddess was stripped of her powers, is tested by the accusation of madness, completes his initiation in the blood of a beast, and finds on his return that the world above is the cave and the world below the light.

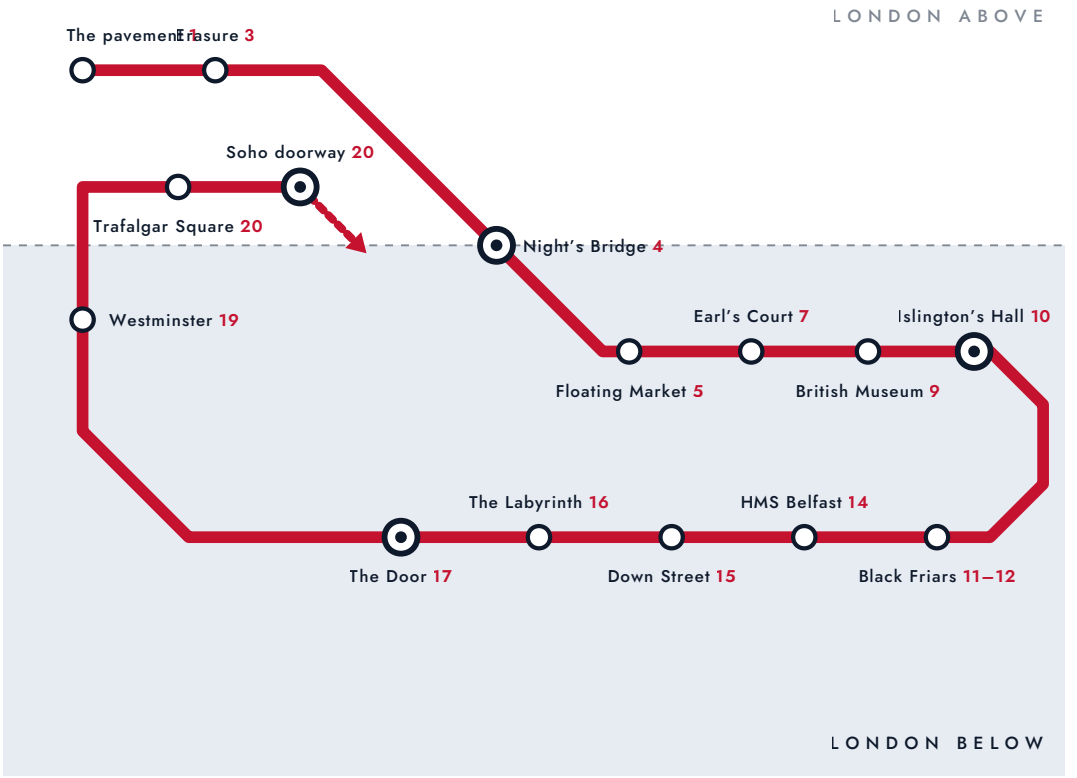


FIGURE 6 *Richard's line: the katabasis drawn as a transit diagram, from the pavement where he stops for Door to the doorway where the last door is cut. Station numbers give the novel's chapters.*

7.1

The descent and its law

The narrative of descent is among the oldest in literature. Inanna, queen of heaven, passes through the seven gates of the underworld to the court of her sister Ereshkigal; Gilgamesh traverses twelve double-hours of darkness through the mountain Mashu; Orpheus goes down for Eurydice, Heracles for Cerberus, Aeneas for the shade of his father, Dante for his own salvation. Plato's *Republic*, the founding text of Western political philosophy, begins with a descent: "κατέβην χθὲς εἰς Πειραιᾶ," I went down yesterday to the Piraeus (327a). Rachel Falconer's study of post-war descent narratives, *Hell in Contemporary Literature* (2005), has shown how persistently the katabatic plot has served modern fiction as a structure for the dismantling and reconstruction of the self.

The classical descent has a law, and Apuleius states it most clearly. When Psyche is sent down to Proserpina in the *Metamorphoses* (VI.17–21), the tower that instructs her warns that on the way she will be accosted by a lame driver asking her to pick up his fallen sticks, by a dead old man

swimming in the river of the dead who will beg to be pulled into the boat, and by old women at their weaving who will ask her help. She must refuse them all, for pity is forbidden there, and every appeal is a snare set by Venus to make her drop one of the cakes she needs for her return. The classical underworld punishes pity. *Neverwhere* inverts the law at its first step. Richard does not enter London Below in spite of pity; he enters because of it. The act the tower forbade Psyche, stopping for the one who asks, is the act that opens Richard's descent, and the whole novel can be read as a demonstration that the underworld of the dispossessed is entered only by those who fail Psyche's test.

7.2

Divestiture

The Descent of Inanna, preserved on Sumerian tablets of the early second millennium BCE, gives the earliest account of descent as divestiture. At each of the seven gates of the underworld, the gatekeeper removes one of the goddess's insignia: the crown, the necklaces, the breastplate, the ring, the measuring rod and line, and finally her royal garment, so that she arrives naked before Ereshkigal, who fixes on her the eye of death and hangs her corpse on a hook. Richard's erasure follows the same logic. At each threshold of the days that follow his act of pity, he loses an attribute of social existence: his fiancée, his home, his work, the cabs that will not stop, the recognition of strangers, and finally his standing as a person whom the city's institutions can see. He arrives in London Below stripped of everything but his name, and his name, in the city above, has ceased to refer.

Victor Turner's analysis of the liminal phase, "Betwixt and Between" (1964), explains the state in which divestiture leaves him. The neophyte in the liminal period, Turner observed, is structurally though not physically invisible: no longer classified and not yet classified, stripped of status, property, and insignia, often treated as dead or polluting, and likened to darkness, wilderness, and the womb. Chapter Three described Richard's invisibility as a political distribution of the sensible; Turner shows that it is also the invisibility of the initiand, and that London Below as a whole is the zone in which van Gennep's traveller "flotte entre deux mondes." The novel fuses the sociological and the ritual meanings of invisibility. The poor are invisible as the initiand is invisible, and the novel asks what would follow if their invisibility were understood not as exclusion from the social order but as the threshold of another.

The Descent of Inanna also contains the oldest version of the ethic that resolves the novel. When Inanna fails to return, her minister appeals to the gods, and only Enki responds. From the dirt beneath his fingernails he fashions two small creatures, the *kurgarra* and the *galatur*, who slip into the underworld like flies and find Ereshkigal in pain. They neither fight her nor deceive her. They echo her cries, lamenting as she laments, and Ereshkigal, moved by their sympathy, offers them a gift. They ask for the corpse on the hook, revive it with the food and water of life,

and Inanna rises. The goddess is rescued from death by beings made of dirt, the remainder of a god's hands, whose only power is compassionate attention to the suffering of the queen of the dead. Four thousand years before Gaiman, the Sumerian poem had stated the principle of London Below: the remainder saves, and it saves by attending.

7.3

The Ordeal of the Key: madness and the country of the blind

The key that Islington demands is guarded by the Black Friars, whose Abbot keeps a wall of photographs of those who have failed, and it is won only by passing their Ordeal. There are three tests, one for each of the company: Hunter bests the first gatekeeper in a fight in the mud, Door answers the second gatekeeper's riddle, and Richard, though both offer to take his place, is left to face the Ordeal of the Key itself (novel, ch. 11). In it Richard finds himself, or seems to find himself, on the District Line platform at Blackfriars, the friars' own station, a ragged man among commuters (ch. 12). A mother tells her staring daughter that people like him lack the courage to end it all; then his colleague Gary, a double with his own face and voice, and finally Jessica, compassionate as he has never seen her, each tell him that they are only himself talking, that London Below was the hallucination of a breakdown, and that he is close at last to sanity. The advertisements across the tracks, for credit cards, sports shoes, and holidays in Cyprus, rewrite themselves as injunctions to die, and as a train approaches he understands how little it would take to end his pain. His hand finds the quartz bead in his pocket, and he seems to hear the rat-girl tell him to hold on. He does not step back from the train; he waits for it, and when its doors open on a carriage of the dead, each of whom died by their own hand and some of whose faces he half-remembers from the friars' wall, he steps aboard, and the lights go out. He wakes in the shrine where the key hangs, alive. The Abbot, who had expected a ruined survivor, prepares to send him to the infirmary as a poor creature, and Richard answers that he is not a poor creature. The trial is a test not of courage but of perception and fidelity. Richard passes it by refusing the explanation, holding to what he has seen against the consensus of a world that cannot see it, and he holds to it by remembering the dead. He completes it not by refusing the train of the dead but by boarding it: a descent into the company of those who failed, which he survives.

H. G. Wells's "The Country of the Blind" (1904) is the ordeal's closest literary precedent. A mountaineer, Nunez, falls into an isolated valley whose inhabitants have been blind for generations and have built a complete cosmology without sight. He expects, by the old proverb, to be king; instead his talk of seeing is taken for the raving of an unformed mind. When he wishes to marry, the valley's doctors diagnose his eyes as diseased organs pressing on his brain and propose "to remove these irritant bodies," after which he will be sane. Nunez chooses his eyes and flees up the mountain. The structure of the Black Friars' trial is identical. London Above is the Country of the Blind, a society whose anaesthesia, in the sense of Chapter Three, is its norm of

health; to perceive London Below is, by that norm, a symptom; and the cure on offer is the surrender of perception, which the ordeal carries to its terminus: the reasonable world's last counsel to Richard is that he end his life. Richard, like Nunez, chooses his eyes.

Michel Foucault's *Histoire de la folie à l'âge classique* (1961) supplies the history behind the trial. Foucault began with the ship of fools, the vessel on which the mad of late medieval Europe were sent along the rivers, and described the madman as the passenger par excellence, held captive by the passage itself. He dated the great confinement to the founding of the Hôpital Général in Paris in 1656, when the insane were shut away together with the poor, the vagrant, and the idle. Madness and poverty were confined as a single population, and Gaiman's undercity, which receives the vagrant and the deranged together, inherits Foucault's great confinement turned inside out: not a hospital in which the excluded are hidden but a city in which they are sovereign. The ship of fools returns, moreover, in the Floating Market's convocation aboard HMS Belfast. The prisoners of passage have taken possession of the ship.

The period of the novel's composition gave the ordeal an immediate and specific referent. Under the policy known as Care in the Community, given statutory form by the NHS and Community Care Act 1990, the great Victorian asylums were closing. On 17 December 1992, at Finsbury Park station on the Underground, Christopher Clunis, a man with a diagnosis of paranoid schizophrenia who had been discharged from compulsory detention in hospital that September and had since missed his follow-up appointments, fatally stabbed Jonathan Zito, a stranger to him, in an unprovoked attack on the platform. The inquiry chaired by Jean Ritchie QC, whose report appeared in February 1994 (Ritchie, Dick, and Lingham 1994; see also Coid 1994), traced years of failure in Clunis's care across health, social, police, and probation services and addressed questions of race and racism in psychiatry; Jonathan Zito's widow, Jayne Zito, founded the Zito Trust to campaign for reform; and the government responded with supervision registers, independent inquiries into homicides by people under psychiatric care, and the Mental Health (Patients in the Community) Act 1995. The case made the mentally ill man on the Underground platform a national emblem of danger. The emblem was not proportionate to the evidence. Pamela Taylor and John Gunn's study of homicide statistics for England and Wales (1999) found no rise in killings by people with mental illness across the decades of deinstitutionalization, and people with severe mental illness are far more likely to be victims of violence, and to die by suicide, than to harm others (Teplin et al. 2005; Appleby et al. 2001). *Neverwhere*, published less than four years after the killing, sets its crucial trial in the Underground and inverts the emblem. The ragged man muttering in the station is not the danger but the seer, and the danger the ordeal stages is the one the evidence rather than the headlines identifies as the greater: not his violence against others but his own death. R. D. Laing's *The Politics of Experience* (1967) had argued a generation earlier that what passes for normality is itself a condition of alienation, and that madness may be a voyage from which the traveller returns enlarged. The ordeal stages Laing's inversion, asking whether the man who sees London Below is mad or the city that can-

not see it. Within its fable the novel's answer is unambiguous, and the fable carries a risk that Chapter Eight confronts: that the real suffering of those who hear voices in the Underground may be aestheticized as visionary insight. The ordeal is best read not as a romance of madness but as a test of fidelity, in which what is tried is the protagonist's loyalty to what he has witnessed and to the dead who witnessed it with him.

7.4

The labyrinth and the beast

The final stage of initiation is the killing of the Great Beast in the labyrinth before Islington's hall. Chapter Four read the beast as the Calydonian boar and Chapter Six as the Minotaur; both are monsters of a forgotten sacrifice, and both are slain at the end of a ritual path. The labyrinth was itself an initiatory form. Plutarch records that Theseus, returning from Crete, danced at Delos the *geranos*, the crane dance, whose turns imitated the windings of the labyrinth (*Theseus* 21), and Karl Kerényi's *Labyrinth-Studien* (1941) interpreted the figure as the path through death into renewed life. Richard enters the labyrinth without Ariadne's thread, carrying the spear the Marquis made Hunter surrender, and what he contributes is a single act at the decisive moment, when Hunter, mortally hurt, draws the Beast onto herself and tells him when to strike. The Beast he kills is, on Old Bailey's account recalled in Chapter One, an animal fattened for a Christmas feast that escaped the butcher into the sewers. It is literally an interrupted sacrifice, and Richard's spear completes, some three centuries late, the killing the feast required.

Walter Burkert's *Homo Necans* (1972) explains why that act completes the novel's rite of reparation. Greek sacrifice, Burkert argued, descends from the rituals of Palaeolithic hunters, for whom the killing of the great beast was surrounded by anxieties of guilt and by gestures of restitution: the gathering of the bones, the raising of the skull, what Karl Meuli had called the comedy of innocence, by which the hunters disclaimed the killing and restored the animal symbolically to life. The hunt and the sacrifice are one institution. In the labyrinth the hunter dies and the beast dies, and the monster of the city's forgotten sacrifice is at last given the sacrifice it was owed. Burkert's restitution is humble, ritual, and partial, and it contrasts at every point with the total restitution Islington seeks beyond the door.

Richard emerges from the kill bloodied by the beast, and the oldest literature of heroic initiation knows what such a marking means. In the *Völsunga saga*, Sigurd roasts the heart of the dragon Fafnir, burns his finger, puts it to his mouth, and on tasting the heart's blood understands the speech of the birds, who warn him of his foster-father's treachery; in the *Nibelungenlied*, Siegfried bathes in the dragon's blood and is made invulnerable save where a linden leaf fell between his shoulders. The language of the birds acquired, in the esoteric tradition, a further meaning that bears directly on this dissertation. The *langue des oiseaux*, or *langue verte*, of the French alchemical writers, given its best-known modern statement in Fulcanelli's *Le Mystère des*

cathédrales (1926), is a phonetic cabbala, the art of reading hidden meanings through homophony and pun. The language of the birds is the language of London Below, the art by which Knightsbridge is heard as the bridge of night. Gaiman's version of the rite is more modest than Sigurd's, and more exact. At Hunter's dying instruction, seconded by the Marquis, Richard touches the Beast's blood to his eyes and tongue, and what it gives him is not the speech of animals but the labyrinth itself: he runs through it as if he knew every turn (novel, ch. 16). The initiate is granted the map of the maze, the knowledge of a place's windings that London Below has of London; and as he runs, the refrain of the Lyke Wake Dirge beats in his head, so that the rite of initiation and the watch over the dead are sung in a single measure.

7.5

The inverted Cave and the door in the wall

The katabatic narrative ends in a return, and the return of *Neverwhere* is the most philosophically pointed episode in the book. The Abbot reveals that the genuine key, which Richard won, is the key to all reality and will take him wherever he wishes; Door, on a hill above the river at dawn, holds it out as if to an invisible lock, tells him to walk away and not look back, and turns it when he looks back from the foot of the hill (novel, ch. 19). The injunction is Orpheus's, and the reversal is instructive: Richard looks back and loses nothing but the underworld itself. He climbs out of an underpass into Trafalgar Square under a sky the narrator compares to the blank blue of a television screen tuned to a dead channel, an inversion of the opening of William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984), and receives his former life back, its work, home, and prospects returned as though nothing had happened (ch. 20). His colleagues assume he has been on holiday in Majorca; he is promoted; his landlord gives him a better flat; Jessica comes back, and he declines her. He discovers that he no longer wants any of it. The city he once inhabited now seems thin, grey, and unreal, a screen rather than a sky, and the people of his old life seem to him like sleepers. When his colleague Gary, climbing into a taxi after a night out, tells him that this is reality and all there is, the sentence is the cave's own creed.

The episode inverts the allegory of the Cave (*Republic* VII, 514a–521b). In Plato, the prisoners sit chained in the dark, watching shadows cast on a wall by images carried behind them, and they award honours to whoever is quickest at discerning the passing shadows and best at predicting which will come next (516c–d). The prisoner released and dragged up into the sunlight is at first dazzled; once he has seen the sun, he would rather suffer anything than return to the prisoners' opinions; and were he to go back down, his eyes full of darkness, the prisoners would laugh at him and say that "up he went and down he came without his eyes" (517a, trans. Jowett). In *Neverwhere* the topography is reversed. The world of shadows is above, a city of worn coins, emblems of emblems, and labels in place of faces, whose most honoured profession, the forecasting practised in the City where Richard works, is precisely the prediction of the procession of

shadows. The world of the sun is below, in the city where names mean what they say and things wear their histories on their faces. Richard's return is the philosopher's return to the cave, and his eyes, accustomed to the light of the undercity, can no longer take the shadows for substance. Chapter Two showed that Gaiman inverted the vertical topography of the *Cratylus*, placing true speech below and falsehood above. The inverted Cave is the same inversion carried from language into knowledge.

> "
>
> *The sentence is the cave's own creed.*

Plato, however, did not let the philosopher stay in the light. Those who have seen the good, Socrates insists, must be compelled to return: "καταβατέον οὖν ἐν μέρει ἑκάστῳ," down you must go, each in turn, to the common dwelling of the others (520c). The *Republic*, which began with a descent, makes descent the philosopher's duty. Gaiman's inversion extends to this last point. Richard's final movement is a descent, but it is undertaken not as a duty imposed by the city but as a choice against it, and its destination is not the realm of shadows but the realm of light. Plato's philosopher returns to the cave to rule it. Richard leaves the cave to live.

H. G. Wells had written the ending that Gaiman rewrites. In "The Door in the Wall" (1906), Lionel Wallace, a statesman of great promise, finds as a child a green door in a white wall in West Kensington, through which he enters an enchanted garden. Throughout his adult life the door reappears, always at moments when he is hurrying towards some advancement, and each time he passes it by. He is found dead at last "in a deep excavation near East Kensington Station," having gone through an unfastened door in a hoarding at night. The narrator cannot decide whether Wallace was deluded or saw truly: "By our daylight standard he walked out of security into darkness, danger, and death. But did he see like that?" Wells's door leads into a hole in London's underground, and his story ends in death and doubt. Gaiman's ends in a choice, and in a gesture that answers Wells's exactly. After seeing Gary off in his taxi, Richard walks back through Soho and stops beside an old woman asleep in a shop doorway, her few possessions, among them a dirty umbrella that was once white, tied to her wrist; he gives her money, tells her that if this is sanity he does not want it, and shows her the knife Hunter gave him as she died, with which the Earl had knighted him (novel, ch. 20). Then he scratches the outline of a door into the brick beside her doorway and hammers on it, calling for Door, until the fit passes and he apologizes. Nothing answers, and he sits down on the pavement in despair. When he looks again, there is a door-shaped hole where he scratched the outline, and the Marquis de Carabas stands in it, impatient, asking whether he is coming. Wells's door is taken at last, and it is taken through a sign that becomes a threshold: the drawn door opens, though only after its maker has given up, and only

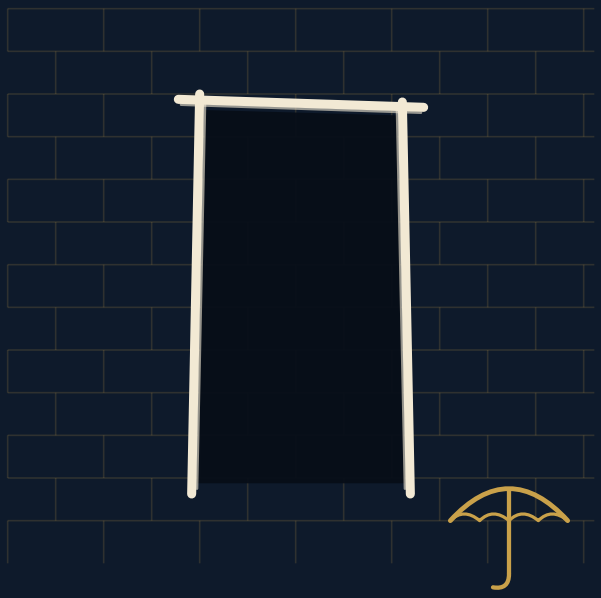
with the trickster standing in it. The novel ends with the Cratylan operation it began with, a figure taken at its word, now performed on the outline of a door. The frame is exact. The book begins with Richard giving an umbrella printed with the names of the city's stations to an old homeless woman who warns him about doors, and it ends beside an old homeless woman with a once-white umbrella, next to whose doorway the last door is cut. The novel leaves the identity of the two women open; it does not leave open where its doors are found.

The ending also completes the inversion of Dante that Chapter Three began. The vestibule of the *Inferno* held the shade of him who made the great refusal out of cowardice. Richard's refusal of the restored life is a great refusal made out of courage, the refusal of a life that the vestibule calls living. Its American counterpart is Herman Melville's "Bartleby, the Scrivener: A Story of Wall-Street" (1853), whose copyist answers every demand of his employer with "I would prefer not to," gazes for hours from his window at a blank brick wall in what the narrator calls his dead-wall reveries, and dies in the Tombs at the foot of a wall that never opens. Bartleby, the narrator learns, had worked in the Dead Letter Office, among letters that set out on errands of life and arrive at death; the clerk of undelivered messages is a Hermes who has failed. Richard is the clerk of the City whose refusal finds a door in the wall, and the novel's last movement answers Melville's last cry, "Ah Bartleby! Ah humanity!", with a threshold.

Joseph Campbell's *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949), through which the novel has often been read, provides the measure of its departure. Campbell's hero returns with a boon for the community he left, crosses the return threshold, and becomes master of the two worlds, free to pass between them. Richard's boon cannot be received in London Above, which cannot perceive the world from which it comes; his return therefore fails, and his mastery of the two worlds takes the form of a choice between them. The novel is an anti-monomyth: its return discloses that the community above has no use for the hero's knowledge, and the hero completes his journey by leaving it.

Yet the double movement of the *Emerald Tablet* is fulfilled in Richard as it is refused by Islington. He descends into London Below, ascends to London Above, and descends again; he rises from earth and returns to earth, receiving the powers of the higher and the lower. The angel who would only ascend is expelled into an elsewhere; the man who ascends and descends becomes a citizen of the threshold. Georg Simmel's essay on the stranger (1908) defined that citizen in a phrase: the stranger is not the wanderer who comes today and goes tomorrow but "der heute kommt und morgen bleibt," the one who comes today and stays tomorrow. Richard came to London from Scotland as a stranger to its official city. He ends as a stranger who stays, in the other one.

CHAPTER EIGHT



VIII

The Limits of the Undercity

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The Limits of the Undercity

Romance, Hierarchy, Gender, and the Problem of Jessica

The novel's limits follow from its method. Cratylan naming confines as it reveals; the romance of a hidden nobility displaces the politics of dispossession into fable; the picturesque threatens to convert want into wonder; and the freedom to bear a name that does not dictate one's fate is distributed unequally between the novel's men and women. The limits converge in a single figure, the woman who did not stop.

8.1

Three cautions

Chapter Two closed by recording three cautions that the Cratylan method could not escape. Socrates warned that likeness is a meagre support for names, which convention must supplement; Derrida, that there is no origin to which a worn sign can be restored; de Man, that every face conferred by prosopopoeia is also a mask. Each caution names a limit of *Neverwhere*. The Socratic caution identifies the cage of nominal determinism; the Derridean, the nostalgia for a natural order that expresses itself as hierarchy; the de Manian, the mask of the picturesque that the novel lays over dispossession. The fourth limit, the gendered distribution of names, is where the first three converge. Section 8.6 considers what the allegations made against Gaiman since 2024 change in these arguments and what they do not, and the problem of Jessica, in section 8.7, is where the novel's own ethics, turned upon itself, discloses its blind spot. To name these limits is not to dismiss the novel. It is to apply to it the discipline it teaches, attending to what falls into the gaps of its own order.

8.2

The Cratylan cage

In London Below a name is a destiny. Hunter hunts and dies hunting; Door opens; the Velvets are what their name describes; Lamia is a lamia; and Anaesthesia's name foretells her disappearance into insensibility. The comedy of fitting names acquired a label in the very years of the novel's composition: the phrase *nominative determinism*, for the tendency of people to gravitate towards occupations that suit their names, was coined in the "Feedback" column of *New Scientist* in 1994, adopted from a reader's suggestion. Among the coincidences that prompted it was a guide to the city's hidden depths, *London Under London: A Subterranean Guide* (1985), one of whose authors was named Trench. London Below is nominative determinism raised from a joke to an ontology.

Plato saw the political form of the doctrine and called it a lie. In the third book of the *Republic*, Socrates proposes that the citizens of the ideal city be told a *gennaion pseudos*, a noble lie: that the god who fashioned them mixed gold into those fit to rule, silver into the auxiliaries, and iron and bronze into the farmers and craftsmen, and that the city will perish when it is guarded by iron or bronze (414b–415d). The myth of the metals is Cratylism applied to society, a fiction in which each person's nature fixes his station and the station is therefore just. Socrates offers it knowingly, as a falsehood necessary for order. The Cratylan city of *Neverwhere* has adopted the myth without knowing it for one. Its inhabitants are what they are called, and the stratification the novel claims to escape returns in the form of nature.

The conventionalism that the novel assigns to London Above deserves, in fairness, a better hearing than the novel gives it. Hermogenes' example of the renamed slave (384d) displays the cruelty of conventional naming, but convention has a brighter face as well: the freedom to change one's name, to leave behind a family, a past, a stigma, or a designation imposed by others, and to be known by a name one has chosen. That freedom is Hermogenean, and London Below grants it to almost no one. The Socratic compromise of the *Cratylus*, which held that likeness must be supplemented by convention (435c), describes a just semiotics better than either of the novel's cities: names that bind, so that persons cannot be arbitrarily renamed by power, and names that can be changed, so that persons are not imprisoned in their designations. The novel's exception proves the point. The Marquis de Carabas, the one inhabitant of London Below who evidently chose his name, is also its freest agent.

8.3

Hierarchy and the romance of the dispossessed

The dispossessed of London Below have a peerage. There is an Earl, a Marquis, a Lord Ratspeaker, a Lady Door, and noble houses, such as Door's, whose fortunes the plot follows. The

aristocracy admits two readings. Read as status reversal in Victor Turner's sense, or as the beggar-kingdom of Hugo's Cour des miracles, it is parody: the dispossessed have crowned themselves, and the crown mocks the order that excluded them. Read as romance, it is nostalgia. Fredric Jameson argued in *The Political Unconscious* (1981) that romance flourishes in periods of transition, when an older social formation is giving way to a newer one, and that it preserves, in its opposition of good and evil and its world of fixed honours and enchanted objects, the residue of the order that is passing. Michael Moorcock's polemic "Epic Pooh" (1978) had charged English fantasy with a consolatory conservatism, a nostalgia for a hierarchical England of the nursery. *Neverwhere* is neither pastoral nor consolatory in the manner Moorcock attacked, but it shares the genre's hierarchical imagination. Its fantasy of the dispossessed is a fantasy of their hidden nobility, and a hidden nobility is a version of the lost-heir motif, the oldest consolation romance offers to the poor.

China Miéville's fiction supplies the novel's most searching immanent critique, and it is the critique of an heir: the acknowledgements of *Un Lun Dun* (2007) thank Gaiman for *Neverwhere*. *King Rat* (1998) sends its hero into the sewers of a drum-and-bass London of the 1990s, where the Pied Piper of Hamelin is at large as a villain. *Un Lun Dun* imagines an "abcity" populated by London's obsolete and discarded things, among them animate broken umbrellas, and systematically inverts the plot of the chosen one: its prophesied heroine, the "Shwazzy" (from the French *choisi*), is defeated early and returns home without memory of her destiny, and the city is saved by her unchosen friend, Deeba, with the help of many others. *The City & the City* (2009) imagines two cities occupying the same ground, whose citizens are trained from childhood to "unsee" each other, and whose boundary is enforced by a mysterious authority called Breach. Miéville's achievement, set beside Gaiman's, is to demystify invisibility. In *Neverwhere* the inhabitants of London Below are unseen by a law of nature, though the novel takes care to show, in Anaesthesia's account of her childhood (section 3.1), the social mechanisms that deliver them to it; in *The City & the City* unseeing is a civic discipline, taught, enforced, and therefore capable of being otherwise. The difference is decisive for politics. Insofar as invisibility is ontological, no politics can make the invisible visible, and the only available response is the one Richard chooses.

That response is exit. Albert O. Hirschman's *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty* (1970) distinguished two responses to the decline of an institution: departure from it, and the attempt to change it from within by protest and argument. Richard's final choice is departure, and for most of the novel London Below's relation to London Above is not voice but parallel existence. Yet the novel contains voice, and it is the voice the villain silences. Door's father, in the recording she plays after the massacre, condemns the petty factionalism of the Underside and its system of baronies and fiefdoms as divisive and foolish (novel, ch. 4), and Islington reveals at the climax that Lord Portico wanted to unite London Below and perhaps to forge a bond with London Above, and was murdered for laughing at the angel's price (ch. 17). The plot is set in motion by the killing of

the one figure in the book who proposed a politics, and the novel ends with his daughter resolving, now that the angel is gone, to finish what he started (ch. 19). The novel never stages the moment Rancière calls politics, in which the part of those who have no part interrupts the distribution of the sensible and makes itself heard in the common; but it places that moment just beyond its ending, in the hands of the heroine its hero leaves behind. The comparison with Ellison is instructive. The narrator of *Invisible Man* ends his book by declaring his time underground a hibernation and resolving to emerge, with the suggestion that he may speak, on frequencies below hearing, for the reader. Ellison's descent prepares voice; Gaiman's return prepares exit for its hero and leaves voice to Door.

The novel's ethics of attention is accordingly personalist. Its weak messianic power, the power of the single act, can rescue a wounded girl on a pavement; it cannot house the homeless. The history it leaves offstage can be named. Rough sleeping in central London rose visibly through the late 1980s. Homelessness charities and social-policy researchers linked the rise among the young to specific changes: restrictions on board-and-lodging payments to young claimants in the mid-1980s; the Social Security Act 1988, which withdrew income support from almost all 16- and 17-year-olds, who were expected instead to take places on the Youth Training Scheme (Harris 1988); and the payment of the new income support two weeks in arrears, which left new claimants without income in their first weeks on the street. Ministers answered in Parliament that training places exceeded demand and that vulnerable young people could still claim (Hansard, 19 December 1988), and the policy's supporters described its aim as moving the young off benefits and into training. The government launched the Rough Sleepers Initiative in 1990 (Wilson 2015), and the encampment known as Cardboard City in the underpasses of the Bull Ring at Waterloo became a national symbol before its clearance in February 1998 (BBC News, 23 February 1998). The period's most quoted statement on the subject came from the Prime Minister. In an interview given to *Woman's Own* in September 1987 and published that October, Margaret Thatcher complained of people who said that they were homeless and that the government must therefore house them, and who thereby cast their problems on society, which, she said, did not exist as such: there were individual men and women and there were families, and it was their duty to look after themselves and then to look after their neighbours. The magazine printed an edited text, in which the interviewer tidied her wording and moved the denial of society from its original place; the account given here follows the Downing Street transcript published by the Margaret Thatcher Foundation. Her defenders have read the remark as a call to personal and neighbourly responsibility, and Downing Street took the unusual step of issuing a clarification, published in the Sunday Times in July 1988; her critics took it as the epitome of a retreat from collective provision. *Neverwhere* stands in an unexpectedly close relation to both readings. Its ethics is the neighbour's ethics the remark invoked, the Samaritan's private act rather than the state's provision; its world gives body to what the critics feared, an entire population fallen through the gaps, with no institution to catch it; the one hospital the novel shows

has been closed by cutbacks and let to its killers (section 8.6). Against that background, a fable that answers dispossession, for its hero, with private attention and private exit registers the period's own way of framing social problems as matters of individual encounter. Fantasy is not obliged to legislate, and the novel's refusal to propose a political solution may be its honesty. But its consolations are private, and Weil, whose ethics of attention Chapter Three invoked, joined attention to a demand for the rootedness of whole populations in *L'Enracinement* (1949). The novel takes Weil's first lesson without her second.

8.4

The lower picturesque

John Ruskin distinguished in the fourth volume of *Modern Painters* (1856) between the noble picturesque of Turner, which sympathizes with the suffering it depicts, and a lower picturesque, which he called "eminently a heartless one": its lover "seems to go forth into the world in a temper as merciless as its rocks," and for him "Poverty, and darkness, and guilt, bring in their several contributions to his treasury of pleasant thoughts" (Part V, ch. 1, §12). Ruskin's own diary, quoted in a note to the same section, supplies the economic truth of the matter: after a happy walk among the picturesque slums along the Somme at Amiens, he could not help feeling "how many suffering persons must pay for my picturesque subject and happy walk." Yet Ruskin's verdict is dialectical, and it fits *Neverwhere* exactly. The lover of the lower picturesque, he went on, is no monster; his pleasure carries an undercurrent of real sympathy, may lead him to a truer understanding of the poor, and is admirable compared with the taste of the person who would thrust all poverty and misery out of his way, "collecting it into back alleys, or sweeping it finally out of the world" (§§13–14). Every literary representation of dispossession courts the first temptation, and a fantasy that transfigures the poor into a hidden marvellous people courts it more than most. But the novel's London Above, which sweeps its poor out of sight, is Ruskin's second and worse case, and the novel at least refuses to share its taste.

The genre to which Richard's descent belongs has a long and compromised history. Jack London opened *The People of the Abyss* (1903), whose first chapter is titled "The Descent," with the declaration: "I went down into the under-world of London with an attitude of mind which I may best liken to that of the explorer." Seth Koven's *Slumming* (2004) showed how the Victorian middle-class descent into the East End combined philanthropy, sociological curiosity, and erotic and aesthetic adventure, and how often the poor served as instruments of the visitor's self-transformation. Richard's story has the slumming narrative's shape. A man of the comfortable classes goes down among the poor, is changed, and returns; the dispossessed whom he meets are the occasions of his growth, and two of them die in the course of it.

The novel's transfigurations can be read in two ways. In London Below, the cold that kills those who sleep in the street becomes the Velvets, pale and beautiful, who drink the warmth of

the living; disappearance becomes the Night's Bridge; violent exploitation becomes Croup and Vandemar; mental illness becomes the Ordeal; hunger becomes the bustle of the market's food stalls. Read as picturesque, these transfigurations glamourize the dangers they name, converting want into wonder and the reader's pleasure into Ruskin's merciless temper. Read as allegory, they are prosopopoeias of real harms: the Velvets are the cold given a face, the bridge is the disappearance of the unrecorded given a place, and the monsters keep the shape of the dangers they transfigure. The novel stands at the junction of these readings and does not choose between them, with one significant exception. At the threshold of the undercity, in Anaesthesia's account of how she came to it, the harms appear without transfiguration, as a case history any social worker would recognize, and the marvel, the rats who find her, arrives only where the institutions have failed. Its strength is that its marvels never quite lose the outline of the harms; its limit is that the harms never quite lose their glamour. That is de Man's caution realized: the face conferred upon the poor is also a mask.

8.5

Gender and the threshold

The structural analysis of narrative has long observed that plot assigns movement and boundary by gender. Yuri Lotman's essay on the typological origins of plot (1973) reduced the mythic narrative to a sequence of entry into a closed space and emergence from it, performed by a mobile hero, and noted that the closed space, whether cave, grave, house, or woman, is interchangeable in its functions, so that entry into it may signify death, conception, or a return home. Teresa de Lauretis's "Desire in Narrative," in *Alice Doesn't* (1984), drew the feminist conclusion: narrative constructs its mythical subject as male, the one who crosses, and constructs the female as the boundary, the obstacle, and the space through which he moves. *Neverwhere* literalizes this grammar with Cratylan exactness. Its heroine is named Door. Richard crosses into London Below through a woman who is a threshold, and the plot is, at one level, the story of the powers that contend over the use of her.

The distribution of names confirms the pattern. The novel's men are free in their names. Richard's name is unmotivated and therefore open; it acquires meaning through his deeds, and even then it does not settle. Waking in the friars' abbey after the climax, he has for a moment no idea who he is and feels free to be anyone, a man or a woman, a rat or a bird, before remembering that he is Richard Mayhew, whatever that means (novel, ch. 19); and when the Earl knights him with Hunter's knife, it is as Sir Richard of Maybury, the same misremembering London Above had inflicted on him after his erasure (chs. 3, 19). His standing is conferred; his name remains unfixed. The Marquis named himself. Croup, Vandemar, and Old Bailey are agents whose names do not prescribe their acts. Islington, whom the narration calls "it," stands outside the distribution, and its name, a place, is as fixed as any in the book. The novel's women are bound

by theirs. Door is her function, Hunter her vocation, Anaesthesia her condition, Lamia her myth, Serpentine her shape, and the Seven Sisters a kinship term. The one woman whose name is merely conventional, Jessica, is the novel's figure of the conventional world and its moral antagonist. The women of London Below are bound to Cratylan names; the woman of London Above is condemned as Hermogenean; and the freedom to bear a name that does not dictate one's fate belongs to men.

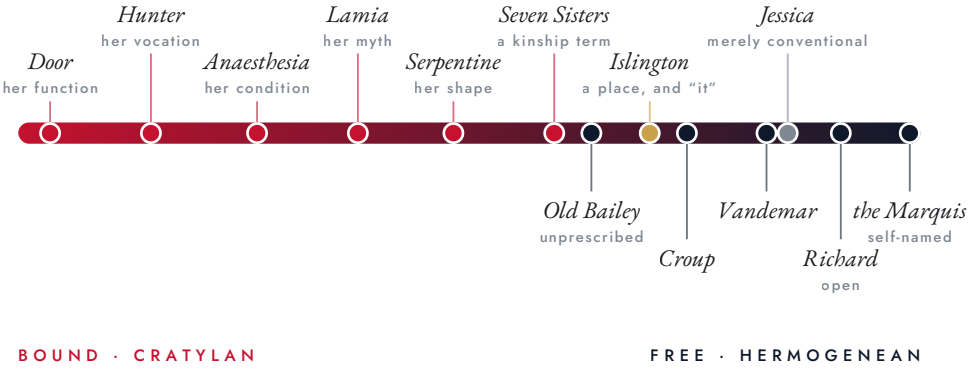


FIGURE 7 *The distribution of names: the women of London Below bound to Cratylan names, the men free in theirs, and Jessica, the one conventional name, condemned for it.*

The deaths complete the pattern, and the novel's remembrance of them confirms it. Anaesthesia dies advancing Richard's passage, Hunter advancing his initiation, and each leaves him a token that becomes an instrument of his story. The quartz bead that fell from Anaesthesia's necklace on the Night's Bridge recalls him from the death the Ordeal urges on him; the knife Hunter gives him as she dies is the tool with which, at the end, he cuts in London Above the outline of the door that opens. The dead women are honoured, and they are honoured as means. Hunter's betrayal is gendered in its terms as well: she is bought with a spear and pays for it with another woman, handing Door to the men who murdered Door's family. In 1999 Gail Simone, then a comics fan and later one of the medium's prominent writers, compiled a list of female characters killed, maimed, or otherwise harmed to propel male heroes' stories. She called it "Women in Refrigerators," after a 1994 issue of *Green Lantern*, written by Ron Marz, in which the villain Major Force murders the hero's girlfriend, Alexandra DeWitt, and leaves her body in a refrigerator for him to find. The phrase named a pattern in the medium in which Gaiman made his name. Hunter is the novel's Atalanta, as Chapter Four argued, but in Ovid Atalanta survives the hunt; Gaiman's huntress dies so that the man may make the kill, and does so by making herself

the bait. The novel grants her the dignity of choosing her death as amends, and it gives her a cortege: Serpentine, one of the Seven Sisters, comes into the labyrinth with her women to carry Hunter's body away and to take back the spear (novel, chs. 16, 18). The choice and the cortege qualify the pattern without dissolving it, since the amends are paid in the coin of a man's victory.

Against this structure the novel sets one decisive countermove, and it is not small. At the climax, the threshold acts, and it acts by guile as well as by gift. Door has foreseen the angel's demand and secretly commissioned a counterfeit of the key; with it she opens the door onto an elsewhere that swallows Islington and its two killers, and the door slams shut behind them. The decisive deed of the book is hers, performed against the angel who would use her, and it unites in one woman the offices of the hinge and the trick that Chapter Four distributed among several bearers. Ovid's Cardea, Chapter Four recalled, received power over the hinge as the price Janus paid for raping her, and exercised it thereafter by her own divinity, "numine ... suo"; Door's power is not payment from a violator but the inheritance of a house murdered on Islington's orders, and she turns it against the murderer. Milton's Sin opened Hell's gate for the fallen angel and could not shut it; Door's door closes on the angel. Vernant's polarity, in which the threshold belongs to the male Hermes and the hearth to the female Hestia, is overturned: the hinge is a girl, and the girl decides where the door leads. The novel also declines to marry its hero to its heroine, and so declines to make her the reward of his quest. Gaiman's Door is both the boundary of de Lauretis's critique and its partial refutation, a boundary that at the last chooses. The judgment the evidence supports is mixed: the novel's gender politics are progressive in its climax and conventional in its economy of sacrifice.

8.6

Reading after the allegations

The Prefatory Note records the allegations of sexual assault, abuse, and coercion made against Gaiman since 2024, his denial of all of them, and the dismissal of the related American lawsuits on jurisdictional grounds, without any ruling on their merits. Their bearing on this study must be stated precisely, because two opposite errors are available, and the novel's own terms describe both.

The first error treats the work as evidence. Much commentary after January 2025 returned to "Calliope," the seventeenth issue of *The Sandman* (1990), in which a novelist, Richard Madoc, holds the muse Calliope captive and rapes her to obtain his inspiration until Dream punishes him by flooding his mind with more ideas than he can write down, and some commentators read the story as a confession. The inference does not hold. A fiction that represents coercion as a crime and punishes it is evidence of nothing but its representation, and the same reasoning would convict every novelist who has imagined a murder. W. K. Wimsatt and Monroe C. Beardsley's "The Intentional Fallacy" (1946) and Roland Barthes's "La mort de l'auteur" (1967) gave

criticism its reasons for refusing to read texts through the biographies of their authors, and those reasons do not lapse when the biography becomes painful.

The second error treats the author's name as a verdict on the work, in either direction: as a guarantee of the fiction's innocence, or as a contamination of it. Michel Foucault's "Qu'est-ce qu'un auteur?" (1969) argued that an author's name is not simply a proper name. It performs a classificatory function, gathering texts together, regulating their circulation, and assigning them a mode of reception. Read through Chapter Two, Foucault's point acquires a Cratylan edge. In Mill's and Kripke's terms, Gaiman's name is a rigid designator that ought to refer without describing; since 2024 it has become heavy with description, so that it now prescribes how the texts are approached, adapted, published, and shelved, and the cancellations recorded in the Prefatory Note are that process in institutional form. The reception of the oeuvre has thus reproduced the structure this dissertation calls Cratylan, a name that binds its bearer, and his books, to a single reading. Criticism should no more submit to that cage than to the one section 8.2 found in London Below.

What the allegations change is not the text but the attention readers bring to it, and in that respect they sharpen arguments this chapter had already made on textual grounds. The novel's founding scene is a man taking a wounded young woman from the street into his home. The plaintiff in the American lawsuits alleged that she was homeless when she met Palmer and came to work in the couple's household, where, she alleged, Gaiman assaulted her. The proximity proves nothing about the novel or about the allegation, and this study draws no inference from it. But it makes it impossible to read the founding scene with the innocence the novel assumes, and it exposes a silence that was there all along. The Samaritan of Luke's parable does not take the wounded man into his own house. He "brought him to an inn, and took care of him," and on the morrow paid the host, saying, "Take care of him; and whatsoever thou spendest more, when I come again, I will repay thee" (10:34–35, AV). The parable's care passes through a third party, an institution of hospitality and payment, and so limits the dependence it creates. The novel stages exactly this choice and rejects the inn. Jessica, before her ultimatum, proposes that Richard call an ambulance without giving his name; the girl, opening her eyes, begs him not to take her to a hospital because they will find her there, and Richard carries her to his flat (novel, ch. 1). The novel never imagines what such dependence might make possible. Its rescue is innocent by fiat. Nor is the institution simply absent. Croup and Vandemar make their home in the cellars of a Victorian hospital closed by National Health Service cutbacks and abandoned by developers who had promised luxury flats (ch. 4), so that in the novel's London the inn has been shut and its cellars let to the killers, and Door's fear of the hospital is truer than she knows. That is a textual observation, and it joins the arguments of sections 8.3 to 8.5. The novel's personalism, which knows institutions only as ruins, cannot see the power the rescuer acquires; its economy of rescue makes the dispossessed the occasions of a man's growth; and its women, from the girl on the pavement to the huntress in the labyrinth, are the instruments of his passage.

The ethics this dissertation draws from the novel prescribes the stance the situation requires. Attention to the singular, in Weil's sense, means hearing the women's accounts as accounts, neither dismissed as noise nor converted by criticism into findings; it means recording the author's denial as his; and it means refusing to let the author's name, in either direction, do the work of reading. To mind the gap here is to keep open the interval between allegation and judgment, which belongs to processes that criticism cannot replace, while refusing the anaesthesia that would look and pass.

8 . 7

The problem of Jessica

Every limit traced in this chapter converges on Jessica. Chapter Three identified her prototype in Baudelaire's beloved, who could not bear the eyes of the poor at the café window and asked that they be sent away. In the novel she embodies London Above's anaesthesia: anxious about dinner with her employer, impatient with the bleeding girl, and quick to make her engagement conditional on Richard's walking on. Yet the novel gives her more than it seems to. Her first answer to the bleeding girl is not to walk on but to call an ambulance, the institutional answer the Samaritan's inn represents, if an anonymous one; she organizes the exhibition through which the angel is reached; and the only time the novel shows her compassionate, weeping for Richard and moving him to want to take her pain away, is in the Ordeal, where she is a figure of his own mind and says so (novel, chs. 1, 9, 12). Her compassion exists in the book only as Richard's projection. When she returns in the last chapter, he declines her. The novel's moral geography requires a figure for the official city's indifference, and it chooses a fiancée.

The choice has a lineage. Washington Irving's "Rip Van Winkle" (1819) sends its hero into the Catskills to escape a scolding wife; he sleeps for twenty years and returns to find himself unrecognized, crying "I'm not myself—I'm somebody else," and confessing that he can no longer tell "what's my name, or who I am!" The bystanders look at one another and "tap their fingers against their foreheads": the man who returns from another world is taken for mad, as Richard is in the Ordeal. He also finds that his wife is dead and that he is free. Leslie Fiedler's *Love and Death in the American Novel* (1960) read Rip as the prototype of a literature whose heroes flee women, marriage, and domestic civilization into a wilderness of male companionship. Richard's erasure repeats Rip's unrecognized return, and his escape, like Rip's, is an escape from a woman who stands for the domestic order. The fantasy of departure to another world is here, as often, also a fantasy of departure from a fiancée.

The problem is not only one of gender. The novel's moral dualism, the opposition between those who perceive London Below and those who cannot, risks the very contempt it condemns. Chapter Six read Islington as a Gnostic angel, contemptuous of the lower world and impatient for release; but the novel's own anthropology is Gnostic in another register, dividing humanity

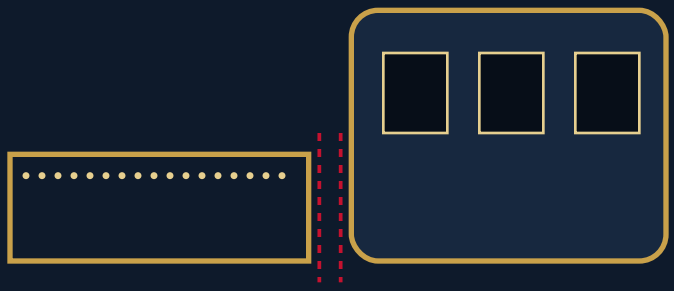
into the seeing elect and the blind multitude. Wells's "The Country of the Blind" knew the danger. Nunez entered the valley expecting to rule its inhabitants because he could see, and the story leaves open whether the poverty of their world exceeds the arrogance of his. *Neverwhere* grants London Above no comparable ambiguity. Its inhabitants are given little interior life: even Gary, who follows Richard into the street and suggests that he see someone, speaks only the city's creed, and Jessica's reasons, whether ambition, fear, exhaustion, or the ordinary pressures of a life arranged around obligations, are never attended to.

Here the novel's ethics can be turned upon the novel. Weil's question, which Chapter Three placed at the centre of the novel's moral vision, is the question one asks of a sufferer: what are you going through? The novel never asks it of Jessica. It perceives her as a specimen of a category, the conventional world, which is exactly the categorical perception that Weil, Wordsworth, and the novel itself identified as the essence of anaesthesia. The city of attention fails to attend to the woman who did not stop. Jessica is the remainder of *Neverwhere*'s own order, the one figure its distribution of the sensible renders invisible, and to notice her is to mind the gap in the novel itself. That is the most faithful use of its ethics, and the conclusion that follows attempts to state that ethics in a form that would include her.

"

To notice her is to mind the gap in the novel itself.

CONCLUSION



MIND THE GAP

Minding the Gap

Ω CONCLUSION

Minding the Gap

Toward a Prosopopoeic Ethics of the Interstice

The apparently miscellaneous furniture of *Neverwhere* forms a single design. A Cratylan undercity lies beneath a Hermogenean metropolis; the dispersed offices of Hermes hold it together; and an ethics of attention to what falls between categories governs it. This conclusion restates the argument, names the rhetoric of fantasy it implies, and formulates the imperative it entails.

C.1

The argument restated

The dissertation has read *Neverwhere* as a fable about the economy of the sign. Its semiotic thesis, developed in Chapter Two, is that London Above is a regime of effaced reference, in which names have become labels and the descriptions they once carried lie buried in a toponymic necropolis, while London Below re-motivates those names by four modes, restorative, paronomastic, personifying, and emblematic, which share a single operation: prosopopoeia, the conferral of face and address on what usage has defaced. Its perceptual thesis, developed in Chapter Three, is that the invisibility of London Below is not optical but political, a distribution of the sensible maintained by the blasé indifference that Simmel diagnosed in the money economy and that the novel names in its first guide, Anaesthesia; against it the novel sets an ethics of attention descended from the Good Samaritan, Wordsworth, Weil, and Levinas.

Its mythological thesis, developed in Chapters Four and Five, is that London Below is a hermetic polity, a community constituted by the dispersed offices of the god whose herms Athens defaced: the hinge in Door, the trick in the Marquis, guidance in the novel's many guides, the contest in Hunter, and exchange in the Floating Market, whose truce, favours, and re-motivated goods form an economy of the remainder opposed to the *usure* of the official city. Its theological thesis, developed in Chapter Six, is that the Angel Islington embodies a strong messianism of

total restitution, and that Door's opening of the door onto an unreachable elsewhere enacts the weak messianism of the small door, a messianicity without messianism that keeps the gap open. Its initiatory thesis, developed in Chapter Seven, is that Richard's story is an inverted katabasis, entered by pity, completed in the blood of a beast, and resolved by a return that discovers the world above to be the cave. Chapter Eight traced the costs: nominal determinism, romantic hierarchy, the lower picturesque, a gendered economy of names and sacrifices, and the novel's failure to attend to the woman who did not stop; and it set out what the allegations made against Gaiman since 2024 change in the novel's reception, and what they do not.

C . 2

A Cratylan rhetoric of fantasy

Farah Mendlesohn's *Rhetorics of Fantasy* (2008) classified fantasies by the relation between reader and fantastic: the portal-quest fantasy, which leads its protagonist and reader from the known world into the fantastic; the immersive fantasy, which presents the fantastic as a given world; the intrusive fantasy, in which the fantastic breaks into the known world; and the liminal fantasy, in which the fantastic hovers at the edge of perception, with a residual category for irregular cases. *Neverwhere* would most naturally be placed among the portal-quest fantasies. Its distinctive operation, however, is not the portal but the pun. Its fantastic is generated by language, and the reader's estrangement is semiotic before it is spatial: the reader is led not only through a door into another world but back into the words of this one.

The observation that the fantastic can arise from language is not new, and its genealogy must be acknowledged. Tzvetan Todorov's *Introduction à la littérature fantastique* (1970) argued that the supernatural frequently originates in the literal reading of a figurative expression, and Samuel R. Delany's essay "About 5,750 Words" (first version 1969; revised 1977) located the defining protocol of science fiction in its licence to read figurative sentences literally. Rosemary Jackson's *Fantasy: The Literature of Subversion* (1981) described fantasy as the literature of what a culture renders invisible, occupying a "paraxial" region alongside the real. John Clute's grammar of fantasy in *The Encyclopedia of Fantasy* (1997) traced the genre's characteristic story through wrongness, thinning, and recognition to a return, and named the hidden communities that live in the interstices of a dominant world *wainscot* societies, the tradition of the Borrowers and the Wombles to which Chapter One assigned part of the novel's ancestry. *Neverwhere* fits each description: London Above is Clute's thinned world, London Below his wainscot, and the novel's recognitions are etymological.

The present study extends these accounts in three directions and names the result a *Cratylan rhetoric of fantasy*. First, it extends Todorov's observation from figures of speech to proper names, the class of sign that Mill held to have no meaning at all and therefore the class whose literalization is most surprising. Second, it grounds the operation not in the reader's hesitation, as

Todorov did, but in the history of motivation traced from Plato through Saussure to Genette: the Cratylan rhetoric re-motivates signs that convention and sound change have rendered arbitrary. Third, it connects the rhetoric to an ethics, since the re-motivation of a sign is a prosopopoeia, prosopopoeia confers address, and address founds obligation.

A Cratylan fantasy may be recognized by four marks. Its marvels are lexically derivable: they can be deduced from the language of its world, as the Night's Bridge can be deduced from Knightsbridge. Its recognitions are etymological: its revelations are discoveries of what words once meant or can be made to mean. Its characteristic moral act is prosopopoeic: the conferral of face and voice on what had merely been referred to. And its characteristic danger is nominal determinism, the binding of beings to the names that disclose them. Its governing paradox is that the world grows marvellous precisely in proportion as it grows literal. The lineage is distinguished. Carroll's Mock Turtle belongs to it, as do Chesterton's Notting Hill, Terry Pratchett's *Small Gods* (1992), in which a god's power is proportional to the number of those who believe in him, and Miéville's punning abcity. So does Gaiman's later work. *American Gods* (2001) literalizes the idiom of believing in, so that gods live and starve on belief; *The Graveyard Book* (2008) names its hero Nobody, the name with which Odysseus once deceived the Cyclops ("Οὖτις ἐμοί γ' ὄνομα," Nobody is my name, *Odyssey* IX.366), and teaches him to Fade, to pass unnoticed among the living. Anaesthesia's condition has become a skill, and the Cratylan rhetoric of *Neverwhere* has become the signature of an oeuvre.

C . 3

The categorical imperative of the interstice

The ethics the novel implies can be stated with a precision the novel does not attempt. Kant's *Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten* (1785) provides the form. Its fourth example of a duty is the case of a prosperous man who sees others struggling with great hardship, whom he could help, and asks "was geht's mich an?", what concern is it of mine? Such a maxim, Kant argued, could exist as a universal law of nature, but no one could will it as one, since a will that so resolved would conflict with itself in the cases, which may always arise, in which it would need the love and sympathy of others (4:423). Kant's second formula commands that humanity, in one's own person and in the person of every other, be treated always also as an end and never merely as a means (4:429), and his kingdom of ends distinguishes what has a price from what has a dignity: "Was einen Preis hat, an dessen Stelle kann auch etwas anderes, als Äquivalent, gesetzt werden; was dagegen über allen Preis erhaben ist, mithin kein Äquivalent verstattet, das hat eine Würde" (4:434). What has a price can be replaced by an equivalent; what is raised above all price, and admits no equivalent, has a dignity.

The Hermogenean metropolis is a realm of prices, in which names, values, and persons are fungible tokens. The Cratylan undercity, for all its cruelties, is a realm in which persons and

things bear faces, and faces admit no equivalent. Levinas objected to Kant that the face of the other precedes and exceeds every universal law; the novel suggests that the objection and the law can be held together, in a universal imperative whose content is attention to the singular. This dissertation names that imperative the *categorical imperative of the interstice* and proposes three formulations of it, corresponding to Kant's three.

The first is the formula of universal attention: act only on a maxim of perception that you could will every passer-by to adopt towards you when you have fallen. Virgil's *guarda e passa*, Jessica's injunction to walk on, and Kant's "was geht's mich an?" fail the test together, since no one who has lain bleeding on a pavement could will that every passer-by look and pass.

The second is the formula of the face: treat every remainder of the order you inhabit, the unnamed, the misnamed, the discarded, and the unseen, never merely as waste but always also as a possible face, that is, as one who may address you and to whom you may be answerable. The formula carries the operation of prosopopoeic re-motivation from rhetoric into conduct. It applies to Door on the pavement, to the rats and their speakers, to the stock of the Floating Market, and, as Chapter Eight insisted, to Jessica.

The third is the formula of the threshold: act as a member of a polity of passage, keeping open the thresholds through which the excluded may enter and the included may leave, and refuse every programme that would close the gap in the name of a final settlement. It condemns Islington's strong messianism, the Hermogenean city's police of the sensible, and the Cratylan city's cage of names alike, since each closes a threshold, and it takes Door's opening without arrival as the model of political hope.

The three formulations are prosopopoeic, because they confer face; interstitial, because their object is what falls between categories; and weakly messianic, because they require no end of history for their fulfilment, only the next act of attention. They restate in the form of a law what Calvino's Marco Polo described as the second and harder way of living in the inferno, the patient discernment of what within it does not belong to it and the work of making room for that to last; what Weil called attention; and what Benjamin found in every second of time, the small door.

C . 4

Mind the gap

The phrase from which this dissertation takes its title entered the London Underground's recorded announcements at the end of the 1960s, when the sound engineer Peter Lodge recorded it in 1968 or 1969 (Martin 2003). The gap it warns against is literal. It opens wherever a straight carriage halts at a curved platform, as at several of the oldest stations on the network, and it is produced by the incompatibility of two geometries. It cannot be eliminated without rebuilding one system to fit the other; it can only be minded. London Above and London Below are such geo-

metries. Islington's error was to suppose that the gap between them could be closed by force. The novel's wisdom is that it must be minded instead.

The verb rewards a Cratylan reading of the kind the novel teaches. To *mind* is to heed, as one minds one's step. It is to take care of, as one minds a child or a house. It is to object, as when one asks whether another minds, which is to ask whether he refuses to be indifferent. And in the Scots of Richard Mayhew's birthplace, to *mind* is to remember: "I mind it well." The fourfold sense of the injunction recapitulates this study. Minding as heeding is the attention of Chapter Three; minding as caring is the economy of favour and obligation of Chapter Five; minding as objecting is the refusal of total settlement in Chapter Six and the critique of Chapter Eight; minding as remembering is the anamnesis of names in Chapter Two and the claim of the past on the weak messianic power. To mind the gap, in the fullness of its sense, is to attend to what has fallen, to care for it, to refuse indifference to it, and to remember it.

> "
>
> *Islington's error was to suppose that the gap between them could be closed by force.*



FIGURE 8 *Mind the gap: the injunction's four senses, and the chapters in which each is worked out (section C.4).*

The herms of Athens lost their faces in a single night of 415 BCE. *Neverwhere* imagines a city in which faces are given back one at a time, a name, a stranger, a door, and it asks of its readers only

what the Underground asks of every passenger at every curved platform in London, construed at last in the fullness of its meaning: mind the gap.



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